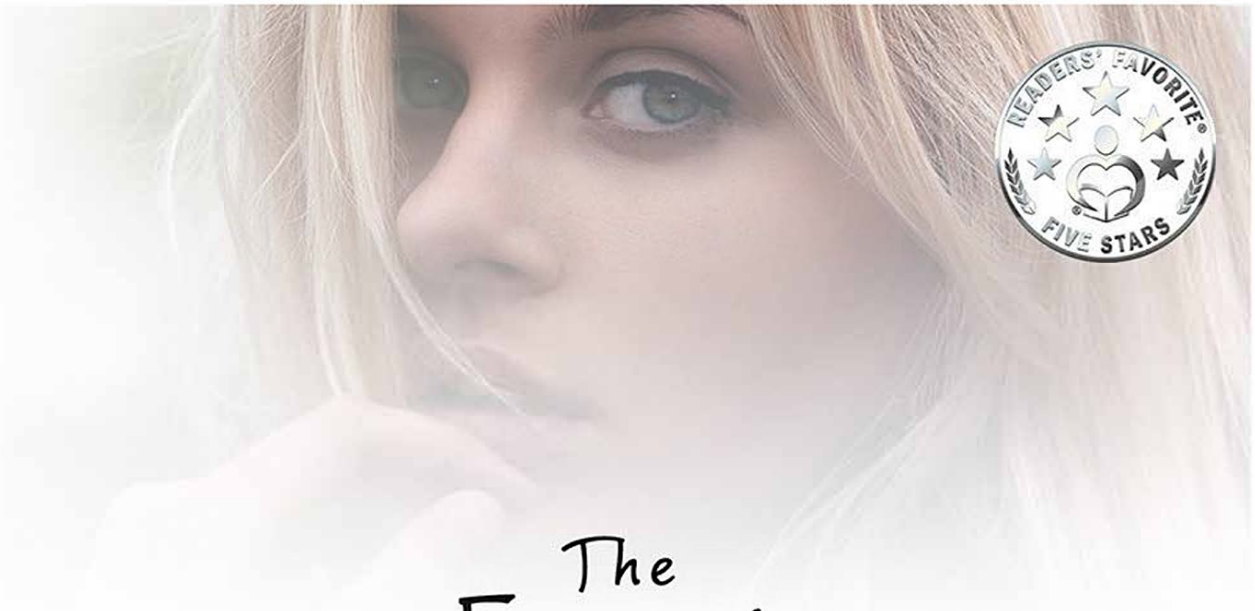
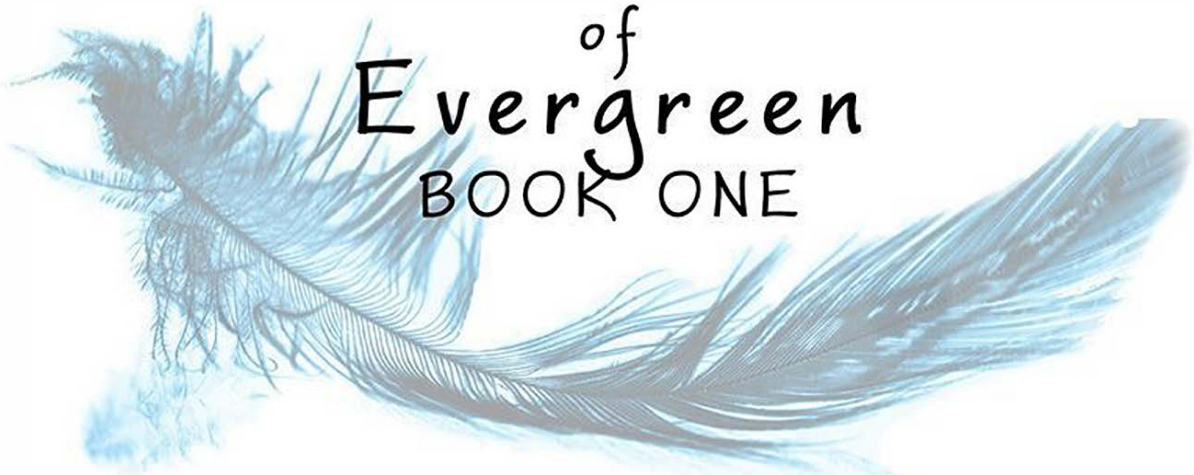




The Forest of Evergreen
BOOK ONE

LOST in the WILDERNESS

"...a beautiful story that will leave readers aching for more."
— READERS' FAVORITE, (Kentucky, USA)

TERESA MAY B. BANDIOLA

This is an authorized free edition from www.obooko.com

This is an authorized free digital edition for registered members of obooko. Although you do not have to pay for this e-book, the author's intellectual property rights remain fully protected by international Copyright law. You are licensed to use this digital copy strictly for your personal enjoyment only. This edition must not be hosted or redistributed on other websites nor offered for sale in any form. If you paid for this free edition, or to gain access to it, we suggest you demand an immediate refund and report the transaction to the author.

Praise for **Lost in the Wilderness**

FROM READERS' FAVORITE®

"The Forest of Evergreen is brilliantly written, in a blending of young adult coming of age with fantasy that will have readers anticipating the next installment."

"It is an exciting teenage fiction fantasy story with a main character whose inner struggle to put her past to rest and find a sense of belonging with her family will tug at your heart."

"The narration is detailed and descriptive, making the book very visual and clear."

"The book is original."

"Teresa Bandiola does a superb job of telling the history of the Pacific island nation of the Great Archipelago of Philipdomia. She was able to explicitly describe all of the characters' emotional turmoil, especially Sophia's, as well as the wonder of her laying eyes on paradise."

"I believe this is a great story that can help readers to get away from the day-to-day complexities of life and be transported to another world."

"The Forest of Evergreen is a beautiful story."

"The book had a unique plot filled with layer upon layer of more exciting developments."

"It takes readers on a whimsical journey through the Evergreen Forest."

"The characters are portrayed well, especially the character of Sophie, which has many shades and layers to it."

"The twists and turns in the plot keep readers glued to the story as it progresses."

"What made Sophia a very intriguing and interesting character was how the author combined the usual teenage traits with something deeper and more gripping in her spirit. Her sombre personality fitted in very well with the theme of the story."

"Sophie's pain, grief, and loss after the accident is palpable and readers actually feel sorry as her memory is lost."

"The calm depiction of the Evergreen Forest provided a serene setting for the story, and the use of unique terms made the story feel more surreal, intriguing, and fun."

"As the author weaves back and forth between the human and fantasy aspect, it allows the readers to begin to visualize the essence of the story."

"It is a magical story that will take readers on an adventurous journey filled with love and fantasy."

"I enjoyed the whimsical plot."

"I enjoyed the story thoroughly."

"I did like her character (Sophia) and would like to see where else she goes in other books."

"The open ending will make readers wait eagerly for the next volume to learn more about the characters and their journey."

"If you like romance and fantasy, pick up a copy of The Forest of Evergreen: Lost in the Wilderness by Teresa May B. Bandiola."

The
Forest
of
Evergreen

BOOK ONE

LOST in the WILDERNESS

TERESA MAY B. BANDIOLA

All of the characters, places, and incidents in this book are fictitious. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, business establishments, events, or locales is entirely coincidental and not intended by the author.

Copyright © 2014 by Teresa May B. Bandiola

Appendix B Illustrations by Phil Dominic B. Bandiola

Map by Teresa May B. Bandiola

Cover Design by Tania Arpa

All rights reserved.

ISBN: 1511580070

ISBN-13: 978-1511580076

No part of this book may be reproduced or transmitted in any form or by any means without permission of the copyright owner, except in the case of brief quotations embodied in critical articles and reviews.

Purchase only authorized editions.

Table of Contents

Acknowledgements

Author's Note

Dedication

Map

Prologue
The Great Archipelago of Philipdomia and the Vangkekans

1
The Vabuerettis

2
The Prom Night

3
A Visit to Forest Green

4
Treasured Memoirs and the First Encounter .

5
The Resemblance

6
The Return of the Past

7
Forget Me Not

8
The Melodies of Yesterdays

9
The Battle of Kravena

10
The Night

11
The Cry of Hearts

12
The Sun Still Rises

13
Cocoon

14
The Awakening

15
The Blood Compact

16
Unbending

17
The Visit

18
The Artist in Her

19
Remember Me

20
Your Song, Our Song

21
Through It All

22
Always One Step Behind Your Silhouette

23
Hold On

24
Come What May

25
The Miracle Plants

26
Struck With His Eyes

27
Confuse Me Not

Epilogue
Leaving the Fate Behind

Appendix A
Definition of Terms

Appendix B
Illustrations

About the Author

Acknowledgements

For the most part of everything, I thank You, Almighty Father, for giving me the wisdom and enthusiasm to finish the story. Lord, You placed me in a family filled with love and talents that turned me into someone who I am today. You are my Light in the darkness, my Everything. Thank You for giving Your only begotten Son to save us all, and for that, all humankind is eternally grateful. All glory, honor, and power are Yours, Lord, forever and ever!

My wonderful parents, Buddy and Tessie—for your endless love and support. This book is my form of apology and unfailing love for you. You guys, are the best! I love you!

My handsome and cool brothers, Paul John and Dominic—for surrounding me with your everlasting love, support, and protection. I always feel like a princess everytime you are around. I love you, guys!

My sister-in-law Michelle—for being always there for my brother and our family.

All my relatives especially Aunt Grace and Jeslen Tesoro—for your encouragement, ideas, and support. Hugs and kisses I offer you!

Uncle Melchor Bangaoil and Aunt Letty Bangaoil—for always receiving me everytime I needed a shelter.

My comical editor Ma. Evelyn Diaz Vergara—for your excellent suggestions, wit, and patience so as to improve the storyline. You have enriched this book beyond anything I could ever conceive. You are the best editor an author could ever have, and because of that, I will forever be thankful. I hope other people could see how much of an asset you are. God bless you in every way.

Layla Amar and Tania Arpa—for your expertise and brilliant efforts that got this whole thing off the ground.

My best friends, Glaiza Ignacio and Lynie Alilis-Saboy—for always being there for me. You never fail to understand and support me. I'm glad I have met people like you. You are a drop in the ocean. I love you, mi amigas!

My godmother Gloria Illustre-Bayeng—for being the best godmother who I'm very sure is even better than Cinderella's. You're always there for me since I was born. You never fail to show me your love. I wish you and Kuya Manny endless love and happiness.

My godson Justin—for being a part of my life, as I am to yours.

Ma'am Maritess Abad and Kuya Nani Abad—for helping me find the Way, when I was lost and naive. God bless and strengthen you more!

Ma'am April Lingat—for giving me a notebook that pushed me to grab a pen and write down a story, which is now this. I could never find the right words to express my deepest gratitude to you. I love you, girl.

Ailu Sitti Lucman—for being a big sister to me. The sisterhood we share is exceptional and priceless. I love you, sister.

Ma'am Imma Navarro—for having the interest to read the first chapter of this book and because of that, you are the first person to take a glance at it.

My big bosses, Dean Olive M. de Vera and Ma'am Juneve F. Tejada—for always understanding me and giving me countless chances, in spite of my shortcomings. (Laughs)

Lastly, all my former and current students and co-faculty members at the College of Pharmacy of Our Lady of Fatima University—for helping me grow as a person and making me feel loved and valued.

I love you all! Cheers!

Dear Reader:

Some of the places in the story, particularly the mythical country I used, do not actually exist. They are all products of my imagination. Since the aforementioned country I created is found in the Pacific Ocean near the equator, the seasons are the same as those in tropical countries where only dry and rainy seasons occur.

The characters' surnames and some of the terminologies used were also created by me, though they may sound strangely familiar to you.

I sincerely hope you will enjoy reading this book as much as I enjoyed researching, and writing it.

Happy reading,

T.M.B. Bandiola

In memory of my brother

SALVADOR “JAY-JAY” B. BANDIOLA III

SEPTEMBER 9, 1983 - SEPTEMBER 1, 2003

and

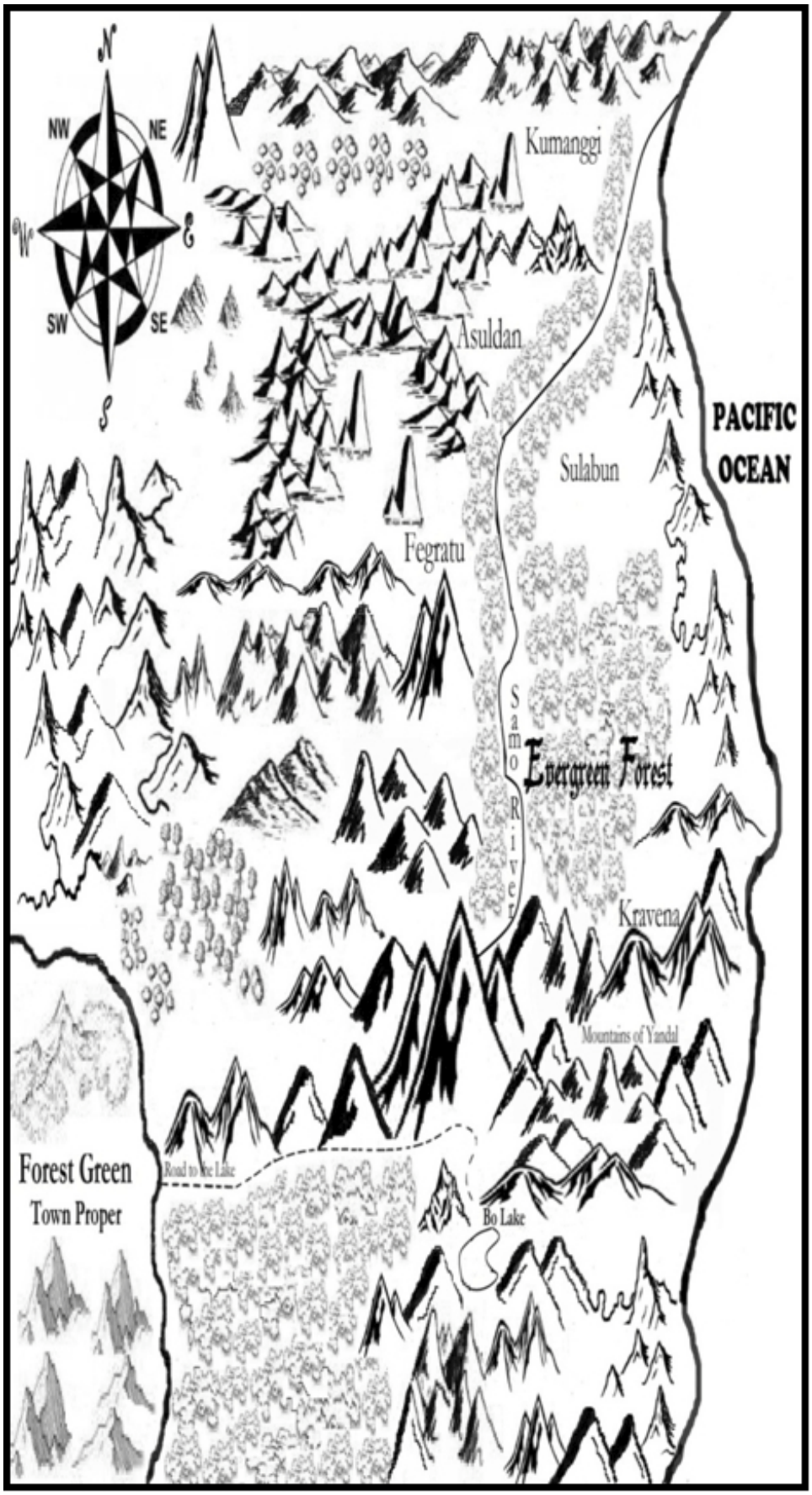
my grandmother

DR. ROSITA “INSING” Q. BANGAOIL

JUNE 30, 1939 - OCTOBER 5, 2013

Three things will last forever—faith, hope, and love—and the greatest of these is love.

- 1 Corinthians 13: 13 NLT


N
NW
NE
W
E
SW
SE
S
Kumanggi
Asuldan
Fegratu
Sulabun
PACIFIC
OCEAN
Samo River
Evergreen Forest
Kravena
Mountains of Yandal
Forest Green
Town Proper
Road to the Lake
Bo Lake

Prologue

The Great Archipelago of Philipdomia and the Vangkekans

IN the North Pacific Ocean, between Guam and Hawaii, there lies a prosperous and powerful democratic country known as the Great Archipelago of Philipdomia. The archipelago is made up of four major islands known as Eser, Mindo, Palulu, and Sador. Several atolls, numerous smaller islets, and undersea seamounts also compose the country, which all contribute to its world famous beauty and richness. Its capital city is Orlando while its most populous city is Isset, both situated at Sador, the largest major island followed by Eser, Mindo, and Palulu.

The Great Archipelago of Philipdomia's tropical splendor includes colorful plant life, beautiful beaches and waterfalls, and extinct volcanoes. The cool Pacific winds keep the archipelago pleasantly mild all year around making the country a perfect tourist destination and the ultimate surfing spot.

For more than three centuries, Philipdomia was controlled by Spain when King Charles I (also known as Charles V of the Holy Roman Empire) sent explorers to sail the Pacific to establish a permanent foothold in the East Indies, which was near the Line of Demarcation between Spain and Portugal under the Treaty of Zaragoza in 1529.

Similar to the Philippines, Ruy López de Villalobos gave Philipdomia its name, after calling the four islands Nueva Islas Filipinas (while Las Islas Filipinas was used for the Philippines) in honor of Philip, the Prince of Asturias at the time, who later became Philip II of Spain. The country ultimately changed its name to Philipdomia after adjoining *Domia*, the name of the native chief who killed the earliest set of Spanish invaders.

It has been said, although no historical record as to its veracity exists, that the country was originally discovered in 1521 by Ferdinand Magellan, a Portuguese explorer under the sovereignty of Spain in search of a westward route to Moluccas or the "Spice Islands," before he reached the Philippines and was killed in the Battle of Mactan.

The islands, primarily Sador, were important stopovers for the Spanish Manila Galleons that crossed the Pacific until the Mexican War of Independence ended Spanish access to Mexican ports. No records in the archives, however, confirm this. Akin to Fort Nuestra Señora de la Soledad in Umatac, Guam, the Spaniards built a number of garrisons such as Fort Aquilina to guard these Pacific fleets. These forts are still standing today and considered to be one of Philipdomia's main tourist attractions.

The archipelago was a site for exile, for the revolutionists under the Spanish Crown in the Philippines, including Cuban revolutionists, during the Little War from 1879 to 1880. Filipino deportation here was extended until 1901

following the Philippine-American War. But unknown to the world, it was also here where some Puerto Ricans who protested against the American territorial acquisition of Puerto Rico were deported.

The year 1898 marks the end of the lengthy and vicious Spanish rule in Philipdomia, when it was surrendered to the United States of America during the Spanish-American War and later formally ceded as part of the Treaty of Paris. But during World War II, it was captured by the Japanese, the day after the attack on Pearl Harbor. After the Hiroshima and Nagasaki atomic bombing, the archipelago was subjected to fierce fighting with the help of the American troops.

Identical to the Philippines, the country was offered by the United States of America to be one of its states but Sebastian Ignacio, then the country's leader, declined.

Today, the Great Archipelago of Philipdomia is one of the first-world and English-speaking countries in the Pacific Ocean that is not under the US territory, having oil industry and glorious tourism as its major sources of income.

Five hundred kilometers north of Orlando City is the Province of Orstia. In Orstia, a remote town known as Forest Green is renowned for its remarkably rich Spanish heritage.

However, by the mountainous northeast of Forest Green, there is a mystic wilderness called the forbidden Forest of Evergreen. The people, at one point in the distant past, believed that creatures of utmost peculiarity existed there. They have heard of the stories from their forefathers, stories of terrifying deeds and darkness. But as the lengthy years went by, such stories became mere folktales and went unheeded as time embraced modernity, and such anecdotes are, by now, deemed of no account.

There in the vastness and thickness of the dark forest was the world of the Vangkekans.

The Vangkekans were outlandish creatures, fractioned into five tribes: the Kravena, the Fegratu, the Sulabun, the Asuldan, and the Kumanggi.

The Kravenas were distinguished by their gigantic and bright feathered wings; the Fegratus, their lustrous and reddish wings; the Sulabuns, their frail yet fear-provoking dusky ones; the Asuldans, their serene olive greens; and the Kumanggis, their velvety browns.

The Kravena Tribe was the realm of Datu Ilak. The Kravenas lived in the foothills of Yandal near the Pacific Ocean, and to their west is the deep River of Samo that passes through the other tribes and ends as estuary. North of the tribe lies the magnificent Falls of Harem.

Farther north was the Sulabun Tribe, led by Datu Karok. They had smaller wings than the Kravenas and they preferred to dwell in flat lands rather than highlands.

Across the Samo River was the Fegratu Tribe, headed by Datu Saak. They were smaller ones but fast and vigilant. They lingered by the banks of the river, and fishing became their primary source of food.

Not too distant from the Fegratus was the Asuldan Tribe, ruled by Datu Intal. The Asuldans were friendly Vangkekans and were fond of hunting wild animals. Their wings had the same size as the Sulabuns but appeared to be much weaker. They were lovers of woodlands and they preferred to live in the highlands.

Right next to the Asuldan was the Kumanggi Tribe, guided by Datu Uliman. The Kumanggis had the smallest size of wings but they were the tallest Vangkekans. They were lovers of trees and woodlands, and the hillsides became their habitation.

The Vangkekans were, once, immortals. However, it was discovered that they could be killed by the strike of an arrow dipped in the hot spring secreted by the Mountains of Yandal. But only those who were brave enough could go through it. At the other side of the Yandal Mountains lies the magical Falls of Ovaweh in which water served as the antidote for the deadly arrows.

The Vangkekans' immortality vanished when the Ovaweh Falls ran out of water.

To represent ideas and sounds, the Vangkekans used picture symbols. Primarily, they used stone monuments but sometimes, banana leaves were used as writing sheets and permanent plant pigments as ink. The inscriptions were written or carved by highly trained ones called suratos, but as time passed by, every Vangkekan learned to write and read them.

The male Vangkekans wore wide and thick breechclothes, or wang-gis. These were made from flayed tree bark, brown in color with red ocher, but some were woven of cotton thread by the female Vangkekans. Likewise, the male Vangkekans were topless to reveal their masculine bodies.

On the other hand, the female Vangkekans wore bark-fiber skirts called kul-pas, which were worn after putting on a tight girdle. Their skirts were also brownish but with red stripes down each side and through the middle. Their skirts were extended from below the navel to near the knees which opened on the sides, and were frequently so scant and narrow that one leg was exposed when walking. As well, a series of woven bands of about five inches wide—passing through beneath their wings at the back—were wrapped around their bodies to cover their breasts.

To make a distinction between themselves and an ordinary Vangkekan, the five tribe datus wore a basket-work hat known as sukdalang. It was worn on the back of the head that was held in place by a cord attached at both sides and passing across the forehead. More prominently, the spearheads had tattoos on their upper left arms based on the heavenly body that first fascinated them: the bright sun for Datu Ilak, the twinkling star for Datu Saak, the half-moon for Datu Karok, the C-shaped moon for Datu Intal, and the full moon for Datu Uliman.

When it came to hair, male Vangkekans only possessed a hair cut just above their ears. It was indecent for them to have a long one. But for the females, long hair was necessary.

The five Vangkekan tribes co-existed peacefully until the Battle of Yandal was fought when the Kravena Tribe went to war. It was all started by the ambitious Banaak.

Banaak was the sagigilid of the Kravena Tribe and was responsible for the tribe's protection against the wild animals and any other forms of peril in the forest. He was renowned for his remarkable skills in fighting. For many years, he won the tribe's pasindol, which was the tribe's annual tourney to spot the most excellent male Kravena in archery. Secretly, however, he began to covet the throne.

One sun-drenched afternoon, the Kravenas were engaged in a battle against human beings who were heading for the mountain sides in search of indigenous and exotic medicinal plants flourishing abundantly at the heart of the Yandal Mountains.

The Kravenas, ever protective of their territory, attacked them. The men had guns and explosives that injured many Kravenas yet none of these humans survived, for Banaak was exceptionally fearless and speedy, and so were his

warriors. After the blood-spattered fight, Banaak then proudly proclaimed his victory to the tribe and offered himself to be the new chief, as he had fully shown his ability to safeguard the tribe against the new invaders, whom he claimed as death-defying ones.

The Kravenas, although alarmed by the raiders' coming, remained loyal to Datu Ilak. Some Kravenas, however, were persuaded by Banaak and their loyalty shifted to him.

Banaak's ceaseless desire to sit on the throne led him to plan the slaying of Datu Ilak but it was impossible for him to do so for he did not know how. However, by surreptitiously reading Datu Ilak's writings, he learned of the one thing that scared every Vangkekan—the secreted hot spring. At the very moment of discovering it, he then turned his attention to knowing where it was found. Slowly, his mind succumbed to evil plans.

Datu Ilak who sensed some naughty plans in Banaak never gave up on him. He still entrusted Banaak's position to him with all the optimism that Banaak would soon realize his mistakes.

But nothing stopped Banaak from putting his plans into action. On the sly, he began to plot. As he had not yet learned the whereabouts of the secreted hot spring and absolutely had no idea how to find it, he thought of an alternative plan—to destroy the trust of the Kravenas in Datu Ilak, and steal their allegiance.

Banaak wooed Kaya, who was then the datu's closest female servant, or hakara. He gained her trust and loyalty and then enticed her to try to sleep with the datu. Kaya, unknowing of the other dark plans of Banaak, agreed, for Banaak promised to unite with her after he seized the throne.

One fine night, the Kravenas were celebrating their bountiful harvest of sinapoy, their staple food, a form of grain which was boiled along with various aromatic leaves, to enhance its flavor.

As the tribe's head, Datu Ilak thanked the mang-aanis for their plentiful harvest and encouraged them to further hone their agricultural skills. Banaak was there, sitting near the table of the female servants.

At the celebration, a group of musicians known as bandoryon melodically blew plutas and drummed tambulings while the dance troupe called taga-sumalas gracefully danced—enchanting every Kravena's eyes. All over, no feet ignored the dancing grounds; no lips shunned the stacks of perfectly fermented lapey (a liquor prepared from coconut); and no social status prevented them from freely mingling.

Worthwhile the night was, for the Kravenas to take pleasure in!

When the festivity finally came to an end, every Kravena went home to his kubot while Datu Ilak stayed in the palasyon with his servants. He was about to rest when Kaya came softly and offered herself in the most seductive way.

Banaak, with the bunjaos and kansilos, forcibly entered the datu's chamber and saw the two. Such an act of an unmarried couple was forbidden by the laws of Kravena, especially regarding the datu. Banaak then swayed the kansilos, saying it was great disrespect and shame to the tribe.

Pretending he did not know the hakara, Banaak ordered the bunjaos to get rid of her. The then-inebriated datu explained that he did not know what he was doing. Dividing, the kansilos went into a disagreement as to whether, to dethrone Datu Ilak for his misdeed or not.

The next morning, the Kravenas woke up to a disturbing news: that the datu's reign was already in dispute. On account of this unsettling situation, Datu Ilak made a public act of contrition. He humbly and openly apologized to the tribe and proclaimed that he was going to join the hakara in matrimony. He begged for the tribe's pardon and

pleaded for his dominion, pointing out that he was to have, now, a family. Some kansilos, touched by Datu Ilak's meek and sincere apology, agreed, but some objected to it. Banaak and his followers loudly protested but the kansilos finally decided to forgive the datu and let him continue his rule.

Datu Ilak ordered the taga-siklaw to find out the ones behind his disgrace. Moreover, he persuaded Kaya to reveal who ordered her to destroy him.

Kaya, sobbing and desperately ashamed of herself, confessed that it was all Banaak's wicked plan. Upon hearing this, Datu Ilak ordered his bunjaos to capture and bring Banaak to him, alive. Expecting that such would happen, Banaak had already prepared his followers for the fight for their lives. For his support, he had the Sulabuns with him.

A few days before, Banaak went to the Tribe of Sulabun misleading Datu Karok about an alleged plan of Datu Ilak to expand his territory. Believing the wrong information, Datu Karok then prepared his defense forces against the Kravenas, making Banaak in-charge of the schemes.

When the bunjaos found Banaak at the Mountains of Yandal, they tried to capture him but Banaak's faction and the Sulabuns—on impulse—defeated them. One of the bunjaos survived and fled fast to inform the tribe.

The news came like a crash of thunder to Datu Ilak but he kept his wits and went to alarm the tribe for the possible attack of the joined forces.

It was the worst for Datu Ilak, that Banaak might have finally known the secret passage to the hot spring. Only the five datus of the five tribes knew of the secret that would risk their lives. But the bond of the five tribes was, by now, broken.

The forces of Banaak and the Sulabuns did not push through, to attack Kravena. Instead, they went back to Sulabun, to boast of their killing of Datu Ilak's bunjaos.

Datu Karok rewarded Banaak for his apparent fidelity by making him their tribe's new sagigilid.

In the Tribe of Kravena, the inhabitants were distraught by such betrayal and the spread of the news that they now had an enemy tribe—after a long time of being at peace. Then Datu Ilak ordered his bunjaos to fortify their defense forces and to be ready for any kind of fight that might come their way.

Datu Karok of Sulabun likewise strengthened his army through the help of his right hand, Banaak. With Banaak's stay and false loyalty in Sulabun, he was permitted to wed the only descendant of Datu Karok, Sesa Ebasa.

For months, the two tribes prepared and anticipated each other's attack.

Later, Kaya gave birth to a male Kravena and they named him Abanir.

In the Tribe of Sulabun, Sesa Ebasa also gave birth to a son. She and Banaak named him, Kalib.

Not long after, Datu Karok passed away—mysteriously—and Banaak succeeded the throne.

Chapter 1

The Vabuerettis

SOPHIA Vabueretti opened her eyes to a stormy morning. It was giving her goose bumps and she quickly fumbled around, reaching for her blanket. It might have fallen from her bed during her sleep. She wondered if she was already awake or still trapped in a dream as the broken oak tree branches at their backyard fell angrily onto the rooftop of their renovated Hispanic house.

In a blast, it raged on and on as if the sounds could break every corner, and it truly frightened her.

She peeped through her windows. Outside, the streets were empty of people, and not even the truck of Mr. Salvador that was often parked along the wide street in front of them was around. She sighed for a moment, absorbed by the singing wind and rushing splash of heavy rain upon the windows, when she heard the careful knock of her mother.

"Sophia, honey, it's past nine already. I know your classes are suspended but don't sleep that long," her mother pleaded in a soft voice.

Despite her languor precipitated by the cold weather, Sophia pushed herself to open the door. Rubbing her eyes, she was surprised when her mother handed her a sealed white envelope, a good sign that it wasn't opened yet.

"I was supposed to give it to you last night but you were in a hurry to meet Giovanni," Elizabeth shared, anticipating for her daughter's response: excitement, perhaps. But it turned out wrong when Sophia's head remained up in the clouds.

"Uh, aren't you going to open it already?" Elizabeth resurrected the mood, giving the impression that she already knew what was inside.

At last, Sophia showed some movements. "Um… maybe later, Mom," she smiled and quickly slid it behind her back, feeling much better if she'd open it in her mother's absence.

"All right." Elizabeth returned a wider smile. "Alex and Nadine are already downstairs. Don't skip breakfast, okay?" she concluded and then left.

Closing the door, Sophia shifted her full attention to the elegant envelope and saw that it was from the National Art Institute. A couple of months ago, she wrote and sent them a sample of her artwork, hoping that she would qualify for the institution's annual painting contest—a stepping stone for her, as she always thought of pursuing an art career. That painting contest was Orlando City's most prestigious one and it filled her dreams, that someday, she would be recognized for her passion.

Bit by bit, she opened the envelope, excited to know if she was qualified, but at some point, fearful of rejection. Then, she unfolded the white linen paper and started to read, bursting with hope.

"Oh, I can't believe it!" she nearly screamed. To leap for joy was an impulse. Then she hurried downstairs to tell everyone.

"Whoa! What's with the excitement?" Alex, her older brother, asked when he happened to see her running down the wooden stairs.

"Hey, guess what?" Sophia approached him at the dining room.

"What, Sophie?" Nadine, their youngest, who was then seated beside Alex on the oval dining table piped in.

"Hey you guys, I'm qualified for the contest!"

"Really? Well, that's good news!" commended Alex, with a pair of light brown eyes reflecting the twinkling chandelier overhead. "I'm glad something just brightened up my morning."

"Yup, in spite of the dark shadows outside!" Nadine shot in dramatically, attempting some witticism for Sophia.

"Thanks!" Sophia grinned. "Oh! By the way, where are mom and dad? I thought they're here by now." She then glanced around.

Usually, the Vabuerettis would start breakfast all together except this morning. Elizabeth was busy doing their avalanche of laundry piled since the thunderstorm and Philippe was away somewhere, doing some other things while on-leave from work.

"Mom's at the laundry room." Alex scratched at his jaw and nudged Nadine who was vigorously slicing her blueberry pancake. "Hey, do you know where dad is?"

With an eyebrow lifted up, Nadine sent him a cynical look. "I think he's at the front porch," she replied mumbling.

To distract the thunder strikes emerging between her siblings, Sophia intruded, "Maybe they'll join us later," making sure she didn't sound disappointed. Then she sat down opposite Nadine and met the childish eyes of her eleven-year-old sister, so much like the ocean-blue eyes of their mother's. In fact, the two of them were the doppelgangers of Elizabeth, except for Sophia's deep dimples on each side of her face and shallow cleft chin, all of that from her father's genes.

Watching Sophia blankly spread strawberry jam on a pair of toasted bread, Nadine reminded her that there were too many carbs in it.

It made Sophia laugh modestly. "Well, thanks for reminding me but that does not really apply to me right now. I'm starving. I did not actually have my dinner last night." Then she shifted the course of their talking by asking again of their father's whereabouts.

"Maybe he went to work already." Alex wrinkled his forehead.

"I told you, dad is at the front porch. He's probably reading today's newspaper there," Nadine griped, now giving them a pointed look.

Their conversation went neither here nor there, when their father finally entered the room.

"Oh! Good morning there! So, you are all awake now, huh!" Philippe said distractedly as he passed by them and went straight to the kitchen sink to wash his hands.

"Coffee, Dad?" Sophia immediately offered when her father was already half-hidden by the lustrous antique divider.

"Yes, honey. That would be nice."

Sophia went to join her father in the kitchen, and filled a vintage German porcelain demitasse cup with a freshly brewed Turkish coffee from the coffee maker.

"Dad, where have you been?" Nadine, all of a sudden, called from the table.

"I was at the front porch." Philippe made sure his voice was heard.

"See! I told you." Nadine elbowed Alex.

"Fine! You won, Nad."

Nadine cracked an insulting laugh, savoring such big-deal victory over her brother.

Scowling, Alex watched her and battled his annoyance.

"You know what, Dad? Sophie has qualified for the contest!" Nadine yelled again.

"That's good, honey!" Philippe praised and approached Sophia who was now putting the cup on a matching saucer. Observing his daughter, Philippe assumed it a chance, a chance to further strengthen his fatherly love for her. Although Sophia was with them for almost four years now, it always felt like a huge gap that separated him from her.

"When will that be?" Philippe wanted to ask.

"Tenth of May, Dad."

"So, that's four months from now."

"Yes, Dad."

"I'm so proud of you, you know that?"

Sophia flung a chirp, "Thanks, Dad."

"Really, I do."

Witnessing the veiled affection in her father's eyes, Sophia thanked him again and shifted her stare on the side.

And then, there was a moment of silence.

"I think I have to return now to my breakfast," Sophia spoke low and went back to the dining table.

Agreeing, Philippe followed her and sat down at the center. His appearance was suddenly troubled, then he showered his children with an adoring smile and began indulging himself with coffee.

"I think we should celebrate for Sophie. Am I right, Dad?" Nadine revived their talking.

"Yes, of course!" Their father suddenly blinked, just as he felt the hotness of coffee flooded in his mouth. "That is actually a good idea, sweetie. I'm glad you thought of that." Philippe's tone echoed massive willingness as he took another sip.

"Celebrate? I did not win, yet, or something for us to celebrate already," Sophia countered with puckered brow.

"Though you've not yet won, we're going to celebrate," Elizabeth, coming from the laundry room, interfered. Her sudden appearance caught everyone's attention as she sat across Philippe and breathed heavily the second she landed on her chair, fatigued by early household chores. It was, after all, her choice not to hire house maids in spite of the family's riches. It was also her choice to stop practicing law and instead become a full-time mom. Besides, money had never been a problem for they owned Christ the King Medical Center, the city's largest, and Philippe was a well-known surgeon.

"Wow! What an overflowing confidence you have, Mom, to right away assume that Sophia will win the contest!" Alex cackled and so did Nadine.

Subdued by her timidity, Sophia at least managed to be grateful to her mom, providing a simple yet heartfelt smile.

Her bearing turned distant, as Elizabeth examined her children and arranged her speech in her mind. She had been practicing those words for days now and she already thought of the possible scenarios. Soon, an eye-to-eye with her husband drove her to finally utter the words to them.

"Oh, by the way, your father and I have something to tell you," she announced in a guarded voice.

The three suddenly turned to look at their mother.

With those eyes upon her, Elizabeth held her breath and turned it into a whoosh of optimism. "This coming Friday, since it's holiday, we will visit... Forest Green." The manner of her talking obviously reflected cautiousness as the pounding of her heart began to envelop her. Holiday because it was Philipdomia's one hundred sixteenth year of liberty.

The very instant Sophia heard it, she was tongue-tied. She didn't know if she ought to feel glad about it. Forest Green was unsettling, a place of torment and sanctuary, ironically, but the former seemed to weigh much more heavily and that drove her to the edge of unhappiness.

"Forest Green! At last, we're visiting Forest Green!" Nadine shouted with her excitement and jumped from her seat.

Intrigued by why they were going to visit Forest Green, Alex asked their parents.

"Well, it's your grandma's plea and she misses you a lot already. Plus, you never visited Forest Green, not even once in your life. So your mother and I decided to take you there." Philippe was selective with his words, and he was referring particularly to Alex and Nadine, since Sophia grew up separately in Forest Green, with Grandma Lucy, Philippe's mom. It was only on her thirteenth birthday when Philippe and Elizabeth took her to live with them in Orlando.

At the onset of her life with them, Sophia was entirely secluded and she was filled with notions of being deserted. But in the long run, she finally found her niche in the city and accepted things the way they were. Sadly though, there had been a lot of things missing in her life, and she did her part to fill them up, piece by piece.

"When will we return?" Alex asked again.

"Monday."

"So, that means we're going to be marked absent in school?"

"Not exactly. I already sent letters of excuse to your respective school principals," answered Philippe and glanced surreptitiously at Elizabeth.

"Yes! We're visiting Forest Green!" once more, Nadine shrieked. This time, with a livelier tone.

"Yes, honey! And grandma also has a lake house there, near a wide green forest! It would be perfect for a picnic," Elizabeth said in a high-spirited tone, quite convincing now, even to Alex. However, Sophia's abrupt hush caused Elizabeth some burden.

"Honey, hey?" Elizabeth put a hand on Sophia's shoulder and attempted to catch her eye. "It's Forest Green, aren't you excited to see grandma?"

"I do, Mom! It's just that... it's been years since...." Sophia bowed down her head, with the intent of not finishing her sentence. On impulse, unwelcome flashbacks penetrated her mind, especially the day when she left Forest Green. Someone back there was squeezing her heart, for so long now.

At once, quietness settled the place, as if a horde of ghosts had passed by!

Elizabeth persisted in facing Sophia, eye-to-eye, to discern her daughter's thoughts, but she suddenly understood it all, all so clearly and that shook her resolve.

To change the topic, Philippe announced that the storm would be gone the following day, and that classes would be resuming.

"In that case, the prom will not be postponed," responded Alex, with a jolly voice to clear up the atmosphere. Although Alex was ten months ahead of Sophia, they happened to be both junior students of St. Thomas Academy, a Catholic school, and one of the most prestigious academic institutions in the country. As for Nadine, she was a fifth grader in the same school.

In a little while, surprisingly, the sun was already starting to come into sight and the mists, everywhere, were already outshone by the sun's glimmer.

Still seated on the elliptical table, Nadine finally had the guts to break the sickening silence. With a cup of Belgian hot chocolate in her right hand, she cheered, "This is for Sophie, for qualifying for the painting contest! Yehey!"

Bulging at the seams with surprise, the rest of them congratulated Sophia too, but Sophia reacted hesitantly. Nonetheless, such applause from Nadine went well and they finished their breakfast like nothing unpleasant happened.

Chapter 2

The Prom Night

THE succeeding day arrived and Sophia found it difficult to get up. Two hours of sleep plus a disturbing nightmare ruined her ordinary day. But having no sleep was better than a Gehenna, she thought, and noticed that she was still holding her diary, unable to set it aside when the early crack of dawn finally invited her to darkness. And to some rest.

Her mind struggled to push the memory of the nightmare, away, and focused on the painting contest instead. Although there were still four months to go, she plunged herself into it, to escape and to move on.

As usual, she looked outside through the windows and absorbed herself with the easterly sun; the sky shot with yellow rays as it glinted in her eyes.

Morning was always her favorite time of the day, the time when new chances were brought to life, like a blank page to write on another new life chapter.

Lost in thought, her scheduled alarm finally rang, the sound so earsplitting as if the four walls of her room would rupture at any moment. Then she galloped to stop it, and a text came. It was from Zarah, reminding her of their dresses for the prom. Then and there, she felt zero excitement for the occasion. Yet she tried to give Zarah a positive reply.

She sat in front of the mirror and gently brushed her soft honey-hued hair that passed her shoulders. For about half an hour, she did nothing but sit there, staring blankly and stolidly. She was bothered, truly bothered by their impending visit to Forest Green. She tried hard not to think of him, nor to allow even a flashback of his face in her memory. But it was impossible. She just couldn't help herself seeing Jericho's face all over again.

She thumped herself on forehead before the dresser's mirror. *Why am I seeing you? Please, let go now.* Her eyes were almost tearful when she ran over these thoughts in her mind.

The moment she got her composure back, she hurried for a quick shower and kept blinking back the tears.

Miraculously for St. Thomas Academy, high school students were not obliged to wear school uniforms, only the grade-schoolers were. So for this day, Sophia could wear anything she liked. She put on her plain white sleeveless blouse—one of the thousand gifts from her mother on her sixteenth birthday of about seven months ago—and paired it with fitted jeans. The only accessories she used on her body were her silver necklace tinted with small beads of diamonds, and a leather-strapped silver watch, both from her father during her first few months with them. She had her heels on, adding one and a half inches to her five-eleven, sensual frame. Her closets were filled with elegant shoes. On the other side of her shoe closet was a colossal cabinet of signature bags. Perhaps, such passion for fashion was demanded by her artistic side. Now, with some light makeup on and a heavenly mist of her favorite perfume, she was all set for school.

On her way to join her family at the dining room, she made up her mind to skip breakfast. There was no urge to nibble on anything, not even a small piece of bread. Everything that she left in Forest Green kept on haunting her ever since her mother announced the upcoming outing yesterday, and she wished that their plan of visiting it was just a part of last night's distressing nightmare.

Entering the room, she saw everyone already seated. Their fond gaze on her deprived her of her breath right away, and it reminded her of the first time she joined them for breakfast, just the day after she left Forest Green. The picture was the same, that seemed to congeal and leave her gaping at them, while standing. Squeezing her eyes shut for a moment, she blocked all the memory impulses that came out of her dread.

"I'm not hungry. I'm going to school now."

"Why in a hurry?" Alex asked.

"Yeah, why?" Nadine echoed.

Sophia's mouth froze as their gawk travelled over her, unable to process right away their questions in her mind.

"I… I'm really not hungry," she finally admitted, while her long and thick eyelashes dropped down. "I really have to go. Bye now."

"Sophie, are you sure?" Elizabeth rushed to ask, but Sophia already exited the dining room.

"What's her problem?" Alex wondered.

"I don't know." Nadine shrugged her shoulders innocently.

But the moment was a hard punch in the gut for Philippe and Elizabeth, that drew out all the air from their lungs.

Sophia was now heading to their covered car park, which was extended, at their backyard, replacing the swimming pool that almost drowned Nadine when she was three. Parked in there were their parents' black Mercedes Benz, Sophia's red mini-Cooper, Alex's silver BMW, and a Chevrolet truck, an extra one.

With her mind somewhere in the clouds, Sophia hardly noticed that her parents called her and almost chased her, across the pavement.

"Hey! Did I mention that you look stunning with that blouse I gave you?" Elizabeth's adoring preliminaries went beyond Sophia, as Philippe and his pained look continued to reach her.

The voice of Elizabeth did not reach Sophia right away. Instead, she was engrossed entirely by her father's stare, and it had the power to set butterflies in her stomach, once again.

With his face undergoing the most painful ordeal, Philippe stepped closer to Sophia. "Sophia, about Forest Green…"

Sophia immediately shifted her gaze sideways and fixed her eyes on their well-crafted landscapes, filled with blossoming flowers that instantly sent a calming effect to her nostrils. She thought of Nadine, of her sister's bouncing excitement for Forest Green. Though it killed her, she then forced herself to persuade her parents, that she was actually delighted to go to Forest Green. She tried her best to deliver it, wishing it wasn't a lie.

Listening to her, Philippe and Elizabeth were fairly swayed and whispered their goodbyes as soon as Sophia proceeded to her car.

But something reminded Elizabeth, and she dashed to stop her daughter again.

"Oh, by the way, Soph…"

"What is it, Mom?" Sophia turned to face her mother.

"Your grandma called. She said she deposited in your bank account. Perhaps, for your dress for prom…"

Sophia dampened her lips and glanced downwards, avoiding her mother's resolute eyes. Why would her grandma send her money, especially for an occasion that involved dancing? She had always been strict, and she never wanted her to have a social life either. What was the catch?

Ages passed by and Sophia finally said something. "In that case, tell her my warmest thanks, Mom." It was followed by a compulsory smile.

"All right." Elizabeth sighed and swallowed, with a prominent ripple movement in her throat. She easily perceived the forced smile in her daughter's lips. She knew her daughter and Grandma Lucy weren't close. Ever. But for some reason, Elizabeth did not want any melodramatic scene with her daughter again, hence, she tossed more praises on Sophia's appearance. "You look really beautiful, Soph. Try not to turn every head, okay?"

"Thanks, Mom," Sophia chirped. This time, her face showed no smile at all.

"Take good care of yourself, then. Be good in school. Avoid any form of trouble." Elizabeth spoke in a rush and hastened to squash Sophia in her soft arms.

"I will, Mom, but I have to go." Sophia struggled to escape her mother's embrace. "Bye, Dad." She shot a hand-wave at her father and continued her forward motion to her car.

Philippe did the same and went to Elizabeth, relieved that their conversation went well with their daughter.

Hands on the steering wheel, Sophia remembered to check the time. It was still seven twenty eight, thirty two minutes before her first class. Along the way, she noticed the mass of fallen tree branches scattered at both sides of the streets. She drove on, and at Olympus Heights' main gate, she was greeted by the security guards, giving her a grin so awful, that strained her nerves and made her drive faster.

She passed by one of the busiest avenues in the city and longed for a cup of *cappuccino-to-go* at her favorite coffee shop. Unfortunately for her, the parking lot was already full. But when she finally saw a car leaving, she immediately took a U-turn and drove fast, to occupy it.

She was about to leave her car when, from nowhere, someone called her name. She instantly looked around, wondering who called her, although the voice was familiar. Then, a girl her age, in a white shirt and a red scarf appeared within sight.

"Sophia," she repeated.

Finally, Sophia came to realize that it must be Daniella, one of her classmates during her freshman year.

"Daniella?" she asked uncertainly. "You look different. What are you doing here? I thought—" Her delighted sentence was cut when Daniella eagerly responded to her queries.

"Working! I stopped schooling for a while." Daniella walked closer to her. "I was serving when I saw you parking your car and I thought that I could come to you, to talk to you actually," she added with an easygoing voice.

Sophia was glad to see her good friend once again. "I thought you already left the city." She looked at Daniella with disguised pity.

"Personal problems, that's why…"

Beholding such a sardonic smile and desolate eyes from an old friend, Sophia decided to act sensitive.

"How are you now, Sophia? It's been... I think, two years since I last saw you," Daniella continued, seemingly even more outgoing, with the way she spoke now.

"I'm fine. How about you?"

"You know, after all that happened... I am actually thankful these days. Being away from my foster family now is like an unchained reef knot in the neck!"

"What? Don't tell me you ran away from home?" Sophia's loads of curiosity manifested entirely through her face.

With a mysterious smile, Daniella answered, "Um, something like that," while taking a look inside the restaurant at the other side of the street. "I think I have to go now. More customers are invading the diner," she exaggerated, while smiling, and Sophia conferred her a sincere grin and a tight hug, that brought them back to their memoirs of freshman year.

Sophia was left alone again and a sudden recurrence of the night she was with Daniella hit her; a night that Sophia was now ashamed to remember. She recalled exactly how her parents searched the entire city and found Daniella and her intoxicated in the streets. It was so risky, such that her parents grounded her for almost a month. She recalled how empty she felt in those days.

The sound of a harsh car distracted her thoughts as it passed by in front of her. She looked at her wrist watch and discovered that it was almost time for her English class. Groaning, she hurried back to her car and drove like a jet.

With shivering hands, Sophia rushed through the hallway and climbed the stairs up to the third floor of their one-hundred-year-old five-story school building. She was five minutes late now.

At the door, she noticed that all her classmates were already seated, wishing to survive Mr. Anderson's one-hour-and-a-half boring lecture. Cautiously, she opened the back door so as not to distract the class, but Mr. Anderson saw her and gave her an intense look that made her blood heat up on her face. She quickly apologized and went straight to her seat.

"Where have you been?" her best friend, Zarah, asked, whose seat was just beside her.

Sophia beamed, not saying anything to avoid any further noise that would infuriate their English teacher. She was pretty aware of his limited patience towards those students talking during discussions. Then, she took a momentary look at her back and saw Giovanni. The gloomy look of him made her feel she owned all the brunt in the world. Pressing her eyes tightly, she risked smiling at him, trying to tell him that she was sorry, but Zarah's whisper unfocused her.

"Girl, don't forget about our dresses, okay?"

"Yes, I won't," Sophia replied under her voice, forcing herself to feel excited, too, for the prom. Having Zarah as her brother's girlfriend always seemed to compel her to agree to everything Zarah asked her. Nonetheless, Zarah had always been a good friend since they first met in the summer, before they turned juniors.

When the class ended earlier than usual, Sophia asked Zarah if she could accompany her to the cafeteria for some beverages.

"Sure," Zarah agreed delightedly. They got up from their seats but Giovanni was suddenly upon them.

Zarah knew that the two needed to talk, so she left them, in the meantime.

Sophia appeared like a little chick in front of a livid rooster. "I'm sorry," she said, holding her hands. "I'm sorry that I overreacted. I didn't know."

"It's okay. I miss you already." Giovanni's response echoed piningly, as he offered her a warm hug. "I couldn't stand a day without you talking to me," he said to further bare his emotions.

Sophia's face felt like glowing. One of the hefty burdens on her shoulders had just been lifted. She hugged Giovanni back, telling him that she was again sorry and that she forgave him for being late at their meeting place, the other night. (It was their first month together at that time, and Sophia was already at the restaurant, waiting for him. She did not know that Giovanni was actually busy preparing for her, a huge surprise.)

"I'm glad that you're no longer mad at me." Giovanni's gaze lingered, exposing his heart, and kissed his girlfriend's forehead.

Sophia half-smiled and set her roaming marine eyes on his black hair that passed his hairline, featuring a uniform length that had spikiness all throughout.

They were distracted when Zarah slipped in and reminded them of the cafeteria. Her loud voice, which the two could overhear, made Giovanni a tad frustrated.

Giovanni, instead, held Sophia's hand as they walked to the cafeteria with Zarah.

"Okay! So here's the plan. After buying our dresses, I will be at your house," Zarah talked to Sophia as they looked for an available table, leaving Giovanni listening in.

"All right." Sophia made sure some thrill bounced off of her tone to compensate her best friend's eagerness for the prom. Then, she took a quick look at Giovanni, and perceived his own enthusiasm for the event.

When they finally found an unoccupied table, Giovanni intervened in their chat.

"By the way, I'll drop by your house later. Alex asked me to help him tonight," he said as he put on the table a box of mocha cupcakes from his backpack. They were perfectly prepared, topped with espresso frosting that no one would dare to resist. (It was made by Giovanni's mom for Sophia, and there was no denying that his mom truly adored her. And she even joked Elizabeth about an arranged marriage for their kids. After all, they belonged to the same line, in the business world.)

"Oh! I see," the two girls reacted simultaneously as they sat opposite each other on a small square table. The guys could have arranged something for them.

Still standing before them, Giovanni asked what the two girls wanted to drink.

"Greek frappé," Zarah quickly responded.

As for Sophia, she ordered cappuccino.

Briefly, Giovanni left them and went to the counter.

While waiting, Sophia and Zarah talked of the previous storm and their late session buying dresses for tonight's prom.

When Giovanni returned with the girls' orders in his hands, he sat beside Sophia and volunteered to open the box of cupcakes.

Sophia watched him do so while Zarah began sipping her favorite coffee.

"How's Alex? I haven't seen him these past few days." Giovanni poked Sophia about his bandmate. He and Alex became friends when both of them joined a musical camp back in grade school. Being the lead guitarist, with Alex as the drummer of Zion, Giovanni's every rehearsal with Alex augmented his fiery interest in Sophia.

"Alex's fine, he's always Alex," Sophia answered in a low tone. But when she noticed that her brother was not yet coming to join them, she finally asked Zarah.

"He just texted me. He can't join us. He's still in his History class," responded Zarah while going through the other messages from Alex.

In a flare, Zarah spoke again but in an irritable way. "Soph, please tell Alex to enroll in the same section this coming senior year, okay?" She let her time-bomb fury at Alex explode, before Sophia managed to calm her down.

Though there were still two months to go before the end of their junior year, Zarah still couldn't believe that Alex was actually serious in enrolling in a different section when they had a mega dramatic and overrated fight back during their enrollment period for junior year.

"Yes, I will tell my brother." Sophia handed a smile and took a bite of the cupcake. "Wow, this really tastes good —" She was saying, when she realized Giovanni's warm look, directed at her, for he was very much entertained by her delicate bite of the cupcake. It was as if fireworks flashed in his eyes, and she barely noticed that Zarah was there. But

the moment she recovered, she distanced her look straight away, before Giovanni's glow could turn her or anyone completely into ashes.

Now, Zarah distracted them. "Hey, you guys. I think it's time for Chemistry."

With a splotch of embarrassment, Giovanni and Sophia agreed and rose from their seats, quick as a flash.

Thereafter, they went back to their classes, while postponing their conversation about their plans for prom.

As soon as their last class-period ended, Sophia and Zarah rushed to leave their school for the perfect dresses that would stun everyone for the night.

"I hope we find something that will fit us," Sophia told Zarah as she drove her car.

"Come on, we're both skinny and I'm pretty sure it would be easy for us," Zarah smooth-talked, reapplying her red lipstick as she sat beside Sophia, in front of the car.

"It's really funny that we're buying our dresses four hours before prom," Sophia conveyed, in irony.

"Well, it rained heavily for almost a week and most of the malls were closed."

With a face fogged up, Sophia continued driving until they arrived at Nile, the country's longest shopping mall that was named after the world's longest river.

Hastening to the lady's department, the two gave their best shot, to spot the best eye-catching dresses, in an instant.

In a minute, a scarlet satin dress enthralled Sophia's awareness and it reminded her of the same color of a dress she received three days before her thirteenth birthday. Frustratingly though, she never knew who sent it and she never got the chance to wear it.

Waking up from reminiscing, she took a fond hold of the dress, positioned it in front of her, and looked at the mirror to see if it suited her. It was silken, with an obviously glamorous manner of couture, that would hint at a lady of vogue. It was tinted with glittering geometrical design, fair enough to compliment her radiant olive skin.

"It's beautiful! It's à la mode," Zarah commended as she was holding her chosen dress too. It was plain black, backless, and daring.

Sophia no longer searched around for anything else. She knew it was the perfect one for her. Without second thoughts, she informed Zarah that she would take it.

Zarah agreed and together, they went to the counter with their chosen dresses.

They continued through the lady's department and stopped at a boutique of cosmetics, mapping out for the perfect makeup colors that would definitely make themselves glimmer, all through the night.

Leaving the mall now, Zarah sang with vim and vigor until they approached Sophia's car at the parking lot.

With a laugh, Sophia sang along with her.

They arrived at Sophia's and pressurized themselves in her room. Zarah took a shower first and Sophia brought out her best friend's pack of personal stuff. It was what Zarah used, everytime she decided to sleep over at their house.

They still had a couple of hours to prepare.

While waiting for the shower room to get vacant, Sophia devoted her time hanging their dresses and cutting out the price tags, like an *OC*.

Before long, a call from Giovanni distracted her deep-in-thought-stare at the dresses.

"Babe, where are you now?"

"I'm still here in my room with Zarah."

"Okay! Just called to check if you're ready. Can't wait to see you, babe!"

While on the phone, Sophia saw Zarah coming out of the bathroom.

"Gio, can you call me again later? I just have to… prepare."

"Right! See you later, babe."

"Bye," Sophia concluded in a hurry. Considering everyone's growing anticipation, it only took her ten minutes to bathe.

"Hey, I'll do your hair, okay?" Zarah told her. She knew Sophia very well. She never liked styling her own hair that much. On the contrary, hairstyling was Zarah's interest and forte, no matter what everyone believed about her.

Sophia agreed with her best friend's offer and waited until Zarah was done curling her cinnamon hair that complimented her glowing porcelain skin.

Then, Sophia put on her liquid foundation to contour her face, especially her cheekbones, and to prepare for the bold account of vibrant red lips and smoky eyes.

Zarah was astounded to see her best friend with such makeup on. It was rare for her to see Sophia that way. Afterwards, Zarah looked at her, in every angle, and started on the idea of making Sophia's hair just as splendidly gorgeous.

Downstairs, Alex and Giovanni were already waiting; impatient, too, to see the girls, at long last.

Philippe and Elizabeth just got home from picking up Nadine in school.

"So… are, you guys, excited for tonight?" Elizabeth talked to the boys as she put her shoulder bag on the couch and sat.

"Mom, do you have to ask that?" responded Alex in wonder.

On the spot, Elizabeth laughed. "Of course! It's the prom! I can't believe I just asked that!"

"I wish I'm in high school too, Mom!" expressed Nadine, quite jealous that everyone's all dressed up while she was in her boring uniform.

Elizabeth and Philippe just laughed at her.

"Wait, honey, and you will also get there." Elizabeth tried her best to explain to her daughter.

"You look good," Philippe applauded Alex and Giovanni. They were in hot tuxedos that triggered Nadine to ask for a picture with them.

The two boys, of course, agreed, tittering.

To keep the ball of ecstasy running, Philippe volunteered to take a photo of them while Elizabeth gleefully watched them in motion.

Sophia ended her makeup with a light blush-on to make it more natural. But when Zarah was done with Sophia's hair, she was amazed to see Zarah pin-up the twirls that fell in waves, with a touch of class and with a few pieces that were pulled back, to give her face a frame.

"Wow, this is amazing, Zarah. Thanks!"

"You're welcome." Zarah pleasurably accepted the appreciation. As for her, she had her hair down with tousled waves, and full bangs swept over to one side.

They wrapped it all up with dazzling diamond accessories, from their ears down to their forearms.

Now, they were ready to go.

Then standing at the living room, Alex and Giovanni were, for a moment or two, mesmerized, as their girlfriends, at last, walked down the stairs.

Even Philippe and Elizabeth were stunned.

"Wow! How I wish I was wearing one of those dresses!" Nadine let her amazement show, and everyone chuckled at her.

Alex and Giovanni could not completely help but do stare at the two, forgetting to pin on their partner's dress the corsage they had in their hands.

Elizabeth reminded them and also asked to take a photograph.

Alex and Zarah were photographed, first. But when it was Giovanni's and Sophia's turn, Elizabeth could not help but admire her daughter's gorgeous look. Anyhow, she took three shots of them and even asked Alex and Zarah to join them.

Picture! Picture!

The last shot was when they compacted altogether and the camera was timed for ten seconds.

They were about to go when Philippe suddenly excused Giovanni, hoping for a private and fine conversation with him.

At his office, adjacent to the living room, Philippe unlocked a fragile chat with him.

"Giovanni, look…" Philippe sighed very uneasy. "I trust you, okay?" he said, with piercing eyes that curdled Giovanni's stomach. "I really do! So bring her home on time, in one piece."

"Thank you, sir!" Giovanni replied with an ashen smile, but he survived, and put on a bright one.

"Good," Philippe smiled slightly, accompanying it with a light slap on Giovanni's shoulders. "See that you do."

Now, they were all set. They got into the limo breathlessly, and left.

When the two pairs arrived at the venue, everyone was busy taking a lot of photographs: selfies and all that. The music was so loud that everybody just wanted to dance and have fun.

Camera flashes were all over the place and the party rocked, as everyone expected it to.

Throughout the night, Giovanni never took his hands away from Sophia. It was a sign, forbidding any guy to dance with her. But it was prom night, and she could dance with anyone else, unless she declined.

Sighing, Sophia had nothing to do but sit down and watch her schoolmates who swayed, bumping each other, moving with the music. With the undesirable return of memories from Forest Green, she wished for a dance with Giovanni. Giovanni's reason for being a bad dancer was not an excuse to her, at that point in time.

At last, the music went slow and Giovanni, after a long wait, finally asked Sophia for a dance. His touch on her waist, his dearest stare as he swayed with her—Sophia then began to feel the weight of Giovanni's fondness. The music went on and changed pace. Then Alex meddled, informing Giovanni about their band's sudden performance. They were given the chance to perform, and when they were on the stage, they dedicated their songs to their girlfriends.

It was the night of their lives for Sophia and Zarah. It was a long night where they did not notice that they were taking too many drinks. They spent the entire night enjoying every moment.

Plainly, it was an occasion that Sophia was desperate of, to drift away, to tear herself away from torrents of veiled melancholy that was almost drowning her.

The prom was now about to end. The excitement was still bursting, or perhaps they did not desire it to end, but the principal had finally spoken those pedagogic closing remarks. The discontentment was felt, but nevertheless, they all had to go.

"We'll take the limo, okay?" Alex joked Giovanni.

"All right!" Giovanni assented.

Hastily, Alex and Zarah left them and went nowhere.

Giovanni looked dearly at Sophia. "I'll take you home now," he spoke, like his mouth was budding with beautiful flowers.

Sophia nodded, without saying any word.

"Hey!" Giovanni perked her up and hung his right hand on Sophia's shoulders. "Did you drink too much? You seem so drunk," he spoke, bubbly, as they made their way outside the venue.

"A little."

"Just a little? I don't think so." Giovanni put on a small laugh.

"Don't judge. I'm still myself, okay?" Sophia also laughed.

"Okay."

Outside, while waiting for his car to be delivered by the family driver, Giovanni stared hard at Sophia, as if her face was glowing with the stars from above.

"You are a goddess," he crooned, fascinated, as Sophia looked up at the glittery sky. "I'm sure Aphrodite will get jealous of you, even Snow White's stepmom," he progressed in a laughing way, hoping to brighten up Sophia's face too.

But it sounded like a piece of trash music to Sophia. However, she was able to bestow him a short-lived smile.

Giovanni strove to wash all the negativities away, and persevered, until his car finally arrived.

Supporting Sophia so she could get inside his car, Giovanni fixed the hair that covered her face, as she struggled to sit down. But his mind warred for a moment. The picture of seeing his girlfriend in her most fragile allure warmed him. Yet, he remembered what her father told him and it just smashed him into pieces. He loped over to the driver's seat, and handed his driver some cab fare.

Driving slowly, Giovanni determined not to mind the temptation before him. He took a gaze at Sophia and noticed how she remained silent, focusing her somnolent eyes on the flickering lights of the road.

"Honey bear…" He attempted to ring a bell in her. A nickname he would use to sweet-talk Sophia, but most of the time, he would call her *babe*.

It took eons before Sophia turned to look at him, but in spite of it, he seriously waited.

"What?" Sophia asked, lackluster.

Giovanni unexpectedly stopped the car. There was this solid stare of his, like wanting to say something very important. It was followed by a wide-ranging smile. "I love you," he whispered, leaning his face forward, to say it, while looking straight into her eyes.

Hearing his words, Sophia was shaken to her knees. It was as if alcohol hadn't crossed her brain, and that she was able to process them right away. There was no mistake that she understood his message very well, as Giovanni's faultless nose was only inch away now from hers. Watching him, watching the flickers in his eager eyes, Sophia's chest crumpled in its utmost intensity. There were fear, guilt, and apologies. She needed to respond. She had to compensate for his devoted, unconditional fervor with a passion that she knew she wasn't feeling. But it felt like the more Giovanni tried, the more it put her to the grave. So before his lips could be completely locked onto hers, she quickly shifted her look to the side, unable to feel the slightest voltage of his approaching lips.

"I love you, too." It was ages before she whispered back these words, but her stare was a million miles away. Heavens, she was torn by the clashes of her own emotions.

Swaying his head in frustration, Giovanni then sighed his disbelief and displeasure. But knowing that Sophia needed to come home before midnight, he started his car again and continued to drive.

The two finally arrived at Sophia's.

Giovanni was desperate with one more moment with her. He looked at Sophia single-mindedly, and without a second passing by, he kissed her in fast motion, leaving her frozen.

Under his controlling kiss, Sophia congealed further as his mouth powerfully travelled over hers. It was their first time, the first kiss out of his thousand attempts. Still, there was a part where Sophia wanted to push him away, but she was quite afraid that it might hurt him. Giovanni was a good guy, she knew that, but it just ripped her heart apart to let him drown into his own pool of desire. Not now. Not at this time of confusion, for someone in Forest Green, was recently hauling her back in a rope of uncertainty.

Not prolonging the agony any further, Sophia finally distanced herself and got out of his car immediately.

Giovanni's eyes were steadfast. They followed her every step until she finally made her way, to open their gate. He waved, smiling broadly, as Sophia tried to look at him once more.

Chapter 3

A Visit to Forest Green

THE glorious sunbeams streamed through the thin white curtains of Sophia's bedroom.

With a heavy head, Sophia jumped up from bed and went straight to the bathroom to wash her face. She harked back; later today, they would be heading to Forest Green. She breathed in deeply and sprinted to the kitchen to make herself a cup of brewed coffee. She knew it would help her get rid of the alcohol residues.

"Sophia, honey, do you know where your brother is? I think he did not come home last night," Elizabeth, seated on the kitchen table, asked her daughter as she entered the kitchen.

"We separated when the prom was over, Mom. He was with Zarah and... Giovanni brought me home."

"Oh, Alex…" Elizabeth flung a heavy sigh and went through her cell phone again. "He knows we're going to Forest Green today!" she grumbled and immediately lowered down her voice.

Feeling very much dehydrated, Sophia brought out a bottle of distilled water from the fridge and gulped it gracefully, slipping the name *Forest Green* out of her mind. She was about to grab a cup when her mother spoke again.

"I've been trying to reach him for the thousandth time, now," Elizabeth said worryingly.

"Well, he will be here, Mom." Sophia acted lethargic.

Alex had just arrived when Sophia saw him through the kitchen windowpane.

"Here he comes, Mom! I told you," Sophia murmured, still in a haze.

Now, Elizabeth made a move to meet her son.

Sophia followed her.

"Alex, where have you been? I've been calling you!" Elizabeth's tone was mixed with worry and anger, as she reached him to the doorway.

"I'm sorry, Mom. My cell phone got low last night. I forgot to charge it." Alex scratched his head innocently and placed his coat on the chaise lounge.

"Okay, you are forgiven for that! Join your sister for breakfast." Elizabeth's aggravation immediately subsided.

Eavesdropping, Sophia butted in. "So, that's it, Mom? Aren't you going to ground him or something? He did not come home last night. But if I were to do that, you would ground me for, like a month," she stressed, and at a reckless pace, went back to the kitchen.

"Because you are a girl, Sophia. There's a difference between you and your brother." Elizabeth struggled, to chase her.

Sophia bent her head and filled a cup with steaming coffee, while plopping her mother's words inside her mind.

"Sophia, honey, don't get it the wrong way," Elizabeth implored and grabbed Sophia's chin to face her. "I worry less, for him…"

Faking a smile, Sophia looked at her mother. "Okay..."

"Good."

Now, Sophia sat down and quickly disregarded her mother's unjust treatment to them.

"And Sophia..." Elizabeth wanted to say more.

"Mom..."

"Start packing for Forest Green, all right?" Elizabeth demanded with an evident compulsion.

"Later, Mom. I'll just finish my cup." Sophia pressed her forehead like she was suffering from a headache, and Elizabeth knew it was hangover.

"How's your prom?" Elizabeth took a detour first before interrogating her.

"It was great, Mom."

"That's good. I'm glad you enjoyed it."

Sophia shook her head negatively and rubbed her cup to avoid her mother's stare. She knew her mother's style of questioning very well. Next, she took a slow sip of the coffee.

Noticing how her daughter avoided her, Elizabeth now began to spill out her main concern. "Did you drink a lot last night?"

Sophia got tongue-tied. Her mother was right and she couldn't say no. She wished to explain her actions but nothing came out, when she opened her mouth.

Elizabeth narrowed her eyes, already knowing what Sophia was about to say. "You know, Daniella really was a bad influence on you. I'm glad she's no longer attending your school," she said in a judgmental manner.

"Please, don't talk of her that way. She was a good friend," Sophia defended her old friend.

"Good friend? Does a good friend invite you to the most dangerous clubs in the city and convince you to cut classes?" Elizabeth's voice suddenly raised.

Sophia stared wordlessly. They were back to the same old arguments again. Hence, she decided to shut up.

"You know, we had a problem about your drinking alcohol before, right?" Now, Elizabeth's voice turned low.

"I'm sorry, Mom. It won't happen again," Sophia immediately apologized, but her eyes rolled away from her mother's confronting gaze.

Soon after, Elizabeth left her and went upstairs to start packing for Forest Green.

Sophia reflected for a minute, and then, volunteered to wash the dishes that almost crammed the whole fraction of their sink.

Some images slowly wheeled into her vision, like Nadine who came to her and asked for help to pack for Forest Green.

Sophia was instantly persuaded, but she asked Nadine to wait first.

"Okay," Nadine politely agreed, pulled out a chair, and watched Sophia wipe their wet silverware.

But something bothered her, and Sophia faced Nadine, then asked, "Can't you pack your own things, Nadine?" She made sure she delivered these words without hurting her sister.

"I can but… I'm not really good at folding my clothes." Nadine brought herself a peg down, which was unusual for her.

Raising an eyebrow, Sophia pondered at such unassuming nature from her erstwhile sister. "Wow! At least you humbled yourself this time."

"Can you help me or not? Otherwise, I will ask mom to do it for me."

"Of course, I'll do it for you." Sophia then appeared to tease and bent down to wobble her sister's hair.

"Touch not my sacred hair, sistah!" Nadine clowned in an exaggerated way to play along with her.

Sophia giggled and after she finished the dishes, they swiftly went upstairs and packed for Forest Green.

As the shorter arm of clock pointed ten, the Vabuerettis were ready for Forest Green.

Alex and Nadine were incredibly raring to go, but for Sophia, there again were those recollections. Unhappy events of her childhood that deluged her memory as if in a storm surge. She never mentioned them to her family, not even to her grandmother. It was only Jericho who knew all of them. But the moment Jericho's face reappeared in her mind, she quickly squeezed her eyes shut and stopped herself from thinking of him.

"Oh, God. Please, Jericho, get out of my mind," Sophia whispered to herself.

"Sophia, are you okay? Honey, what's wrong?" Elizabeth examined her as they were almost done putting their suitcases into the trunk. "Are you sick?" she kept on and on and placed her palm on Sophia's forehead.

"This is nothing, Mom. I'm all right!" Sophia let some brightness appear in her face to cover up her emotions.

"I have some Tylenol with me. You might as well take one."

"Mom, I'm fine," Sophia insisted.

"All right." Elizabeth gave Sophia another once-over and continued setting things in order.

But a moment ago, Nadine happened to hear Sophia whispering Jericho's name.

"Who's Jericho?" Nadine suddenly asked Sophia, like a kitten begging for food.

Surprised that she had whispered his name so clearly, Sophia's mouth was completely paralyzed. She didn't expect her sister to overhear. And she had no idea how she was going to answer her puerile sister. Because of it, she answered in tidbits.

"Oh, he's a good friend." Sophia attempted to stretch her lips sideways.

"A good friend? How come I never met him?"

"Because he's not from Orlando, Nad."

"So, where is he from?"

Sophia was tight-lipped again. She massaged her forehead and decided to speak the truth. "He's from Forest Green."

Nadine smiled, like wanting to start a wisecrack, and it made Sophia defensive.

"Look, he's a good friend from Forest Green, okay?" Sophia stressed as Nadine finally laughed it out, guessing that he and her sister were once an item.

"Hey, stop it!" Sophia prodded Nadine, lightly.

Still, Nadine teasingly laughed.

Elizabeth was distracted and interfered, "What's going on?"

"Mom, Sophie's excited to see Jericho!" Nadine continued, putting forth a playful jest.

"Jericho? Who's Jericho, Sophia?" Alex intervened too. He just overheard them while helping their father check the car's condition.

"Um, her childhood sweetheart, perhaps." Again, Nadine made fun of Sophia.

"Nadine, stop!" Sophia tickled her. Doing it to her sister usually helped to change the topic, but today, Sophia was wrong. It actually became a magnet that finally attracted their father's attention.

"I did not know about that Jericho. You never mentioned him to us, Sophia." Philippe joined the issue with a very serious aura.

"He's a good friend, Dad." Sophia was beginning to find the situation unbearable.

"Okay, so let's just get inside the car, then." Philippe, right away, was sidetracked by the flow of their talk, but Elizabeth's wondering eyes were still focused on Sophia.

"All right!" Nadine soured out of her eagerness and entered the car ecstatically.

Feeling a bit of awkwardness, Sophia sat at the back seat near the window. Right next to her was Nadine while on the other side was Alex. As for Elizabeth, she joined her husband in front.

The family was now geared up. They whispered some prayers for their safety on the road, and Philippe started the car.

Alex, on the double, tuned in to his iPhone and swept himself off his feet with music, while Sophia sustained a reply to each of Giovanni's text.

As for Nadine, she waited with bated breath to reach Forest Green in an instant.

They had already left the city and were on their way. Then, Nadine began to get bored and complained that the place was too far.

"Oh! Sweetie, get busy appreciating the view of big billboards, okay?" Elizabeth suggested, noticing how Nadine exhaled noisily, from the back.

"Sure, Mom." Nadine peeked at Alex and Sophia who were full of activities to entertain themselves.

Elizabeth observed Nadine through the rearview mirror. "Oh, poor sweetie!" Because of this, she asked Alex and Sophia to include her in their busy worlds.

Alex got his own back by purposely paying no heed of Nadine. He simply didn't want to get preoccupied by his sister's silly behavior.

Elizabeth rolled her eyes to Sophia and by her gape, she asked her to amuse Nadine so as to help her lose the boredom.

"All right!" Sophia muttered, understanding exactly her mother's message. "Hey! Do you want a Facebook account?" She initiated offering to Nadine.

"Sure but—"

"You're too young to use it?" Sophia continued Nadine's sentence.

"Exactly!"

"Well, Facebook doesn't know you're a total baby! We might as well assume that you're already suited for this."

"Wow! That's clever." Astounded by it, Nadine immediately asked her to make an account through her iPad.

Sophia almost laughed at Nadine's enthusiasm yet she decided to shut up.

Together, they made an account, which took them half an hour to finish, because Nadine wanted her profile to be perfect and intriguing.

The driving kept on until lunch time. Their hunger got them to pull over and eat.

Philippe found a small restaurant yet it appeared very engaging to the senses.

"I can feel my stomach whirling like mad!" Alex roared while their father found a way to park their car.

"Yeah, me too." Sophia was on the same line.

Finally, Philippe stopped the engine.

They got out quickly, with enough enthusiasm to enter the restaurant, and at long last, got the chance to jam-pack their vinegar-like stomachs with plenty of food.

Just seated on a table for five, Philippe called the attention of the waiters. "What is your blockbuster cuisine here?" he asked, without checking the menu, while his whole family watched him order.

The waiter, in a whip, offered every jewel of their resto's crown of cuisines, and Philippe ordered whatever was on the top list.

The moment they had their last mouthful, they returned to the car and drove again for Forest Green.

In the long hours of sitting inaudible at the back, Sophia's mixed emotions gradually engulfed her. She put on her earphones and hoped to amuse herself with a Jason Mraz song, but the bag of nerves she always had for Forest Green troubled her again and again. In the course of it, her mind continually raced and bore the tame face of a young boy in the spurt of adolescence, deeply and widely smiling at her. It was Jericho, and the torture of her heart carried on.

Sophia's lengthy silence clearly piqued Nadine who was at her best, to revivify herself from boredom.

"Hey!" Nadine elbowed her, stimulating her to get up from her self-absorbed position of stupor.

Still, Sophia showed no signs of attentiveness, and so Nadine pulled off her earphones and said, "Aren't you supposed to feel excited? Duh, it's Forest Green," with her eyes rolled up and her hands laid across her chest.

Sophia bit down on her lower lip and risked a fleeting look downwards, also avoiding her brother's shifted look at her. "I am, of course!" she answered, to put off her dilemma.

"Your voice doesn't agree with what you just said, Sophie," Nadine challenged her.

Visibly flabbergasted, Sophia let Nadine's gaze run over her and swallowed her amazement at her sister's wit. To think of a rescue, she began tickling her, probably the best way to end such police-like interrogation.

Nadine finally got all of Sophia's attention and they travelled down the road singing *Mary Had a Little Lamb*. Nadine was singing, of course, at the top of her voice.

As a result, Alex and their parents joined them.

It took them four more stop-overs until they were, at long last, on a thirty-minute drive down to Forest Green.

When they were, by this time, entering the town, Sophia noticed no notable improvements. Because their Grandma Lucy's house was the last one, the largest and the one located on the top of the hill, they continued to pass

by many houses. Sophia was on tenterhooks to see Jericho's house, but such a David disappeared from among the blocks of Goliath houses.

Where's his house? Sophia pondered heavily. *What happened?* Now, these thoughts about him completely drowned her, dragged her back into the lake of their young affection.

They were almost at their grandma's when Sophia saw the mango tree. With a blink of an eye, countless reminiscences collected in her mind. She could tell a million stories, with that tree. She used to climb it with Jericho's help and play there, with him. She even, almost fell down from it. Viewing those images, she was entirely buried in her seat. There appeared those laughters and adventures she had those days with him. Then, an unwelcome teardrop streamed down her face, and Alex saw it.

"Sophie, are you all right?" Alex asked her carefully.

It took a little while before Sophia shook her head to clear her mind. She remained motionless as her hair fell down and covered her entire face.

Feeling a sudden weight in his chest, Alex then shifted his look at the surroundings. Old Spanish houses, green paddocks, commercial enterprises, and various bystanders were all that he could see.

"Okay, here we are!" Elizabeth announced as a historic Spanish manor finally came into view.

"That might be Grandma Lucy at the front porch. She's already waiting for us," alleged Nadine merrily, despite her lassitude at the long trip.

Grandma Lucy, seated on a wooden rocking chair at the veranda, was electrified to see a vehicle coming, and she already surmised that it was them.

The very second Philippe stopped the car, Nadine breathlessly jumped out and ran to cuddle her grandma.

"Oh, I am supposing you are Nadine now." Grandma Lucy warmly received Nadine. "You have changed a lot, my dear."

"Yes, Grandma, it's me," Nadine reacted, exuberantly.

Glee scattered further in the air when Philippe, Elizabeth, and Alex joined them, except for Sophia, and Grandma Lucy patiently waited for her.

Sophia, little by little, slid out of the car. She did not know what to feel at that very moment. But in the face of it, she directed her footsteps to her grandmother and to her surprise, Grandma Lucy swiftly squeezed her, as if like their last time.

"I missed you, Sophia! You're all grown up and you've turned into a very fine lady." Grandma Lucy squashed her more and more, her smile accompanied with tears.

Staggered at where she was standing, Sophia managed to hug her grandma back, while wrestling with the dragons in her thoughts. She had suffered, as a child, from her grandmother's previous harshness.

"Mom, this is Alex now." Philippe recapped his mother of Alex.

"Oh! Alex, you now look exactly like your grandpa."

Alex nodded agreeably. He was thrilled to see his grandmother again after she visited Sophia in Orlando three years ago. Then, he opened his arms to hug Grandma Lucy, too, and Nadine briskly joined them.

"You don't know how happy I am to see you all here. Come! Let's get to the house. Bea and I prepared dinner," Grandma Lucy welcomed them again, in higher spirits, as she led them to the dining room.

Sophia remembered Bea, their tireless housekeeper, who had always served the Vabuerettis. Sophia used to call her, Auntie Bea. She was widowed alongside Grandma Lucy, when their husbands did not return anymore from their scientific quest through the mountains. Some townspeople believed that they were killed by the strange creatures in the dark forest, but Grandma Lucy and Bea were not convinced. (Both widows reasoned out that hunting animals had proved danger to their spouses, after all.) Although the legend diminished through time, some were still influenced by its veracity.

Elpidio Vabueretti, Grandma Lucy's beloved husband, was a well-renowned physician and botanist while Eduardo, Bea's husband, was his ever-loyal assistant.

Sophia decided to put her luggage first, upstairs, while the rest went straight to the dining room. She noticed a step on the staircase, made up of narra, with its unfaded, waxy appearance. The arrangement of wooden furnitures at the aisle of the second floor was obviously re-designed. But the portraits of their lineage were still displayed at the walls; no noteworthy changes were seen; yet plainly, there was no evidence of dust. The old painted portrait of her ancestor, Giancarlo Ruy Vabueretti, brought her to a stop. It seemed like he was Alex's exact carbon copy. She took a closer look at his face and remembered the stories of her grandma: that he was of Italian, Spanish, German, and Dutch descent, and that he was one of the explorers that King Charles I of Spain sent, to sail the Pacific, after Juan Sebastián Elcano's successful return to Spain from the Spice Islands via the ship, Victoria. From Mexico, an anticipated wild storm hit Vabueretti's ship and swayed it off into the western Pacific Ocean. It was how the Great Archipelago of Philipdomia was discovered. In addition, he became the first gobernadorcillo (a town mayor) of Quiño, Forest Green's former name, when he married a beautiful native woman.

Quiño was changed to Forest Green when the Americans finally took over the country. It was, somehow, named Forest Green because every view of the town just looked amazingly green, like the forest.

Sophia walked towards her old room and twisted the doorknob. It was already loose. Gradually, she pushed the door, noticing the smell of old furnishings. It was as if the room was never used, for years. She looked around, and her belongings, as she left them, were still there. Her bed was still the same but this time, designed with fine white curtains. She took a look at her wooden desk beside her bed; there she still found the framed photo of her childhood. She opened its drawers. They were empty and it disheartened her. Her notebooks and the artworks she left were all gone!

After a few minutes of acclimatizing herself again with the old atmosphere, she paced towards the balcony, perceiving the scent of burgeoning flowers of their ample garden. Far away, she could see the glimmering lights of small houses. She sighed for a moment; she put a smile on her face, but knew that it was a fake smile—like the moon, hidden by the dark shadows of the sky.

"Sophia, your grandma wants you downstairs for dinner," hollered Bea as she knocked on the door.

Sophia heard it and took a peek, then opened it for her.

"Why is there a frown on your face?" Bea asked, detecting Sophia's furrowed forehead.

Grasping for a lungful of air served as Sophia's initial answer. Then, she pushed herself to give Bea, at least, a nippy smile. "Nothing, Auntie Bea. I'm just tired. It's been a long trip."

"Are you all right?"

"Yup! I'm fine, Auntie Bea. Thanks!" Sophia was obviously forced to say these words, as she stepped out of the room.

"Okay," Bea half-smiled.

Sophia smiled back, wanting to be at her best, to refresh the old connection she used to share with Bea. Then, she initiated a walk.

Bea went after her and noticed how Sophia changed a lot—physically. Watching her carefully walk down the wooden staircase so as not to create a noise, she remembered the lonely girl always running through it.

"There you are!" Grandma Lucy looked ecstatically at Sophia.

"Okay, let's eat already!" demanded Alex as he clapped his hands once and rubbed them, fixing his eyes on the table that was loaded with a variety of cuisines.

"All right! Let's dig in!" Philippe agreed as he began serving himself.

Sophia watched them in motion. She was not starving at that time. All she ever wanted was to be in her room—alone. She lingered, gawking at them, and noticed that her grandma had not aged that much.

Although in her mid-seventies, still, Grandma Lucy was able to preserve her white and radiant complexion and thick brunette hair, although some gray hair strands stood up in a cloud around it. Plus, her face had only few of the laugh lines and zero saggy eyelids. To sum it all up, Grandma Lucy's natural half-American and half-Philipdomian physique was still there.

"Sweetie, are you not hungry?" Grandma Lucy saw Sophia's distant gawk at everyone.

"I'm… I'm just tired, Grandma," Sophia answered, but in a split second, realized that she must not act that way in front of the food. Her grandma always told her to pay respect to any meal by not refusing it. By some means, she managed to take a nibble of them but she noticed that her grandma gazed from time to time. There was still that persistent feeling that she must be careful with her every move, everytime her grandma was around. Nonetheless, she endured eating with them, not saying anything until she and Grandma Lucy were the only ones left on the table.

With a mysterious smile, Grandma Lucy kicked off the dialogue by asking if Sophia had a boyfriend.

Sophia said yes by nodding, with a fixed look at her half-emptied plate.

"That's good, sweetie. What's his name?"

"Um, Giovanni."

"Oh, a charming name."

A forced smile was seen from Sophia. She excused herself and went upstairs.

Watching her granddaughter's back, Grandma Lucy was overcome with guilt. She realized, too late, she had been too punitive to Sophia, many years ago.

Sophia locked herself in her room, wishing to be relieved of all the raging emotions that she wanted to end. They had been pulling her down for a very long time now. Then, she noticed the silence of her cell phone.

There was no signal and Giovanni might be calling her by now.

And so, she went back to the balcony for a better reception. Then and there, she tried her best to clear her mind.

The sky over the mountains was peaceful, but she was immensely troubled by the burning memory of her yesterdays with Jericho.

It was already getting late that night and Sophia was still at the terrace, in-and-out looking for a signal. It was becoming windy and it seemed like it was going to rain. She went for a steam bath when a ring of her cell phone finally seized her awareness.

At last, a signal popped in, and she loped for her cell phone.

"Hi, babe! I've been trying to reach you for about a hundred times now! I miss you! How's your trip? I hope you're enjoying your stay there!" Giovanni talked in an uninterrupted way. He was obviously excited.

"I—I'm fine. The signal here is difficult. I—I'm really sorry." Sophia did not know what to answer first.

"It's all right now. At last, I've heard from you."

A sigh echoed from Giovanni, and Sophia barely knew what to say now.

"I hope you come back soon, babe. I am really missing you right now," Giovanni expressed sincerely, and that added more fuel to Sophia's burning chest.

"It's just three days, Gio."

"I know, but..."

Another sigh echoed again from Giovanni. This time, a louder one.

"I'll call you again tomorrow. I understand you must be exhausted," Giovanni continued, frustrated.

"Um, no! Please, keep talking. I miss you too."

"Are you sure?"

"Yeah." Sophia attempted to enliven her tone and closed the windows that were opened by the harsh wind.

"Babe, it's pretty obvious that you're tired. I can tell it through your voice. Please, get some rest now." Giovanni's manner of talking was really earnest to her.

"Thanks!" Sophia responded with relief. "How understanding of you."

"I hope you have a signal tomorrow. I'll sleep now and I wish to dream of you." Giovanni managed to conclude it, sweetly.

After the call, Sophia went back to the shower room, when at a flash of second, she remembered the night when Jericho climbed the terrace, to see her. She was so scared then, that Grandma Lucy might see them.

Having it all at the back of her mind, made her heart feel like it would burst from her chest. She turned off the shower and wished for more air. And then, she remembered all of Jericho's efforts, especially during her down times. He was always there to rescue her from loneliness or depression.

Sophia had no friends back then. People were afraid to touch her. She was a Vabueretti, one of the *untouchables* of the town; rich, influential, and dangerous. They were the original settlers. But Jericho had all the guts to see her, to be with her! He was such a boy of compassion and the very person Sophia needed during those days.

Sophia's thoughts of Jericho were disturbed when Nadine knocked heavily on the door.

"Sophie, hurry up, I need to pee!" Nadine pleaded with a sound of jumping.

Sophia hurried and right away opened it, wondering why her sister did not use her own.

The wind blew stronger and the heavy rain started to fall.

Nadine was scared of sleeping alone in her spacious bedroom and begged Sophia to sleep with her.

Touched by her sister's unusual plea, Sophia granted it, but Nadine asked for another favor.

"Sophie, please read me some stories." Again, Nadine appeared like a kitten begging, and it was difficult to resist. And so, Sophia thought of a story, a fable, the one that her Aunt Bea used to tell her always. Gazing through the high ceiling, she began to tell the story of *Jack the Boastful Deer and Joe the Meek Snail.*

Once upon a time, by the riverbank of Far Away Land, Jack the Boastful Deer challenged his friend, Joe the Meek Snail, who between them could reach the end of the river faster.

Joe knew that he would lose the challenge but in spite of his smallness and sluggishness, he accepted it.

The day of their competition came and Jack checked on Joe if he was ready.

"Joe, my friend, are you all set?" yelled Jack as he stood by the riverbank.

Without delay, he heard a response coming from the river water and it was a sign that both of them were ready.

Then, their race began.

Jack was running slowly and confidently. He decided to stop for a while and asked Joe if he was with him.

"Eak, eak!" Jack heard.

Very much surprised to know that Joe was responding from the water, he ran faster.

Run after run! Jack checked on Joe if he was still with him.

"Eak, eak!" Still a response echoed from the water.

Put to farthest shock, Jack could not believe that Joe could actually make it. For this, Jack forced himself to speed up until he got drained.

When he successfully reached the endpoint, he was very much surprised to see Joe already celebrating his victory there.

"How did you...?" Jack asked Joe while trying to catch his breath.

"I won, Jack! Who's faster now?" Joe joked.

Jack was very much disappointed by his defeat and went home unhappily. He did not know that the snails responding to him during their race were actually Joe's snail friends, and Joe was already at the endpoint waiting for him.

Just as Sophia finished the story, Nadine was already sleeping. "She's tired," Sophia whispered to herself and kissed her sister goodnight. Then, she turned the lamp off, and also went to bed.

Chapter 4

The Treasured Memoirs and the First Encounter

THE sun shone early the ensuing morning and the rain had gone away. The sky was unclouded, perfect enough for the Vabuerettis to spend a picnic at the Bo Lake.

"Good morning, everyone! Yohooo! It's a lovely day for a picnic! Grandma, Mom, Dad, Alex, Sophie, and Aunt Bea! Please, wake up! The heavy rain had stopped," screamed Nadine, around the house.

"Philippe, honey…" Elizabeth prodded Philippe with a sleepy voice while still in bed.

"Um…?"

"Nadine's up already and she's screaming around the house, waking us all."

Philippe sighed heavily and half-opened his eyes. "I guess she's really excited for the picnic!"

"Let's just understand her. It's her first time to be here," Elizabeth pointed out.

They all got up and got ready for the picnic. Moreover the excitement was for Grandma Lucy's sake, because, at long last, a family-get-together would be happening at the lake house.

The lake house is fifteen kilometers away from Grandma Lucy's house and it was never visited for years. Knowing that her grandchildren would visit it, Grandma Lucy instructed her servants to get it cleaned up.

When they got there, Sophia was surprised that their two-story narra-made lake house was still the same, both outside and inside. It seemed like those almost four years of her absence in Forest Green had not aged every piece of wood and wiped out their shiny appearance. Surely, one could still taste the feeling of comfort there. She explored the first floor. There stood the visual open-shelving divider, between the living area and dining area. But one thing that truly amazed her was the huge pair of deer horns on the wall that faced the main door. The whole of it was still there,

still in branches and spine-chilling. It was intentionally placed there to scare anyone who visited the lake house. Then, she remembered the first time she laid her eyes on it; it scared her a lot. She opened the main bedroom across the living area and noticed the same old bed and design of furnishings. Later, she went upstairs. All were the same. One by one, she opened the three bedrooms including the guest room. Sighing, she went to the balcony, and everything from the past came back to her all at once. It always felt like the lake house was forever a home to her. She took a deep and long breath, and busied herself with a view of the lake, just below the wide and green mountains. Although it was almost lunch-time, the rays of the sun felt like it was still dawn. Gasping for another lungful of fresh air, she noticed that her family was already preparing a table outside, a few meters away from the lake water. They wished to have a lunch there, to be under the glowing bright sky, shot with gold.

Going back downstairs to join her family, Sophia's mind began to be filled with exclusive things about Jericho. The lake reminded her so much of him. She used to play and swim there with him. It was him who taught her how to swim, how to catch some fish, and how to stay longer in water.

"Sophia, do you still remember the times when we used to come here?" Grandma Lucy asked her granddaughter as she approached her at the lake bank.

Sophia quickly grasped for some air. "Yes, Grandma! Very clearly. It seems like it was only yesterday when we were here," replied Sophia, as her eyes were set on the lake. She already programmed herself to never mention Jericho's name whenever her grandma was around. She knew that once she uttered his name, an explosion would happen.

"Um, excuse me for a while." Grandma Lucy left her, to help Philippe and Elizabeth with the table.

A full minute passed, and Bea approached her.

"Remember the old days, Sophia? You used to play here around when you were just a little girl. You tried to climb the trees, you wanted to swim, you wanted to catch some fish... but your grandma never permitted you." Bea elbowed Sophia.

"Yes, Auntie Bea! None of them escaped my memory. I remember them so well. It is funny though that I learned them all here with Jericho but grandma never knew about it..." Sophia, all of a sudden, realized that it was a slip of tongue.

"Ah, Jericho! Yes, that boy. Oh, poor boy! I remember him. You were too young for that puppy love, Sophia. But he's still in town just in case you're wondering. I heard he already got married!" Bea detailed.

"Really, Auntie Bea? He's now… married?" Sophia confirmed, with a depressed voice.

"Of course, I'm kidding! He's a doctor now, a new doctor actually! And he's in town. He works at the town's only hospital," Bea delivered, bright and breezy. She was very much eager to know what would be Sophia's next reaction.

Sophia was shocked, a little bit confused of how she was going to react. Jericho was only five years ahead of him. Why would he become a doctor that fast?

"Really? A doctor? But... he's too young to be a doctor," Sophia pondered heavily.

"That's what I asked too at first. You know, Jericho is a genius. Maybe, he got accelerated," Bea illuminated, with a shrugging of shoulders.

Sophia paused, running things in her mind, as Bea directed her own black eyes at her.

"When we were passing by the Belfast Street yesterday, I noticed that Jericho's house was not there anymore. I wanna know what happened," Sophia spoke again.

"Actually… here is one thing that you should know. He's rich now, Sophia."

"Really? How come? I mean, since when?" Sophia continued to get puzzled.

"You really missed a lot of things here, ever since you left." Bea's voice waned. "You know Mount Kalban, the one that we passed by earlier? It's his family's and it was found out that there was gold there. Jericho's grandfather sold it to a mining company," Bea supplemented.

"So, that started it all?"

"Yes, Sophia. Don't you know many girls run after Jericho? He's like the cocaine of every girl here, even of the oldies." Bea told her in an exaggerated way to play along with Sophia's changing facial expressions. "Do you want to see him, Sophia? Because if you do... I can find a way," Bea offered, laughing.

Sophia smiled and brought up the topic that she was in a relationship now with Giovanni. She told her that Giovanni was a good boyfriend and he was her brother's best friend too.

Bea also smiled but she had always known… always known Sophia's feelings, for Jericho.

"Okay, people! Lunch is ready!" Grandma Lucy announced excitedly.

"Everybody, find your own seat now. As for me, I will bring out the barbecue," Bea chimed in.

"Do you need some help, Auntie?" Sophia offered.

"No, honey. Just sit there and turn your flat tummy into a hump."

Sophia stretched her lips sideways, still impressed by Bea's good-humored nature.

Elizabeth noticed the closeness of her daughter to Bea. She knew that it was she who stood up as Sophia's mother, when she was still a child. Because of it, regrets troubled Elizabeth again.

"Sophia, tell us something about the lake," Alex asked, as they gathered around the table for lunch. "I'm sure you have a lot of stories to tell."

"Yeah, Sophie! Tell us some stories, but not with a Jericho!" Nadine overlapped, kiddingly.

Grandma Lucy's eyes, at once, dilated, and looked at Sophia penetratingly.

"Jericho? So, you've been mentioning him to your sister, huh?" Grandma Lucy delved Sophia, even more penetratingly.

Sophia flushed severely and acted as if she never heard a thing. The name Jericho was always poison ivy to her grandma. Thus, she fared better to just stay, close-mouthed.

"Okay, enough with that guy! And who's that guy anyway, huh?" Alex protested.

"He's no one," replied Grandma Lucy and guzzled a glass of water.

The moment Sophia heard it, she asked herself why her grandmother never liked Jericho, and mulled over the fact that if Grandma Lucy already knew that he had now a profession, as a doctor, just like what grandma had always wanted for every male member of the family… What, then, would Grandma Lucy think of Jericho, now?

"Here's the barbecue!" Bea announced delightedly as she neared them.

"I super-like barbecue, Auntie Bea. I'm glad you had them prepared," admitted Nadine, extending both hands to grab one stick of it.

"So, you call her auntie too?" Alex asked, just to provoke his sister, a bit.

"Why? Is it prohibited to call her auntie too? Is that word exclusive for Sophie?" Nadine retorted, always in a childish way.

The Vabuerettis laughed at Nadine's behavior, and her humor had caught everyone's attention, including Sophie's.

Throughout the chattering after the meal, Philippe's eyes were entirely engrossed by the lake. He missed it so much so he offered his family a swim.

"Dad, I am really glad you thought of that." Alex released his boredom, waiting for his father to finally ask it.

"Honey, see to it that you don't go to the deep part!" Elizabeth warned them uneasily.

"Wow! Dad, teach me how to swim. Please, Dad! Please!" Nadine begged, hopping at where she was standing. Finally, she was on the mode to learn swimming again, after her drowning incident that caused everyone trauma.

"Okay, honey! Yes, I will."

Nadine laughed her excitement away and looked at Sophia. "Dad, how about Sophie?" She wanted her sister to join them but she knew her sister's fear of deep waters too. Grandma Lucy once told them that Sophia almost drowned in the lake when she was nine.

"Sweetie, your sister is also afraid of deep waters, okay?" Grandma Lucy intruded.

Sophia overheard it and flung a heavy sigh. At the back of her mind, she had already overcome it, and she overcame it with Jericho's support.

They watched the three swim in the lake, and Sophia took photos of them.

Taking a brief look at Sophia, Elizabeth noticed her pulling face, as she focused the camera to her father and siblings.

"Hey, are you all right?" Elizabeth approached her across the dock.

"Mom, I am fine! I am! I am, Mom!" Sophia asserted so she could not take everyone's joyfulness away.

"Are you sure?" Elizabeth flippantly confirmed as she caressed Sophia's hair.

Sophia nodded, giving her mother a strained smile. Then she continued taking photographs to escape the clashes of her own mixed emotions.

When she finally took a lot of photos, she craved to rest her legs when, unexpectedly, she saw the huge blue stone in front of the lake house that was naturally square in shape. It was still the same where it was located, still surrounded with peanut grasses. She paced towards it and remembered the day when she was sitting there with Jericho.

It was Mother's Day at their school but she made up her mind to skip the program. She was so downhearted that she was the only student whose mother was not there to attend it, so she swept her sadness away by agreeing to Jericho's invitation to the lake house. That day, he waited for her outside their school with his assembled cab. It was an Italian scooter with a trunk welded with metal tubes at its side, supported by another wheel, making it a tricycle. There was a rectangular wooden plaque that served as a seat. Jericho was fond of inventing so he was able to pull them altogether. He thought of it as a means of taking Sophia to the lake house for it was, somehow, a one-and-a-half-hour trip from the town proper, and he did not want them to walk, nor to hitchhike with deer hunters.

Crystal clear, Sophia unearthed all these memories and smiled, a smile between sadness and joy. Her smile widened when she further remembered how Jericho spread a blanket onto the grasses for them to sit on, and he served her wafers and a can of soda.

At that memory, she could scarcely impede her tears from flowing. She needed to wipe them; she did not want to be seen crying by her family, so she hurried inside the lake house to pacify herself.

"Why is this still happening?" she asked herself as she opened the main door. "I thought I have moved on."

Then, she went straight to the sink to wash her face, and ran for her shades to cover her reddened eyes.

Elizabeth and Grandma Lucy were watching the three enjoy the water when they noticed Sophia's sudden disappearance.

"Where's Sophia?" Grandma Lucy asked Elizabeth.

"She's just taking pictures a while ago. I don't know where she went."

They continued wondering of Sophia's whereabouts when Sophia walked down the dock and joined her father and siblings. The moment she dove into the lake, everyone was put to a tense halt.

"Sophia, no!" Grandma Lucy yelled with bursting panic but she was surprised to see Sophia swimming as if a mermaid.

"What?" Elizabeth was solidly staggered.

"Whoa! Did you just see that?" Nadine asked her father and Alex.

"I thought she's afraid of the water," they all asked each other.

Sophia finally got her head above the water and fixed her hair, uncomfortable with the way they looked at her, including her mother and Grandma Lucy from the bank.

"What?" Sophia asked them.

"I thought you're afraid of the water," Nadine answered while being carried by Philippe on his shoulders.

"Who told you that?" Sophia contemptuously asked, still uncomfortable with their reaction. Then she got out of the water and walked through the dock dripping wet, self-questioning why it was such an issue.

Instantly, Elizabeth came to wrap her with a towel and asked when she learned to overcome her phobia.

As well, Grandma Lucy went after Elizabeth to ask the same question.

"Long time ago," Sophia replied and grabbed her flip-flops.

Hearing it, Grandma Lucy wondered heavily and drew a sharp breath.

Sophia was already shaking badly, hence, she excused herself and rushed inside the lake house.

The setting sun was already half-hidden by the wide mountains, and the Vabuerettis decided for an early bonfire.

Sophia gathered her hair in a ponytail. The wind entering the lake house was cold so she brought out her much-loved white shawl from her suitcase.

In a while, her grandma knocked on her door, with a smile so refreshing that puzzled Sophia.

"You just surprised me today," Grandma Lucy said. "I thought you're still afraid of the deep water."

A nod, along with a partial smile, manifested from Sophia, hesitant to admit that she actually overcame it with Jericho's help. But the brief silence she shared with Grandma Lucy reminded her of the bonfire.

"Um, I guess, everyone is already outside," Sophia said in a bowed head.

"Yes. You're right," Grandma Lucy agreed, and they walked together to the venue.

Everyone gathered around as soon as the fire livened up, and they cheered for Nadine to perform.

Nadine was always willing and vigorous for any presentation. She sang a bubbly melody and bopped some lively dance moves before them, making everyone clap in awe, even their workers who joined them at that time.

"Okay, it's time for Sophie now!" Nadine gamely told everyone as she went back to her seat beside Elizabeth.

"What? No!" Sophia griped.

"Sophia, Sophia, Sophia!" they cheered.

"No, I don't sing. I don't dance!" Sophia grumbled further. "Trust me, I'm a terrible one!"

"I don't think so!" Alex countered, his face appearing very teasing.

"Oh, actually Alex can sing!" Sophia struggled to avert all the attention from her. "He's in a band and really an excellent singer. I guarantee you, your cheers will all be worth it." Sophia strongly gave fine points about her brother, desperate enough to end her agony.

It was pretty obvious to everyone that Sophia did not want to perform and so, Nadine suggested playing *I'll Act, You'll Guess Game*.

"What's that?" they wondered.

"Oh, this is how we play it. I'll describe a word or a phrase and you'll guess it only through my gestures within two minutes," Nadine explained, in full hope to be understood. "Like a charade!" she added.

"Oh! Okay! I bet that's a lot of fun!" Elizabeth agreed.

And to make everyone participate, they grouped themselves into two. Philippe, Sophia, Bea, and two Vabueretti workers composed the first group while the other one was consist of Elizabeth, Alex, Nadine, and the other two remaining Vabueretti workers. As for Grandma Lucy, she served as the mediator and the scorer at the same time.

They tossed a coin to determine which team would go first and it happened to be Philippe's, and Sophia was assigned to do the demonstration. She went to Grandma Lucy to listen to what she would be whispering and was surprised of what she heard: *Somewhere Over the Rainbow*, her grandma's favorite song, and it was too long for her to portray it.

"All right, timer starts now," Grandma Lucy announced as she took a look at the wrist watch she borrowed from Alex.

Sophia held up four fingers to denote four words and moved her fourth finger.

"Fourth word!" her groupmates said.

Sophia nodded agreeably and started shaping in the air a rainbow.

"Mountains?!" Philippe initially guessed.

Sophia moved her head side to side indicating that her father's guess was wrong.

"Half-circle?" Bea also guessed.

Sophia again swayed her head, the frown in her face turning deeper while their opponent group loudly teased them.

"Um, wait! Is that a rainbow?" One of the Vabueretti workers yelled asking.

Sophia joyfully nodded and the rest of the group was now getting excited.

Sophia moved her second finger, meaning they had to guess for the second word, and she symbolized the word *over* by placing her right hand over her left one, doing it again and again.

"Hand over hand?" Philippe once again guessed.

"Over?" the other Vabueretti worker guessed, and Sophia again agreed.

Bea remembered the song that Grandma Lucy always listened to. "Somewhere Over the Rainbow!" she shouted.

"Yes!" Sophia leaped for joy and so did her groupmates.

"Huh?" Nadine reacted, quite disappointed. "That was difficult but it took them just a while to guess it!"

"Okay, your turn!" Philippe challenged the opponent group.

Elizabeth's group got up from their seats, pressuring themselves that they had to guess it too and they decided Nadine to do the demonstration.

"Okay," held Nadine in a very babyish manner and went to Grandma Lucy to listen to what she would be whispering.

Grandma Lucy paused for a minute, thinking of a phrase as difficult as the first one. But she found it hard to think so she asked them to wait for a while. Then the movie *Titanic* popped in her head and she instantly whispered it to Nadine.

Nadine was confident. It was just one word and it would be easier for her groupmates to guess it. Then she raised her left index finger with a wide smile.

It was, of course, a delight for her groupmates that it was just one word and it would be much easier for them compared to the previous one.

Now, Nadine started to illustrate a ship in the air and repeated it twice.

"A boat?" Alex initially guessed.

Nadine conveyed it wrong by moving her head sideways, giving them an upset look. She drew it bigger for them to identify that it was a ship, a bigger one.

Aggravated, they could not still get her.

Now, Nadine became even more irritated and repeated highlighting a big boat in the air, doing it again and again.

Sophia already had in mind that it must be *Titanic* but she just laughed, helping herself not to slide the word out of her mouth. They had a VHS tape of it at her grandma's and she even remembered how Bea cried at the end of the movie; too much affected she was those days!

Elizabeth and the rest thought even harder, frustrated that they couldn't guess it.

For Nadine, she illustrated it over and over again.

"The movie 2012," Alex guessed again.

All of a sudden, Elizabeth realized that it might be *Titanic*. "Tita—"

"Oops, time's up!" Grandma Lucy declared.

"What? Are you sure?" Nadine's group protested.

"But I was supposed to say Titanic," Elizabeth shared.

"Sorry, two minutes is up already!" Philippe insisted on his mother's behalf.

"Fine!" Nadine exhaled noisily and went back to her seat, admitting their first defeat.

"You should have spread your arms. Remember, the *I'm flying* scene of Jack and Rose in front of the ship!" Sophia made fun of her sister.

"Whatever!" Nadine fought back, her lips pouting and right eyebrow lifted up.

It was Philippe's group again. Unfortunately for him, he was assigned to illustrate.

This time, Grandma Lucy already thought of something and it was the *Bible*.

Philippe exhaled noisily and started to demonstrate. He raised his left thumb and smiled.

"What?" his groupmates wondered, unsure if he was depicting one word or he was just giving them a thumbs-up sign.

"Dad, does that mean one word... or you're just giving us a thumbs-up sign?" Sophia confirmed, holding her laugh.

"No!" Philippe defended himself and explained to everyone that the thumb was actually the first digit and that he meant one word.

"Oops! Warning!" Grandma Lucy imposed. "No talking!"

"I'm sorry, Mom! I'm just trying to explain." Philippe defended himself as they laughed at him in full blast.

Not to confuse his group anymore, Philippe moved his left index finger. He illustrated the *Bible* by shaping a rectangle in the air. Rectangle could mean a lot to them so they guessed the following:

"A door?"

"A window?"

"A flag?"

"A refrigerator?"

Philippe was already getting frustrated. He widened his eyes and looked at his hands as if he was holding a book.

"A book?" Bea guessed.

"Yes, Auntie Bea! It must be a book," Sophia synchronized. "But what book?"

"Okay, let us guess a title of a book!" Bea told her groupmates when their opponent was already doing a countdown.

"Eight, seven, six, five..."

"Oh, no!" Sophia and the rest screeched, quite dismayed.

"Okay, time's up! You were not able to guess it," Grandma Lucy told them. "It's the Bible!" she then smiled.

"Oh, okay!" Philippe's group reacted.

Nadine abruptly yawned and everyone noticed it. It was supported by the drooping of her eyelids.

"Honey, you're already sleepy. Time for bed now," Elizabeth said and allowed Nadine to lay her head on her shoulder.

Hence, all of them decided to stop the game although some were still at the peak of their enjoyment.

They ended the bonfire, laughing, saying that it was a night to remember.

The night carried on, and Sophia was still up at the terrace looking for some cell phone signal. Giovanni was probably incensed now, trying to reach her. The sky was shimmering and the tall trees were dancing when she suddenly heard a flock of birds nearby. On impulse, she looked at the source, hoping to see a disturbed flock of wild birds, but as she kept on staring, something seemed to hit her head. It was a gigantic pair of white wings! And, oh so beautiful!

What a heart-stopping moment!

Hands still shaking, she realized that her senses could have deceived her, and she tried to believe so. Then, she returned to the lake house and ran to bed, still troubled by those gigantic white feathers.

Chapter 5

The Resemblance

IN the wild Forest of Evergreen, the Kravenas were still reined by Datu Ilak. His son, Abanir, was hailed as the tribe's first sepe. He was trained for any form of fight, providing an accolade to his masculine emergence. His wings were so fine and white that could outshine the clouds at day. His eyes were so splendid for they changed colors, depending on his mood, and they were shielded by thick and long eyelashes—the features that discredited him as mere, ordinary Kravena, and dubbed him as the apple of every female's eyes.

He was roaming around one night, away from his tribe, when he was distracted by a flame coming from a distance. His senses were very sharp so that he perceived it instantly. At first, hesitation controlled his thoughts. But as he noticed the flame slowly cease, out of extreme curiosity, he approached the place.

There, a bizarre house was revealed. Hiding from the shadows of tall trees, a horrifying bolt from the blue seemed to strike him in the head.

A creature! There was a creature he hadn't seen before! Something without wings, that made him gawk, completely!

He lingered, scrutinizing, wondering what it was. *An enemy*, he thought.

As the peculiar creature endured standing at the terrace of the lake house, Abanir's enchanted eyes never blinked, wondering why it didn't have those gargantuan wings to ascend into the air.

He persisted in observing it and flew back. Only then, when he was up in the air, did he realize that the peculiar creature could have seen him.

He came back to Kravena, horrified. His hakaro, Rabel, came to him and asked where he just went, complaining that he had searched the entire tribe to see him. But Rabel noticed Abanir's odd look.

Abanir's eyes had widened more and more, and changed into green, filled with fear and query, and that made Rabel fall into a pond of questions.

"What happened to you, Raha? You seem strange tonight! Why?" asked Rabel, eyes puzzlingly alarmed.

"I saw something!" Abanir fought for his breath. "It was strange!"

"Strange?" Rabel stepped closer to him.

"Yes, Rabel! Strange!" Abanir met his eyes. "A very strange creature!"

Looking through his raha's eyes, Rabel's mind battled. What was he pertaining to? Then he said, "Oh! Maybe, it's just a wild animal meandering around."

Rabel's eyes shut close and his head swayed. "No. It was something that looks almost the same as us but... has no wings to fly."

Rabel's jaw dropped, eyes widening. He now knew that it was a human. He had an encounter with one before, while he was with Banaak in the Mountains of Yandal. But he must not tell it to his raha. Not now.

"Raha, it's just an animal that we seldom see, for they live away from us," Rabel then insisted.

Abanir looked him through the eyes, clutched him at the shoulders, and said, "No, it was almost like us. It can not fly but it was—"

"What, Raha? It was what?"

"It was beautiful. Wonderful. I can still picture its face in my mind!" Abanir then appeared exceptionally amazed.

Scared for his raha to fall into something dangerous, Rabel stressed, "Raha, I told you—"

"Told what, Rabel?" asked Kaya, the mother of Abanir, who had unexpectedly gone outside the palasyon, and saw her son and Rabel arguing.

Being proclaimed as the tribe's reyna when Datu Ilak married her, the tribe members called her Reyna Kaya since then. Abanir was not the only son. When the royal couple was accepted by the tribe, they planned to have more offsprings. Along came Sanaya, then Karan. Sanaya was proclaimed the tribe's only sesa and Karan, the second sepe.

The Kravenas lived abundantly but there was always that fear—that fear that the Sulabuns would attack them at any moment. Every male Kravena was trained to be a warrior. Learning to fly also meant learning to hold a bolo and hit a bull's eye with an arrow. Weakness was never accepted. Failures never defined them. Everything must be earned with blood and sweat.

Abanir was trained to become the bravest, fastest, and strongest Kravena—the perfect warrior that Datu Ilak always wanted him to be, for he would be his successor.

Abanir, surprised by his mother's presence, bowed down in respect. Then, he went inside the palasyon to join his siblings.

Wondering heavily, Reyna Kaya asked Rabel why her son was arguing with him.

Rabel conveyed that he would explain it, but only in the datu's presence.

Abanir joined his siblings in playing sticks, by simultaneously dropping a bundle of them on the floor. Such a game would allow the players to separate the sticks one by one, without moving the others. But his mind was back at the lake house. The face of the bizarre creature persisted in reappearing in his vision. Back to that other world, Abanir had lost track of what they were playing now.

As for Reyna Kaya, she went to Datu Ilak after his meeting with the kansilos.

"Rabel has an important message!" Reyna Kaya told the datu.

"Call Rabel and bring him to me," Datu Ilak ordered one of his bunjaos.

In a blast, Rabel came and explained to the regal couple what he learned about his raha's bosom-encounter with a human.

"This shall not happen!" Datu Ilak screeched. "This should be a secret to my son! He must not know about the humans. They are enemies," he shouted louder. "Rabel, I command you to take my son's attention away from that human! Humans are a threat to our tribe!"

"Yes, Datu Ilak! I will," responded Rabel, taken aback by the datu's unusually enraged reaction.

"But, my Datu…?" Reyna Kaya intruded. "I think it's time for our son to know about the humans. We don't know when they will invade us again," Reyna Kaya prevailed, with bowed head.

"In time, my Reyna!"

Rabel left them and went back to his raha, reminding himself to be quiet.

Abanir saw him and asked why his parents talked to him, behind closed doors.

"Oh, my beloved Raha, we're just planning to improve our planting of sinapoy." Rabel avoided Abanir's eyes. "The mang-aanis were complaining that some of the wild birds had eaten their seedlings," he proceeded, with more tense movements.

"I see," said Abanir but he knew he was lying. He knew Rabel well—he was not a good liar.

Chapter 6

The Return of the Past

"SOPHIA, wake up!" Bea shook Sophia's shoulders lightly. "It's already eight! Everyone's downstairs for breakfast!"

"I'm still sleepy. I couldn't go to sleep last night," Sophia spoke languid.

"Maybe, you just can't stop thinking of Jericho," Bea, in full swing, teased her, not having in mind that it was better to throw a joke on a drunkard person than on someone who had just woken up.

Sophia, in the twinkling of an eye, thought of what she saw last night.

"They were beautiful," she mumbled, unconscious, as her eyes were directed on the ceiling.

Flippantly, Bea asked, "What do you mean beautiful? Are you pertaining to him? As in Jericho?"

"No, Auntie Bea! It's not... him."

"Maybe, you're still sleepy, Sophia. Come on. Off the bed now." Bea shook Sophia's shoulders once again and pulled her so she could stand up.

In a little while, Sophia prepared herself and went downstairs, straight to the dining area to join her family. She saw everyone there, laughing as they enjoyed their breakfast.

"Come on now, dear! Join us and sit here beside me," offered Grandma Lucy with delight. "Didn't you sleep well last night?"

Sophia obeyed her grandmother and replied, "Yes, Grandma. It was actually terrible to see—"

"A ghost?" Alex guessed jokingly.

"Ugh! Please, don't tell me if it's true, Sophie!" Nadine was obviously frightened, and Alex just loved watching her in fright.

"Sweetie, don't believe in ghosts! Your brother's joking, okay?" Elizabeth pointed out to take Nadine's horror away.

"Honey, what did you see?" Grandma Lucy cut the joke and inquired Sophia.

"Oh, never mind, Gran." Sophia diverted the topic and served herself a slice of freshly-cooked omelet.

"Maybe, it was just your imagination." Philippe joined their talking. "Here! Take a glass of this juice!" He handed Sophia a glass of fresh calamansi juice.

To change the subject matter, Sophia praised Nadine for suggesting the game that they played last night.

"What's the name of that game again?" Elizabeth asked as she passed Sophia a bottle of distilled water.

"*I'll Act, You'll Guess Game*, Mom, like a charade," responded Nadine with glee, her head dancing from side to side as she crunched her choco flakes.

"Okay, I'll remember that from now on."

"Yes, Mom. You should because we will frequently play that game from now on." Nadine glared at Sophia piercingly, trying to make a hint that she was not yet done with their defeat.

Sophia beamed and refreshed herself with a gulp of calamansi juice.

As soon as their breakfast ended, Elizabeth reminded them to get ready right away, for they would be leaving in an hour.

"What's with the rush?" Alex asked in wonder, disappointed that his plan of fishing wasn't about to happen.

"It's just that… it might rain. The road to the town is, you know, steep and dangerous," Philippe explained on Elizabeth's behalf.

"All right!"

Almost immediately, they began packing. Bea and Grandma Lucy were already prepared to leave, so they did the dishes.

Before long, the Vabuerettis were all now putting their baggages into the trunk but Sophia was, somehow, bothered. She wanted to look at the place once more where she saw those beautiful white wings, hoping that she might see them again to clarify her vague thoughts.

Unknowingly, someone who was not from the lake house was watching her. This time, his heart pounded heavier as his eyes strained, following her every move.

As the Vabuerettis left, Abanir watched them from afar but the eagerness to know more about such creatures and the bizarre moving metallic objects that could transport them unremittingly disturbed him.

Sophia took a glance at the lake house once again. There was this aching inside of her… it was like something was missing, something that she must uncover, before she could leave.

On the way, Sophia could still sight the lake house from the cliffy road. Around it were the thick green mountains.

"Beautiful! God's nature is really beautiful!" Elizabeth was overwhelmed while surveying the green surroundings. "I hope the thickness of the mountains will not fascinate the illegal loggers," she added, sardonically.

"You're right, honey!" Philippe was of the same mind, and continued to follow the truck of Grandma Lucy and Bea, which was driven by one of their workers.

The family lingered while appraising the mountains, until they were all approaching the town proper. The chatting was, all of a sudden, turned onto Philippe and Sophia, and to their adventurous childhood days at Forest Green.

They finally arrived at Grandma Lucy's house and it was past twelve when they got there.

Sophia suddenly realized that she must look for a signal, for Giovanni might be calling her. It had been a day since they had talked to each other.

Alex wanted to see the entire town before they could leave the next day, so he asked Grandma Lucy if they could have a stroll. Also, he requested Sophia to come along but Sophia did not want it, at first. She was convinced, when their father asked Bea to tour with them.

The three then got into the car and Alex was permitted to drive.

Nadine wanted to join them but a heavy headache quickly overcame her.

On the road, Alex asked Sophia where she studied, what church she attended, and who her friends were, so they could all visit them there.

In shame, Sophia revealed that she actually had no friends back then.

"No friends! Are you kidding me? I mean... why is that so?" Alex's feedback showed he was bursting with curiosity.

Seated with Sophia, at the backseat, Bea chose to remain quiet, and she just listened in.

"Alex, does it seem like I am joking?" Sophia's tone was defensive.

"Okay! So who's that Jericho you were talking about, yesterday?" Alex passed her a stare through the rearview mirror. "Is he...?" Then Alex looked at her again with a dawning knowledge, realizing that Jericho might be Sophia's old flame.

Sophia was put to silence.

"Aunt Bea, where does this Jericho live and then we'll visit him?" Alex shot a silly laugh.

"Oh! Maybe, he's in the hospital today."

"What do you mean hospital, Aunt Bea?"

"He's a doctor, Alex."

"A doctor?" Alex almost lost control of the wheels. "Soph, he's much older than you?" he asked Sophia with louder laughs, almost insulting her. "I didn't know you're into old men!"

"No, Alex! He's just five years ahead of your sister. Maybe, he was accelerated that's why he finished med school that fast," Bea explained for Sophia.

Sophia's stillness lingered.

"Okay, I see!" Alex waned.

Then, they passed by a coffee shop and decided to pull over.

Entering the shop, they noticed the short line.

"I'll just wait for you there." Alex pointed a vacant table near the coffee shop's glass wall. "Espresso, by the way."

"All right," Sophia responded and fell in line with Bea.

While Bea was ordering, Sophia happened to see Beatrice and her friends through the open door, the people who used to bully her back in grade school; the usual type of girls who were unhappy at home and bullied others, too, to cover up their misery.

Unfortunately, Beatrice was also a Vabueretti, an illegitimate one who descended from Cleorita, the mistress of Arturo Vabueretti, Philippe's grandfather, but no one in town knew about it. It had been a secret for years now.

Her fright elevating up, Sophia informed Bea about their presence, and that they needed to leave.

Bea retaliated, while ordering. "Why would we leave? You have not done anything wrong to them."

"I know but… we have to go." Sophia's voice ricocheted with more tension.

"Honey, just let them see how much more beautiful you've become." Bea stayed put.

"Auntie Bea, I don't think that's a good idea. Let's just leave," Sophia insisted, like a cat on a hot tin roof.

Beatrice and the other girls were already entering the coffee bar when they saw Alex on a table for three. Without them knowing that he was Sophia's brother, they talked of him, as they fell in line, behind Sophia and Bea.

"Who's that handsome guy there?" Beatrice pointed Alex.

"Um, I think he's new here," one of Beatrice's friends answered."He's hot," Beatrice supplemented.

"So true!" Then they laughed altogether.

Stirred, Sophia brusquely turned around and proudly said, "Excuse me, I think it's my brother whom you're talking about."

"Excuse me, too! And who are you?" Beatrice faced Sophia arrogantly.

"Oh! Don't you remember the girl you always bullied back in grade school?" Sophia dared as her height made them step back.

Dumbfounded, they now knew she was Sophia.

"Are you surprised that the girl you used to make fun of is here?" Sophia kept on, making sure her voice was relax and pervading.

"And that girl now is even more gorgeous and way prettier than you are," Bea said with a rolling of eyeballs.

Beatrice and her companions were stunned speechless, hardly disbelieving Sophia's drop-dead gorgeousness.

"Oh! By the way, he's my brother!" Sophia pointed to Alex who was entirely clueless about what was going on. "And he's just out of your league," she stressed, and grabbed their orders. Then, they went to Alex saying that their interest to stay at the coffee bar already washed out. Still, Sophia and Bea sternly looked at the girls as they went back to the car.

Alex roared the engine back to life and rolled driving with no directions until they happened to pass by the town's small hospital.

All of a sudden, Sophia saw a tall guy leaving the building.

Bea also saw him and conveyed that he was actually Jericho.

Sophia's heart immediately leaped out from her chest. She could hardly believe that it was Jericho, that he turned into a very respectable person, even manlier and sharper.

"I heard the name Jericho again. Did you see him?" Alex was intrigued. "Shall I pull over?"

"Yes, Alex. I think you should pull over," Bea requested and convinced Sophia to talk to Jericho, at least, to say *hi*.

Sophia did not agree to it and begged Alex to continue driving.

Bea objected to it and stressed that it could be the last time she would see him.

Sophia still doubted. She knew how hard she broke his heart when she left Forest Green without telling him.

"I know how devastated he was when I left," Sophia explained quietly. "I don't have the nerve to face him and talk to him like I hadn't done anything wrong."

"It's been years. Maybe, time has healed everything! Just try, honey."

"I just can't, Auntie Bea. What if he has changed?" Sophia bared, even more.

"I understand," Bea sighed. "All right, if that's your decision... let's just go, then."

"Okay, we'll go," Alex agreed and was about to restart the car, when Sophia suddenly changed her mind. She went out, to Jericho, and said his name—softly and cautiously.

Jericho was putting all his stuff in his car when he heard a female voice calling his name. It was so very familiar that it made his heart drum in his ears.

For a while, Sophia wondered what forced her to open the car and talk to him. Her heart was racing, for he was about to look at her already.

Jericho stood stock-still and couldn't identify if the girl he had always loved was really standing right in front of him, or it was all just a product of his long-time hallucination.

But as she came closer to him, at a snail's pace, he had finally realized it was actually her, even taller, yet still frail and soft.

"Sophia... is that… you?" he asked in a faltering voice.

"Yes, Jericho. It's... me," Sophia barely replied.

They hardly said something. They were hesitant to ask each other's lives but were patient enough, for their dialogue to keep on.

"My family and I—" Sophia's voice suddenly trembled. It took her a while before she found the courage again. "Um, we're here for a short vacation," she finally said, reddened and pierced by his probing look. "We were passing by when Auntie Bea saw you. I mean, when I saw you, too, and Auntie Bea told me that it was actually… you." Sophia felt she passed through thorns, to say those words.

For a minute, he was wordless, gazing through those oceanic eyes that reflected the depths of her very apologetic soul. It was as if his fixed look bypassed the length of her spine and blew up straight to her mind, stimulating all the memory impulses of their young love.

"I'm glad you're here, Sophia," Jericho finally spoke, after epochs. Then, he noticed a guy in the car with Bea. "Is he your boyfriend?" He strove, adding some false liveliness to his voice.

"Oh, no!" Sophia palmed her forehead and took a glimpse at Alex in the car. "He's Alex, my brother. He drives the car and… Auntie Bea is also with me."

Yet again, Jericho turned quiet and unwittingly examined her.

Sophia stood frozen, already feeling like collapsing, as Jericho's stare turned more powerfully, making her uncomfortable, from head to toe.

"How long would you stay in town?" Jericho continued, still with that lethal stare that now made Sophia's eyes gaze in different directions.

"Um, not that long. We're actually... leaving tomorrow." She bowed her head uneasily.

"Tomorrow?" Jericho's eyes revealed crying disappointment.

A massive wave of torture washed over her, and it felt like she was drowned by those gloomy sea-green eyes of his. She tilted her chin up and said, "Auntie Bea told me that you're now a doctor. I am really, really happy for you."

Jericho's eyes narrowed then. "I promised you that I would be a doctor, remember?"

A blast from the past!

Sophia looked down, hiding her face with her long brown hair, and remembered the day when Jericho was aiding her bruises. She was bullied in school that day and was also sick. Then and there, Jericho promised her that he would be a doctor, to be always there for her every time she was wounded or sick.

Sophia could not talk too much at that very moment. She could not believe that he actually kept his promises—and in return, she could never pay it back. She hardly stopped a tear from flowing and came to realize that crying would only add up to all the pain she brought into Jericho's life.

"I think I should go," Sophia managed to whisper, wishing she could look him in the eye. "I'm sorry." She turned around and went back to the car, wiping those aching tears with her bare hands.

Standing mutely, Jericho lingered while watching her, but he felt completely melted by the flames of his ceaseless love for her. Shattered, he had nothing else to do but watch her leave again.

Sophia entered the car and continued wiping her stinging tears.

Alex and Bea did not know what to do. But to her surprise, Bea then asked Alex to restart the car.

The moment they arrived at Grandma Lucy's, Sophia hurried upstairs. She laid in bed crying, ashamed of herself. Why in the world would she ever deserve someone like Jericho, whose compassion and affection was impossible to recompense, not even a piece of it?

The dusk proceeded, with parades of flashbacks in Sophia's mind. It was clear to her now that throughout those almost four years of Jericho's absence, it had turned her heart fonder. There were still those sparks! The forbidden sparks! For they were too young (especially her).

Sophia struggled to let go of all her affection for Jericho. Troubled she turned for it only meant that she was falsehearted with Giovanni.

"I'm sorry… forgive me, please," Sophia cried at Giovanni's picture in her cell phone. She ensued dictating herself that she loved Giovanni and at some part of her heart, it was true. But her love and stinging thirst for Jericho were always there, firmly hovering at the very bottom of her heart.

Sophia begged Bea that dinner time to let everyone know that she would not be joining them. More importantly, she asked Bea to remain silent about her encounter with Jericho.

Bea understood it fairly enough and reassured Sophia when Elizabeth suddenly knocked on the door.

"What's going on?" Elizabeth snooped, witnessing those swollen eyes of her daughter.

"Um, I'll just go downstairs." Bea was mindful enough to give Elizabeth a private exchange with Sophia.

Looking at her daughter, Elizabeth craved for the same personal conversation, just like how Sophia bared her heart to Bea.

"Hey." Elizabeth exerted her best to make Sophia confess why she reddened those ocean-blue eyes.

Eons seemed to follow... for Sophia remained silent, vacantly looking at her hands that never stopped from trembling.

"Sophia, honey…" The light tone of Elizabeth echoed tons of concern but still, there were no signs of responsiveness.

Obviously, Sophia did not want any disclosure. She knew that once she let the cat out of the bag, it would all come badly to her grandma, and beyond doubt, there would be, again, an unending cavalcade of stage shows, involving Jericho. She didn't want a repeat of the past. For her, the past was only meant to be buried. Too much water had already flowed. Never again.

Sensing her daughter's slight coldness, Elizabeth thought that it would be best to leave her now. She gasped for air and left with full understanding.

Sophia initiated movements again, just after her mother closed the door. Though she did try, she couldn't shorten the distance between her and her mother, especially with the rocky highways of her struggle, of those from her childhood. She had grown up learning to depend on Bea.

The night deepened.

Steadfastly, a roar erupted from Sophia's pit of longing, for Jericho. And she exerted all her paramount efforts to silence it.

Chapter 7

Forget Me Not

THE family was all set to leave.

Though it was heartbreaking, Grandma Lucy tried to appear lively before them. Deep inside, she knew it might take years for them to visit Forest Green again.

"I'll be missing you all." Grandma Lucy released her sentiments.

"Don't worry, Gran. We will visit you more often from now on." Alex attempted to relieve his grandma's melancholy.

"Yes, Grandma. Alex is right and we will miss you too," Nadine supplemented as she fetched up her goodbyes.

Sophia, quiet and tearful at the front porch, neared Grandma Lucy and Bea. She bequeathed them her hugs and kisses and joined her family in the car. Yet, crucial discernments and silent cautionings were delivered to Bea through Sophia's heartfelt stare.

"Okay, before we embark, is there something we forgot?" Philippe asked everyone while starting the engine.

"Nothing, Dad," Alex and Nadine responded, but for Sophia, she was evidently out of herself. The car moved, and Sophia rolled the window down, wishing to be flown away with the fresh air. She wished for Forest Green memories to be wiped out, once and for all, but the green mountains they passed by reminded her so much of those gigantic white wings.

"Honey, I think we should drop by your daughter's old school. I wanna see it," Elizabeth told Philippe.

"Yes, hon! That's actually a good idea."

Sophia strongly vetoed it to herself. It would just remind her of the other things she already buried in the past.

"Honey, would you mind instructing me about the way?" Philippe looked at Sophia through the rearview mirror. "You know, the streets are no longer the same, even their names."

"Um, take a right turn when we get at the crossing and another right turn later, Dad."

"Okay!" Philippe continued driving, following his daughter's instructions.

As they passed by certain business establishments and aged houses, familiar faces stirred Sophia's blood. Two-faced, pointy little headed, and bare-faced people were all recognized by her; the people who once made her feel secluded. No matter how long ago it all was, she could not let loose to wash them away.

But there were still those mysteries why the townspeople always treated Sophia differently, as if she was something close to trouble. Even Jericho couldn't explain it to Sophia, before. But one thing he told her once was... she was a product of a crime, which became the talk of the town for quite some time, and caused the Vabueretti Plantation to close down and make some people lose their jobs. However, Jericho and Sophia never knew what that felony was. Everybody seemed to be tight-lipped about it.

Soon, they were already approaching Forest Green School. It was empty because it was the town's Foundation Day, another holiday.

Sophia was surprised to see many changes at her old school. The mahogany trees that crowded the school grounds were already cut off and a wide parking area took over. There used to be only one building but now, there were three. At the other side of the school, many commercial buildings were now erected but before, it was just a vast grassy meadow.

"I can't believe it changed a lot," Sophia uttered, unaware that she voiced it a bit loud.

"Really?" her family asked.

"Honey, you had a good school," Elizabeth hailed.

Sophia slipped out of the car. The flag pole that took her back to the days of her grade school was the only thing that hadn't changed. Gazing through their nation's pure white rectangular flag with a bright yellow sun at the center, Sophia had enough of memories.

Her family got their feet out of the car too and eyed Sophia's old school.

"Honey, we're not going to stay long here. It will delay us from getting home," Elizabeth then said, tapping her fingers on the car roof.

Sophia nodded, promising, herself, to look at the surroundings another time, and went back to the car.

The rest followed, and Philippe brought the car back to life.

They passed by a Roman Catholic church, and Sophia saw Michael, one of her concerned classmates before, gathering the dried leaves at the church's front yard. Then, more reminiscences rushed in like flooding water. She remembered, Michael and Jericho once rescued her from drowning in the lake, during one summer camp. Tightening her grip, she risked a gaze at the other side and blocked all additional memories, before the torrential rain would pour from her eyes. Then, she observed her father, wondering if he had a good childhood, unlike her.

The family already exited Forest Green, and Sophia progressively fell into silence.

Elizabeth reminded Philippe to stop over at a minimart to buy something for their lengthy trip.

In a little while, Nadine began to sing. It was a type of country song that further aggravated Sophia's sentiments.

Alex joined in and their voices were all over the car, making Sophia, at some point, irritated. Sophia didn't want, of course, to kill the joy weaving through everyone's mouths, but she just didn't find it bearable. Owing to it, she focused her eyes on the pasture land they passed by and sighed it all away.

On their one-hour drive, Philippe, at last, found a grocery store and pulled over.

For Elizabeth, she simply noticed how Sophia remained motionless. Because of it, she asked Sophia what she wanted to buy.

With a very unenergetic voice, Sophia returned a response, "I'm not hungry, Mom." And though seeing Alex and Nadine readily escape the car, Sophia still didn't change her mind. "You go ahead and I'll just... stay here, Mom."

Elizabeth crumpled her forehead. "Hmm…" She disregarded Sophia's reason right away. "You didn't have your dinner last night and breakfast this morning, and do you think I would believe you?"

"Mom, I'm not really hungry."

"Are you sure?"

"Two hundred percent sure, Mom!" Sophia then exaggerated, to finally end her mom's grilling.

"I'll just buy for you, then. I don't want you to get an ulcer," Elizabeth said in a smooth voice and got out of the car, too.

On a whim, Sophia put on her earphones and eased herself, through pop music.

After almost half an hour, her family went back to her. She could see how Nadine loaded herself with junk food as if she could munch them, all throughout their entire way home.

Now, they were on the go again. Sophia stuck at being serene until they finally reached Orlando, at past eight in the evening. They were all tired, and none of them had eaten dinner. Instead, they went straight to their bedrooms and slept their tiredness away.

Chapter 8

The Melodies of Yesterdays

SOPHIA'S driving to school was shadowed with guilt. Later today, Giovanni would come to her with all his loving splendor, and she barely knew what to do anymore. Giovanni was the type of boyfriend that every girl could ask for, but it was Jericho who kept on pulling her back.

Making her way to the locker, Giovanni suddenly appeared before her, with a box wrapped in red and laced with a white ribbon.

"For you," he said, smiling.

Her face on fire, Sophia tried to return the same smile, but it felt like her heart would fracture at any moment. The more Giovanni persisted, the more it killed her, and it just didn't feel right anymore. "Thank you. I'll open it later." She slid another smile and quickly avoided Giovanni's stare.

Then Zarah joined them with a rushing announcement. "Hey, you guys, have you heard of the good news?"

"Good news?" The two bestowed her with a puzzled look.

"Ms. Garcia has a leg injury! I heard the principal couldn't find a substitute. Thank God! It's not time for St. Thomas on Critical Thinking!" Zarah was obviously swarming with relief.

"Yeah, we understand you hate logic." Giovanni passed her a mocking, friendly smile.

"And philosophy too," Sophia incorporated, making Zarah the center of their ridicule.

"Hey, you guys! You know I'm not into those kind of things." Zarah made fun of herself, too, and poked Sophia about Forest Green.

"How's Forest Green? Did you have fun?" Zarah asked, and Giovanni listened in with interest.

A negative energy surrounded Sophia for a moment, thinking of words that would echo enjoyment and cover up the name Jericho. There was no way that his name would ever be mentioned, especially with Giovanni's presence. And so, she brightened up her face and said, "It was fine," adding more and more liveliness to her voice.

"That's good. And Alex?" Zarah's face immediately turned serious. She was aware of Alex's Waterloo for girls. "Don't tell me, he spent some time with some girls there!"

"Of course, not! My brother will always be loyal to you," Sophia defended her brother but the word *loyal* somewhat slid a lump on her throat.

"Yeah, where is that guy, by the way?" Giovanni, finally said some words.

"In his Social Science class, maybe."

Zarah's assumption went wrong when Alex hastily joined them.

"Giovanni, I saw this posted. Battle of the Bands, bro! What do you say?" Alex handed Giovanni a flyer that was almost torn apart.

"Cool, bro! This will be a lot of fun!" Giovanni agreed laughing, giving Alex a high-five.

"Wow! That's interesting!" The two girls slipped in, with glee too.

"Practice at the house, bro!" Alex offered, exceedingly excited. After a long wait, another award would add up to the hundred of trophies their band had received since grade school.

"Yeah, at the garage," Sophia uttered and they all laughed at it.

When school was over that day, Alex and Giovanni waited for Sophia and Zarah at the parking lot, along with the rest of their band.

"So, what do you think of the song?" Shall we compose one?" Alex asked the guys.

"Yeah! More points if we have our own song," Giovanni put forward.

"All right! So, what would be the theme of the song?" Rambo, their arrogant bass guitarist, asked.

"About heartbreak, perhaps?" Alex proposed.

"Heartbreak? Dude, come on!" they grumbled sniggering.

"Come on! It's what girls want to listen to."

"Whatever, dude!"

"Hey, Rambo! Jasmine just dumped you, right? I guess you would be the perfect one to write the lyrics!" Alex hit back.

"Wait a minute, dude! No! I don't write down my heartbreaks!" Rambo shrugged more arrogance.

Their banter was fettered as soon as Sophia and Zarah came to them, endowing them a grin of curiosity because the guys were laughing out loud.

"Okay, the princesses are already here!" Alex clogged the giggling, and at the same time, asked everyone to already get into their cars.

They arrived at the Vabueretti residence in almost an hour, and rushed straight to the garage. All their musical instruments were still there, after several months of no-rehearsals for causing an earsplitting noise throughout the entire neighborhood. They initiated playing them yet again, and echoed the same loud noise that would definitely irritate the folks around.

"I think they need some refreshments," Sophia spoke to Zarah, feeling like they needed to leave the guys.

"Aha," Zarah nodded, and they went to the kitchen.

Alex, at a snap of a second, remembered he used to write a song before. He ran the lyrics through his mind and quickly wrote them down on a white paper, including the guitar chords.

Then, his bandmates read the lyrics as they listened to him with his acoustic guitar.

Intro: C-G-Am-F

I.
C G Am F
I know when you'll come and go again
C G Am F
Maybe when tomorrow comes, it won't be the same
C G Am F
He's here and now he's waiting for you to come back
C G Am F
And But baby I just can't let you go with him again

Chorus 1:
C G Am F
After some time, I'll try to give up
C G Am F
I can see now that I have no more space

II. C-G-Am-F
It hurts but I have to let you go, my love
Now that my love is not enough
I have to move on
'Cause things are not like before,
they totally changed (Chorus 1)

Bridge:
Am C
I'll see you crawling
Am C
I'll see you falling
Am C
I'll see you knocking on my door
Am C
Oh, I don't have to be hurt
F G
All over, all over again

Chorus 2: C-G-Am-F
Hopefully, someone will rescue me
Who will love me and treat me
like a king in my empire

Everyone liked it. Quick as a flash, they began playing his song.

Sophia and Zarah were, of course, very supportive to the guys, but throughout every strumming of guitar and crooning of every lyric, Sophia couldn't — by far — forget those pleasing melodies of yesterdays, of how Jericho sang before her, along with the songs he wrote for her. Though she did try, the ghosts of Forest Green just kept on haunting her.

Chapter 9

The Battle of Kravena

IN the prosperous Tribe of Kravena, the tribe members abounded with activities, preparing for tonight's merriment. The mang-aanis had a bountiful harvest of sinapoy for that season and Datu Ilak announced a grand night of thanksgiving.

Abanir was outside the palasyon, of his own accord, to help the workers.

"Abanir, my son! Why are you helping the hakaros?" Reyna Kaya asked him, seeing how he exerted all his muscles carrying a bulky pile of firewood into the fireplace. "You're supposed to be preparing your speech," she proceeded.

"Ila, I have nothing else to do so I decided to help them," Abanir said humbly. "Besides, for tonight's speech, I'll speak from what comes from my heart. No need for flowery words," he smiled. "I am enjoying the hakaros' company, by the way. They are very friendly."

Reyna Kaya's face brightened. "I am glad you care for your fellow Kravena, my son, although you're not supposed to be doing that." Reyna Kaya's eyes unexpectedly oozed with tears, couldn't help but remember the old days of her slavery. "I'll leave you now," she managed to whisper before memories could engulf her.

Abanir forced a grin, self-questioning why his mother turned emotional, when a female Kravena in her finery passed by in front of him, trying to get his attention.

"Oh, Tiyana!" greeted Abanir, quite startled to see her one foot away from him.

"My Raha, a pleasant day!" Tiyana bowed her head down with all her poise. "It is my pleasure to perform tonight! Thank you for choosing me!"

Abanir was put to a sudden halt. He never chose her, but since she was the daughter of the datu's top kansilo, he decided to accommodate her, well. "Oh, yes! Splendid! Such a delight to hear your sweet, amazing, awe-inspiring voice." Abanir gestured while speaking. He knew she had a huge admiration on him.

A drum roll was heard from Tiyana's chest. It was too loud that finally turned Abanir uneasy. However, Tiyana continued her intentions, to own all of the raha's attention.

"Thank you, my Raha. I guarantee you won't be disappointed." Tiyana flashed a widening smile.

His look going distant, Abanir arranged every piece of firewood and endeavored listening to every detail of Tiyana's preparation for the thanksgiving.

Tiyana, somehow, discerned the raha's detached guise, so she left graciously and began feeling that their tête-à-tête was out of his interest.

The thanksgiving venue was all set, and it was now late afternoon. The place was roofed with coconut leaves, and bamboos served as the framework. The seats and tables were freshly prepared from acacia trunks, while a few of sweet-smelling orchids were hung above them.

Abanir was indulging himself with the sight when Rabel hastily approached him, badly shaking, reporting about the presence of two Sulabuns at the Samo River, the boundary of Kravena and Fegratu.

On a whim, Abanir flew to the river to confirm it. He saw not only two Sulabuns, and it was now the sign that their long-time fear had finally arrived. Then, he went back to Kravena faster than a whirlwind.

Datu Banaak had been planning to attack Kravena. He could no longer wait to devastate the tribe and put it under his territory. When he learned of the Kravenas' thanksgiving, he assumed it to be the perfect night for their attack.

Arriving at the palasyon, Abanir immediately informed Datu Ilak.

Upon hearing it, Datu Ilak straight away called his top bunjaos and prepared them for the possible attack of the Sulabuns. He ordered them to bring out the pile of deadly arrows that were long-time secured and distribute them wisely.

On the double, the bunjaos set into action.

Alas! Death would be in the firmament because the lethal arrows were out, and the antidote, the Ovaweh Falls, was for a lengthy time now, petered out.

"Do not hesitate to hit every foe with an arrow!" Datu Ilak ordered. He assigned Abanir to lead the lookout at Harem Falls, the region of Kravena territory facing the Tribe of Sulabun, and Karan at the Samo River, the western part of their territory.

Datu Ilak and the rest of the warriors stayed in the focal terra firma of their tribe to protect the females and the young ones, including Reyna Kaya and Sesa Sanaya. The pugad served as their hiding place. It was located underground, covered with wild grasses and had a secret path to the Samo River.

The nightfall gradually came, and every Kravena was vigilant for the attack.

A piece of burning arrow from the shadowy sky suddenly landed on the ground.

When the Kravenas saw it, they knew it was already the start of the battle. It was then followed by loads of burning arrows. The Kravenas, in return, prepared their arrows and started striking, with utmost effort.

The Sulabuns terrifyingly came out from the giant trees and began attacking.

The Kravenas fought back and blood started to drench the terrain.

Away from the heart of Kravena, one could easily see the raging flames scattered throughout the shadows of the night. One could clearly hear the echoing cries, as the fires continued to grow and consume every house of the tribe.

All through the haze of smoke and resonance of terror, Abanir and his faction rushed to the site.

By the Samo River, Karan and his group were guarding when the Sulabuns, together with Datu Banaak and his son, Raha Kalib, from nowhere, attacked them.

The Sulabuns were dynamic and heedful that many Kravenas fretted and stepped back.

Sepe Karan forcefully fought back with his bolo, felling several Sulabuns. The rest of his followers endured, impeding the flurry of trepidation flagging them.

The battle persisted throughout the night.

Suddenly, the sky was filled with flashes of lightning and heavy rain threatened to fall from the dense clouds.

Every warrior—from both tribes—shrank back! The fiery thunderbolts frenzied silhouettes!

Stab after stab, release after release of noxious arrows, came and went… and then, the earth gradually fell into stillness.

Alas! The Kravenas were on the verge of losing the fight!

At the heart of the thunderstorm, the Sulabuns could scarcely fly. Their wings were quite smaller and more sunken than the Kravenas, causing grievance to their wings. Hence, fleeing was a choice they must pursue.

Still, Karan clashed against Kalib, both aimed to win the fight. Karan had the chance to stab his bolo unto Kalib but Kalib was strong enough to stop him.

The driving force of Karan that pushed Kalib, now Kalib was rolled around the ground. Karan was about to stab him through the heart when Datu Banaak saw his son losing the fight.

Datu Banaak quickly prepared his poisonous arrow and pointed it at Karan. As soon as another thunderbolt illuminated the entire place, Karan was hit through the heart and fell down to the ground.

Then, the Sulabuns began escaping, for their smaller wings were, at that time, very much damaged by the heavy rainfall.

The Kravenas, altogether, gathered, to aid their adored sepe, but he was already losing too much blood.

With a heavy moan, Karan took his last breath.

His followers then knew of his passing and grieved.

"Farewell, our dearly loved Sepe!" they cried enormously.

"Farewell!"

They were extremely weakened and fearful to take his body to the palasyon but they must not dwell on their lamentations. They had to take their much-loved sepe to the palasyon.

Datu Ilak was devastated upon seeing the dead body of his beloved son. His entire family was, too, as every Kravena gathered to console the royal family.

It was a night of mourning for every Kravena. Cold hearts were felt, everywhere! The valour of Kravena wilted into dust! They, had lost their fathers, brothers, husbands, sons—all their loved ones.

Chapter 10

The Night

THE first day of summer came at last, and the most awaited Battle of the Bands was on.

The stadium was full and the crowd was exceptionally loud, cheering for their favorite bands. Sophia and Zarah were screaming at the top of their lungs. They had done so much preparations for the guys, from promoting the band through social media down to their outfits.

Twenty bands competed that night, and each of them had impressed the crowd. Giovanni stood as the vocalist because George, their front man, had an unexpected sore throat. Fortunately, Giovanni created an impact on the judges and grabbed their interest.

The announcement of the winner was almost near, and everyone was on the brink, already predicting Zion to be the champion.

Zarah and Sophia were holding their hearts from too much excitement when Philippe called his daughter.

"Dad!" Sophia tried to speak louder to overcome the crowd's noise.

"Honey, what time will the contest end? It's almost twelve and I'm kind of worried." Philippe's voice was obviously troubled.

"It's almost over, Dad! They're actually about to announce the winner now," Sophia was saying when she saw the announcer climbed the stage. "I have to go now, Dad. I promise we'll come home after this!"

"All right! Get home in an hour," Philippe sighed uneasily.

Sophia flung a brief laugh. "Bye, Dad."

The announcer had finally spoken and thanked every participant for their outstanding performances. At long last, he declared the year's champion and it was... Zion.

Incredibly, the entire band and the girls jumped to their euphoria—loudly yelling. Then, the guys headed to the stage to receive their trophy and cash prize, and Sophia and Zarah took a thousand of photos of them.

When the awarding ended, the guys went back to the girls and handed them their awards.

"Congratulations! You made it!" the girls hailed.

"Yeah! We made it, guys!" Giovanni cheered and wrapped his hands around Sophia's shoulders.

"I guess I have to stop this joyfulness for a while," Sophia told Alex. "Dad called and he asked us to go home right away." She said it evidently that the rest overheard her.

"Yeah, daddy is already worried!" Zarah joked, still at the peak of her enjoyment.

"All right! Let's go home, then. And tomorrow, let's have a huge party!" Alex encroached, and the rest roared in agreement.

They exited the stadium and said their goodbyes.

Rambo was about to get a cab when Alex saw him and stopped him.

"Why are you riding a cab?" Alex asked.

"Man, I'm grounded by dad! I actually escaped tonight!" Rambo grumbled.

"Oh, man! That's too bad!"

"What can I say, man?" Rambo poked fun of himself.

"You know what? Why don't you take my car?" Alex offered.

"No! I can't do that! And what are you going to use, if I take it?"

"Hitch into Giovanni's!"

Rambo was put to a pause. "No, dude. I'll take a cab and, hey, thanks for your offer!"

"No, man! I mean it! Take my car and… just don't forget to return it tomorrow," Alex insisted, laughing.

Rambo eventually agreed. "All right! Thanks, man!"

"No problem, bro! No scratch, okay?" Now, Alex handed him his car keys.

"Right! Thanks again." Rambo ended their conversation with a high-five and excitedly entered Alex's car.

"Why did he take your car?" Zarah approached Alex.

Giovanni and Sophia followed them and asked the same question.

"He's grounded." Alex turned to face them. "Would it be fine if Zarah and I will join you?" Alex talked to Giovanni.

"Sure, dude!"

"All right! I think we better get home now!" Alex then ensued.

On their way, along with a low-volume rock music, Alex and Zarah began kissing at the back seat.

"Whoa! Not in my car, guys!" Giovanni made fun of them.

Seated beside Giovanni, Sophia was just smiling.

Reckless, himself, Giovanni concentrated his eyes on Sophia, and with a stare, like he was wanting to kiss her, too.

"Get your eyes back on the road, Gio," Sophia demanded.

Giovanni ignored her, kept on staring at her, and started to kiss her.

Sophia begged him to stop and reminded him to keep his eyes on the road, but suddenly, without them knowing it, a hasty pickup truck, driven by a drunken man, bumped their car.

There was a strong impact—a loud sound of collision, and their car rolled around to the side of the road. Everything ended with a cloud of dust and smoke.

Ring, ring, ring!

"Honey, please get the phone," Elizabeth begged her husband, her voice sounding drowsy and out of sorts.

Philippe unwillingly turned the lamp on and answered the phone. He was extremely shocked by what he just heard! Their children were brought to the hospital and they were in critical condition!

Philippe told Elizabeth right away.

Taken aback, a volcano of weeping was about to erupt from Elizabeth. She could not believe what she just heard.

Philippe reminded her and asked her to hurry, for they had to go to Orlando General Hospital.

They were in a crying rush, and they brought Nadine with them.

Along the way, Elizabeth was consistently asking her husband to drive faster.

Philippe was on it and explained that he was already at the maximum speed.

Panicking tremendously, Elizabeth kept on uttering words just to unload the heaviness from her chest.

"Mom… Dad… what's happening?" Nadine, from the back, risked to ask, already pulsating with what she was seeing and hearing from her parents.

"My kids!" Elizabeth sobbed.

"Let's pray for them at the moment!" Philippe comforted Elizabeth. He looked at Nadine and asked her to be calm.

"What do you mean calm? Our kids are in danger, Philippe! How can you ask her to be calm?" Elizabeth sobbed angrily.

Philippe ignored his wife. He understood the situation very well and instead, struggled to focus on the road until they reached the hospital.

Philippe immediately parked the car.

They hurried to the emergency room and discovered that Giovanni's and Zarah's parents were already there, howling as they waited outside the emergency room.

At the height of their worry, they prayed together and eased each other's worry, as they waited for the doctors to come out.

After few minutes, a doctor approached them. He was looking for Giovanni's parents.

"I'm sorry Mr. and Ms. Habendard! Your son did not make it!" grieved Doctor Balauren.

The couple, not believing what they just heard, fell to the ground and wept loudly.

Philippe's and Elizabeth's worries turned for the worse. They could no longer wait for the other doctors to come out from the ER. They were shaking and terribly weakened. In spite of it, they managed to approach Giovanni's parents and consoled them.

Zarah's parents were also on the verge of collapsing. Zarah's father started to yell and even punched the concrete wall to relieve himself of his fear and agony.

Finally, the other doctors came out and talked to them. They told them that Sophia was critical while Alex and Zarah were not that severely injured, compared to Sophia.

For not too long, two cops came and clarified that Alex and Zarah were at the back seat that was why they were not that injured, compared to Sophia and Giovanni who were seated in front.

When Philippe and Elizabeth visited Alex, they were distressed to see him. He was unconscious and pitiful.

Zarah's parents also went to see Zarah and were very much saddened by their daughter's appearance. Like Alex, she looked terrible.

Sophia, meanwhile, was transferred to the intensive care unit.

A wake for Giovanni was held. His classmates, bandmates, and everyone who knew him were all there. They could not believe that their good friend was, by now, gone.

To pay his respects, Philippe attended the funeral service although he had not yet recovered from what happened to his children, especially to Sophia.

It was a day of grief for everyone. The night of success and supposed celebration turned into a moment of shock and unbelievable pain.

Chapter 11

The Cry of Hearts

IT had been days and the Vabuerettis were still at the hospital.

Sophia was now comatose.

Philippe stayed at Alex's room while Elizabeth and Nadine at Sophia's.

Alex was already conscious at that time and still in shock at what he learned. He was shattered after knowing of Giovanni's passing, could not believe that his best friend was gone. Then, he asked about Sophia and Zarah.

His father explained that Zarah was fine but his sister was comatose.

Torn apart, Alex lamented all day. He even blamed himself for what happened, for it was his idea to join the contest.

Philippe called his mother and told her what happened to Alex and Sophia.

Very much worried for her grandchildren, Grandma Lucy asked Bea to pack their things right away and to accompany her to Orlando.

Bea was in shock, too, but she coped and immediately packed their things.

It was sunset when they were all set to leave Forest Green but Joey, Grandma Lucy's driver, was not feeling well.

Impatient to see her grandchildren in the hospital, Grandma Lucy requested Bea to look for someone who could drive for them.

Unfortunately, most of their workers were on-leave that day and had gone home to their families.

Desperate, Bea looked for Reuben, their gardener who happened to be a third-degree cousin of Jericho.

Reuben was hanging out with Jericho when Bea found him at Forest Grill, the town's popular diner.

"Aunt Bea! You seem so tense!" Reuben was startled to see Bea in panic mode.

"Alex and Sophia had an accident. Alex is fine now but Sophia is comatose and we need you to drive us to Orlando," Bea explained, aware of Jericho's presence. "Lucy is terribly worried for her grandchildren."

Shocked and worried about what he just heard, Jericho, all of a sudden, grasped Bea's shoulders, looked her in the eye, and asked where Sophia was admitted.

"Orlando General Hospital!" Bea answered, shaking.

Jericho screamed his heart out. He wanted to see Sophia right away, but he knew he couldn't.

Then, Reuben and Bea left him and went to Grandma Lucy.

It took them twelve hours to arrive in Orlando General Hospital. Straight away, Grandma Lucy and Bea entered the hospital, while Reuben was left in the car.

Very soon, Jericho called Reuben and asked him about Sophia's condition.

"I honestly have no clue yet but by the sound of Grandma Lucy's voice, I can tell Sophia's kind of critical." Reuben exerted his best to deliver it, uncomplicated.

Jericho grew weak and almost shrunk to the ground. "This must not happen to her," he howled, and threw his cell phone to the wall, crashing it. "I love her. I never had the chance to tell her how much I love her! How I planned my life around her and with her!" Jericho, falling into the pool of his own sorrows, grew worn out.

Inside the hospital, Philippe's and Elizabeth's heavy loads were lessened when they finally saw Grandma Lucy and Bea.

"Oh, thank God!" Elizabeth dashed to receive Grandma Lucy's embrace.

Immediately, Grandma Lucy asked for her grandchildren.

Straight off, Philippe and Elizabeth led her first to Alex's room.

Seeing Alex, Grandma Lucy cuddled him intensely. The moment she let go of the tight embrace, Grandma Lucy, without preamble, asked where Sophia was.

Consequently, Philippe accompanied her to Sophia's room.

Setting her eyes on her pitiful granddaughter, Grandma Lucy cried at once. "I never thought this would happen to her," she expressed, and broke down into words of prayer.

Bea followed Grandma Lucy in Sophia's room with shivering knees. Upon witnessing how her dearly-loved Sophia looked, with numerous bruises and a distressing number of tubes attached to her, she was thrown to the heights of her own worry.

Father… she prayed silently.

Endlessly, they were all praying for Sophia's condition and fast recovery from coma.

Chapter 12

The Sun Still Rises

IT was almost two months but Sophia was still in a coma. But, she seemed better now. Her family was still firm, still holding on to their hope that, soon, Sophia would wake up from it. They had already transferred her to their family's hospital where she could be given much more medical attention.

For Alex, he had now fully recovered, and was no longer in need of a cane to help him walk.

Elizabeth stayed at her daughter's room while the rest of the Vabuerettis left, after a long day of looking after Sophia. Some of them went to the hospital cafeteria, while others went, just to break the monotony.

Elizabeth stared dearly at her daughter, tenderly wiping Sophia's hands with a wet bath towel, when a sudden resonance of the past hit her head, and she remembered the day when she left Sophia in Forest Green. Sophia was only three-months-old at the time.

Heavens, if only she could return to the mists of the past, to that exact moment when she was standing right in front of Grandma Lucy's door, ready to surrender the infant Sophia to her grandma, thinking that everything would fall back into place, to fix that shameful family dilemma! But it was something that was biting Elizabeth now. Looking at the wounded Sophia, she was almost near the breaking point.

"I am so sorry, Sophia," she cried, kissing Sophia's hand, as if her daughter felt it.

After a moment, she was joined again by her family along with Zarah and her parents. Zarah missed Sophia a lot, and could no longer wait to see her best friend finally open her eyes.

"I really miss my best friend," Zarah expressed, joining Elizabeth in baring her emotions.

Alex hurried to comfort them as he himself stood straight and held back his own tears.

Nadine, the moment she found a space near Sophia's bed, drew closer and began talking to her unconscious sister.

"I have a joke, Sophie, and I wish you'll hear it," Nadine whispered hopefully. "I swear this joke will not annoy you like I always do," she lingered, tripping over her tongue.

When Nadine was about to tell her joke, she noticed her sister's right index finger moved.

"Mom, Dad, Alex, Grandma... did you see it?" Nadine asked them, in a surprised tone.

"What, honey?" Elizabeth pulsated.

"Sophie just moved her finger. I think she's awake," Nadine ensued, already with joy in her voice.

On a split second, all of them got up from their seats and checked Sophia. They were hugely surprised to see her finally opening her eyes.

"Oh, my..." they all cried, greatly grateful, couldn't believe that it was all happening now.

Jubilation was suddenly in the air!

"It's a miracle!" they cried all the more, countlessly thanking the Heavenly Father for such a phenomenon.

Sophia, dizzy and confused, hardly looked at them. Slowly, she gazed around, trying to clear her vague vision. Then, she spoke, "Who are you?"

For a shocking moment, they all turned speechless, not believing what they just heard.

Philippe, as a doctor, already surmised that his daughter had amnesia.

"Where am I?" Sophia asked them again, with a gentle yet frightened voice. "I don't know you!" she piercingly added.

A thunderous crush, and there was a sweeping silence.

Sophia's eyes continued to roll at each and everyone of them. Perturbed by their uneasy reaction, she began to act wildly, and the nurses rushed to aid Philippe in calming her down.

The rest of the family got out of the room temporarily. Stinging silence vanquished them.

"I can't believe this is happening!" Grandma Lucy exploded.

There was, again, silence.

"Mom, can you at least explain to us what's happening to her?" Alex harshly approached Elizabeth, who was seriously frozen at that very moment.

It took ages before Elizabeth responded. With tear-filled, oozing eyes and trembling lips, she spoke, "I think she has... amnesia."

At that, everyone became even more sapped of strength.

As expected, Nadine cheered them up, elucidating that, at least, her sister was now awake and that it would be easy to get her memory back.

Relieved by Nadine's positive thinking, they finally tried to calm themselves down, and clung to those hopes.

* * *

IN KRAVENA, sorrow and fear still filled the heart of every tribe member.

Abanir and his family were still in mourning for Karan.

In the face of it, Datu Ilak had to be strong for the tribe, for his family. He must not dwell on his lamentations.

He ordered his kansilos to think of an improved scheme to fight the Sulabuns and forced his warriors to pursue harder.

Abanir pushed himself to the edge. He wanted to be stronger than he was. He wanted vengeance for his brother. Most of the time, he would find himself floating, bordered with intense agony and impatience to defeat the enemies. He frequently flew away from Kravena and wandered alone.

While roving around one night, he got thirsty and landed at the lake near the Vabueretti lake house. Sipping water through the palms of his hands, he caught himself taking a sight at the house. It reminded him of the strange creature, of Sophia. Her unusual body gestures flashed back to him, all at once, capturing the look of her frightened face when she unexpectedly saw him, that peaceful night. His sorrow subsided at that moment—realizing that such an unlikely creature would help his misery to fade away.

Cautiously, he went near the lake house and did not see anyone moving. It was dark and quiet. He attempted to enter it but it was securely closed. Then, he flew gently to the terrace where he saw the strange creature. Looking down, a white piece of cloth caught his sight. It was Sophia's shawl that she dropped when she surprisingly saw him that night. Abanir, unhesitatingly, picked it up. He could smell the scent of blooming flowers from it.

For a pleasurable moment, he lingered, observing the fabric. He was about to put it back on the balcony table when the harsh sound of a coming car sidetracked him. On impulse, he flew back to Kravena, with it, unable to leave the fabric, and wondering enormously at the object that had just caused the sound.

A drunken man ruthlessly got out of the car. It was Jericho. He just came from the town's popular grill and drowned himself with liquor. His desolation worsened because he overheard about Sophia's amnesic condition. He knew that Sophia's loss of memory would completely separate her from him.

Jericho dragged himself into the lake house front porch and sat by the rocking chair. Sighing, he remembered the days when he and Sophia were playing around the front yard, when they were almost inseparable. They were there, secretly playing every time Sophia was scolded by Grandma Lucy. She would let go of all her emotions there, with him. She would cry on his shoulders. And to perk Sophia up, he would ask her to climb the trees and swim with him at the lake.

The lake house was Jericho's greatest link to Sophia. All the memories from it only intensified his raging longing, for her.

Chapter 13

Cocoon

THE waiting became almost unbearable when Sophia finally opened her eyes and gawked at her family. They were all there to offer her a grand breakfast, along with their shimmering and hopeful smiles.

Childlike, Sophia squeezed her eyes shut and tried to understand things in the midst of oblivion. Then, she rolled her eyes at everyone, and finally came to realize that maybe, they were her family indeed.

"Are you my family?" she asked, in a very small voice.

Up close, they glowed and nodded, agreeing silently.

In her highest spirits, Grandma Lucy rushed to hug her, and there was no way that Sophia could ever make a move, for she was entirely buried.

Is she? Sophia thought and lingered looking at the rest, with more questions in her mind that needed immediate answers.

Elizabeth feasted her eyes on her daughter, and couldn't wait for Grandma Lucy to finally release her, so she could embrace her, too.

The Vabuerettis came to her, one by one, and introduced themselves, in the easiest way they could.

"Your name is Sophia," Elizabeth told her daughter, with a smile that hovered between delight and sympathy. "You are a kind and lovable daughter, and also an adorable sister to Alex and Nadine," she added as she pointed her finger at Alex and Nadine, respectively.

"Welcome back, Sophie!" Nadine cheered, at the top of her voice. "I miss you tickling me because of my nasty jokes about you," she said, simpering.

They all laughed at what Nadine said, perhaps swayed by their combined gladness and excitement, for Sophia.

Sophia's face crumpled, and she looked at Nadine deeply, trying her best to recognize her.

"You are such a clown, Nad," Alex praised Nadine and muddled her hair gently. "How blessed we are to have you! You're such an angel!"

Nadine laughed, and everyone was enchanted by such good rapport arising from all of them. To keep it going, Bea offered them some muffins.

Bea's scene-steal captivated Sophia's attention. Sophia looked at her for so long, and wondered who she was in her life.

Bea just flashed her a smile but behind it were her sympathy… and hidden hopes.

* * *

IN FOREST GREEN, Jericho instantaneously got up and found himself sleeping at the lake house, in the front porch. He was surprised at where he just got himself into. Fortunately for him, there were no people who visited the lake house. He looked around and saw an empty bottle of whisky beside him.

Oh, man! What have I done? He scratched his head.

He immediately stood up, took the empty bottle, and started his car. Then, he was back to the reality that Sophia didn't remember him anymore. His heart was breaking, but he had to go back to the town proper, to his responsibility as one of the town's doctors. But how could he ever do the same things again when he couldn't even be responsible for his own self? Now, there were no more bridges to Sophia's life! Memories were the only ones that linked them, and her amnesia was just the dead-end, for them both, now…

He was blank while driving when his car went slower and slower, not knowing, that he was now running out of gas.

"Nice!" He banged the steering wheel in irony. Walking, now, was a choice he must pursue. He got out of the car and called Sophia's name again and again. He neared the cliff and called her name even louder.

Amidst those screams were nothing but echoes.

"Sophia, I miss you!" he cried. He was too lost so that he didn't notice that the sun finally settled in the west. He just stayed there until a vehicle's light kindled, before his very eyes. It was Reuben, searching the whole town for him.

"There you are!" Reuben's exhausted voice resonated concern. "I've been looking all over for you. I knew you would be in the lake house," he sighed, shaking his head, with its fine, aging lines.

Still in pain, Jericho joined him in his truck and begged him for another shot of tequila.

* * *

AFTER MANY SESSIONS of therapy and various tests, Sophia was finally allowed to leave the hospital.

Alex and Nadine, to compensate for things, had prepared a superb welcome-back party for their sister. They invited Zarah and almost everyone who knew Sophia.

When they arrived home, Sophia was surprised to see people of her age coming to hug her. Tired and confused, she did not bother walking out of the party and she, somehow, enjoyed everyone's company.

Zarah and some of their classmates sang for her, hoping to flash back into her mind the same scenarios of yesterdays.

That entire night, Sophia appeared like a butterfly emerging from its cocoon, too soon to open its wings and fly away, and as the event progressed, her parents watched her from time to time, sneakily, hoping for her return to her old self!

Chapter 14

The Awakening

A sonata of laughs echoed from downstairs when Elizabeth opened one eye and saw the light of the progressing morning. She looked over to her side and found Philippe, still wrapped as if grease in the cold. He looked exceptionally drained, a reasonable state for a father who had been on-and-off the hospital to take good care of Sophia.

Groaning sleepily, Elizabeth followed the echoes until she was led to the dining room. There her mother-in-law and Bea were, preparing for breakfast.

"Good morning!" Grandma Lucy greeted her and pampered herself with the aroma of Darjeeling tea.

Despite her lack of sleep, Elizabeth managed a cheerful face. The brighter it became when Nadine ran to her, like craving for chocolates.

"Mommy." Nadine clung firmly to her shoulders, giving this kitten-like look that was too hard to resist.

"Hello there, kiddo." Grandma Lucy beamed, looking at Nadine. "How was your sleep?"

"It was fine, Gran." Nadine went to her seat and looked for Sophia.

"Oh, honey! She's still in bed," Elizabeth replied and served her a bowl of choco flakes.

Then, Alex joined them.

"I still miss her, Mom." Nadine, all of sudden, sent a stare of pining.

"Oh, sweetie! Your sister is here now." Elizabeth palmed Nadine's hair and poured sterilized filled milk into her cereal. "And she's not going anywhere, all right?"

Nadine's grimace slowly turned into a smile. "All right," she nodded, agreeing, and began a spoonful.

Sophia was still in bed, staring vacantly around her. The surrounding was new and it never felt like she had missed it, never felt that it had always been linked to her all her life. She reached out for some photo frames on the desk and saw nothing but herself. She went to the window and slid back the curtains. The rising sun radiated through her skin, and she wished her memory could shine through, too.

Lost in thought, a drawer that seemed very special emerged, in her senses. She went to open it and saw a diary, with a piece of photo inserted between the pages. She took it and saw a good-looking guy kissing her cheeks.

Her mind was in rainstorm now!

To clear things out, she opened the diary and saw two male names written: Jericho and Giovanni. She went to the last entry and discovered it was almost three months ago. Raring to know who he was, she went to her mother, only to hear the sound of talking voices from the dining room.

"There you are! The princess has awakened!" Philippe, who just joined the family for breakfast, noticed Sophia's shadow.

"Princess? Really, Dad?" Nadine reacted, kind of jealous, in the way she asked it.

"Oh! Are you jealous, Nadine?" Alex cracked a joke.

"Of course, not!" Nadine turned defensive.

The fight was cut as soon as Sophia went near them, with a face that needed to be cleared immediately. "I wonder if you know this guy, with me in this picture," she said, while handing it to them.

Across the silence, everyone looked at each other.

"Is he?" Sophia managed to talk again, halfway between crying and excitement, and asking for some answers. "I saw it when I opened my diary and... I wonder if he is my... boyfriend."

Silence overtook the room, once again.

Then, Alex immediately stood up and left the dining room. His conscience was killing him. He knew it was Giovanni and he just didn't find it bearable to answer her.

Sophia wanted an answer right away but her brother's walk-out scene, somewhat bothered her.

Elizabeth initiated a motion towards Sophia, while battling with herself, regarding how to say it. She knew her daughter had the right to know everything, but it felt like it wasn't the right time, not now that Sophia had just come back from coma.

"Sophia, he's Giovanni... your boyfriend." Elizabeth finally unwrapped a portion of her Pandora box.

"Where is he, Mom? Does he know I'm here?"

Sophia's seeking for answers put Elizabeth to the snapping point. But Elizabeth wasn't the only one. The rest was also on the brink, searching for the right words, to answer Sophia.

"And why did Alex leave?" Sophia proceeded. "Is there something wrong?"

Once again, everyone was unspeaking.

"Why are you not answering me?" Now, Sophia's voice quivered. "Mom, I'm asking you. Where is he?"

"Sophia, please, calm down for a while. We will explain to you everything but… this is not the right time to tell you everything!" Philippe finally talked, with a sidestepping look, then realized it was a stupid response.

"What do you mean, Dad?" Sophia's tone was probing.

Uncomfortable yet bold enough, Grandma Lucy spoke, "He's… he's already gone, Sophia!"

An aching moment passed. All eyes were unblinking!

"He passed away when you had your car accident," Grandma Lucy further said, forcing her nerves to be strong with the truth.

Shaken, tears immediately streamed down Sophia's face. It was all hard to process so that she almost fell down to the floor, and felt as if her mind would separate from her body.

"Sophia, honey, listen," Elizabeth implored.

Disbelieving, Sophia ran to her room and locked herself… crying, struggling to breathe, to understand, to remember Giovanni… but, all the while, the entirety of herself was shouting for more truth, and for the return of her memory.

She had a boyfriend. But now he was gone. Forever gone.

Grandma Lucy could not leave the city for Forest Green. She knew that Sophia was unstable, and it felt more important to focus on her than on anything else. She begged for Bea's help—to go back to Forest Green and to take good care of their trades, and to ensure that someone was there to do decisions, on her behalf. Bea willingly agreed, and she planned to leave the following day.

Sophia lamented all day.

Her worried parents had been knocking on her door, but she just couldn't bear the thought that she'd lost Giovanni. Although she remembered nothing about him, she knew in her heart that she had loved him.

Midnight was arriving, and Alex was not yet home. He hadn't been answering his cell phone and nothing served as a sign of his whereabouts.

Worried, Philippe and Elizabeth sought for police help. Grandma Lucy was very more worried, so that she almost had a heart attack.

Elizabeth's dense emotions worsened. She couldn't risk to hear more bad news. She was fully stretched to the breaking point, and one more strain would finally drop her right into the brink of sanity.

Subsequently, a call seized their attention.

Philippe hastened to answer it, and was informed of Alex's arrest, for driving under the influence of alcohol.

Hurrying to fix their son's mess, Philippe and Elizabeth used up all their remaining strength and asked Grandma Lucy to look after the girls.

It was already dawn when the couple arrived home. Alex was still at the precinct and he would be released after twenty four hours.

Philippe and Elizabeth went upstairs and discovered Nadine's absence in her room. They opened Sophia's door and were eased to see the girls peacefully sleeping on the same bed. Philippe held Elizabeth's hand and let loose the knots squeezing his heart. "We have to be strong for our family," he said, almost into tears.

Elizabeth agreed and cried on his shoulders, quietly. "We're going to get through this."

They eased each other, further, and finally, walked to their room.

Sophia was dreaming at that moment. She was seeing herself in an abandoned garden, surrounded by wonderful butterflies that soon turned into wild crows.

Awakened, Sophia almost leaped out from bed. With sweat soaking her clothes, she went to the bathroom and washed her face.

What a nightmare! She faced herself in the mirror. Then, she went to change her garments, catching a glimpse of her sister who looked like oil in frostiness. She tried to go to sleep again, but she was still bothered by her nightmare. Then, a hint inside of her made her read her diary. Unintentionally, she opened the part… when they visited Forest Green a few months ago.

Dear Diary,

I don't know what to feel after seeing Jericho. When I saw him, I was delighted but it came to a point that I wished I never saw him that day. I hate myself for everything I've done to him. But when I looked at him, everything was refreshed. He is handsome and adorable, as always. I know I did not have to feel that way. I'm with Giovanni now. I know he loves me in ways that I could never imagine. But I don't know why I felt that way when I saw Jericho.

Oh, please, Diary! Please, don't tell me that I'm going insane. This is not right but... ~~I wanted to kiss him~~ Yes, Diary, I wanted to kiss him the moment I set eyes on him again. His eyes and lips were very begging. Oh! It reminds me of the night he climbed my grandma's terrace. His touch... that touch of him that weakened me! And his kiss... that kiss of him that took me to a

place I could never describe! It was my very first time. I know I was young. But it was a kiss that I will always treasure.

I am confused, Diary. I am confused. I love Giovanni and I always will. But Jericho, oh, God! I can't stop thinking of him! Please, tell me what to do, Diary. I know I should not feel this way.

Till then...

Love, Sophia

An unwelcome teardrop fell onto her diary.

Who are you, Jericho? Sophia pondered, squeezing her eyes shut from tears that lingered, overflowing, now.

That was a slice of her heart! It only meant she betrayed Giovanni, and it just shattered her.

She shut those eyes again and struggled to grasp for more air, when suddenly, her diary fell off her lap, its pages turning quickly to the previous marked ones. She picked it up and saw the part saying,

I can't believe what I saw that night at the lake house. I was frightened. Those beautiful... white feathers! They were astounding. I want to make myself believe that it was not real but it bothers me. At first, I thought that I was kind of mental but I was not. It was real, diary. It was real.

Finishing it, Sophia's emotions were hurled to nowhere, all of a sudden. Her mind was at war. Wiping away her tears, she almost woke up Nadine, unwittingly. Then, she rushed to hush her sister, and to arrange her blanket that almost fell to the floor.

Chapter 15

The Blood Compact

IN Sulabun, Datu Banaak forced his son, Kalib, to train harder.

"If I did not see you, you could have been killed!" Datu Banaak screamed at his son. "You are weak, Kalib! You are weak!" he stressed furiously.

Kalib, ashamed of himself, flew away from the tribe, in blazing anger.

Datu Banaak prepared his army for they would visit the Fegratus. He had been planning to visit their tribe to mislead Datu Saak, that they were invaded by the Kravenas and that they needed his tribe's help.

Beyond questions, Datu Saak believed the false information and agreed to Datu Banaak's favor.

As respect and reward for Datu Banaak, Datu Saak prepared a small gathering. Plentiful drinks were served and attractive female Fegratus were splattered all over, to entertain the Sulabuns.

For the two tribes' union, a blood compact was set between the two spearheads.

Datu Banaak took his bolo, had a small cut on his palm, and dropped his blood into a small goblet, and so did Datu Saak. As their blood mixed in it, they cheered and drank it up to the last drop, signifying a strong bond between their tribes against their enemies—the Kravenas. It was accompanied with flamboyant laughs from both groups.

The Fegratus and Sulabuns ultimately spent the rest of the night celebrating their union.

* * *

IN KRAVENA, Abanir was at his chamber, holding the piece of cloth that he got from the lake house.

His hakaro, Rabel, saw it and asked him where he got it.

At first, Abanir was doubtful to reveal the truth but he was eventually swayed.

"Remember the strange creature I told you?" Abanir asked Rabel. "I went back to the place where I saw it and found this." Abanir poured out with qualms. "I did not intend to take it but I heard a strange sound. I was not able to leave it there and now I have it."

Alarmed, Rabel could not believe that his raha went back to the place of humans. He was afraid that some of them could have seen him.

"Raha, when you were there... did someone see you?" Rabel inquired carefully.

"No one, Rabel!"

They kept talking when Sesa Sanaya suddenly overheard them and curiously listened in, to their conversation.

"Rabel, I am still amazed by that strange creature. It's very pleasing to the eyes," admitted Abanir, floating.

"What strange creature?" Sesa Sanaya, without any warning, intervened.

"Sanaya, have you been listening to our conversation?" Abanir was suddenly startled.

"Tell me, sayong! What was that creature?" Sesa Sanaya flooded more of her curiosity. "And what is that... that piece you are holding?" She referred to the bizarre fabric and inspected it thoroughly. "It's strange!"

"This is nothing, sayang!" Abanir speedily answered, tense that Sesa Sanaya might tell it to their ilo.

"With all due respect, my Sesa, it's late and I think you need to go to sleep now. Reyna Kaya might be looking for you," Rabel interceded.

"Ilo will know of this," Sesa Sanaya warned them, before leaving.

The two looked at each other and Abanir was worried that Datu Ilak would find it out.

At the back of Rabel's mind, he knew that Datu Ilak might already know about it, but that he chose to remain silent.

Abanir hid the piece of cloth in his dulsabang and covered it with nests, with his thoughts on the strange creature.

Rabel ogled him for a bit.

"Tomorrow, Rabel, help me with my training!" Abanir requested but he did not hear any response. He then turned around to face his hakaro but to his surprise, Rabel was already snoring. "Oh, Rabel! You are such a very sleepy hakaro!"

Accordingly, Abanir went to his bed of nests and found himself unable to fall asleep. Through the bamboo-made windows, his smitten eyes were concentrated on the glittery sky, until it seemed to completely bare the innocent face of the strange creature.

Chapter 16

Unbending

WHEN Bea returned to Forest Green, she earnestly took good care of everything there. She made sure that things were the same even in Grandma Lucy's absence.

She was gardening the manor's front yard one early morning when a sound of footsteps distracted her from behind. It was Jericho, and Bea was startled to see him.

"Oh, Jericho! What are you doing here?"

"I'm sorry I shocked you! I'm here to ask about Sophia. I heard about what happened. How is she?" Jericho asked determinedly.

"Sophia is fine now but… she lost her memory." Bea slumped her gaze downwards, for she couldn't bear to be seen in tears.

"I know." Jericho managed to reply, his voice sounding like he'd gone through fires and oceans.

Bea found it difficult to stop a tear from dropping, and for a while, they shared a stinging silence.

Desperate enough to see Sophia, Jericho finally had the nerve to ask Bea something, something that—by no doubt—could not be tolerated by her.

"Bea…" Jericho dared, his eyes trying to show courage.

"Yes…?"

"I know this is too much but…" A light in Jericho's eyes, at once, reflected the depths of his yearning, of his forbidden love for Sophia, and Bea plainly felt it.

Still on exposed bundle of nerves, Jericho dared to man up and asked, "Can I get Sophia's city address?"

Bea's face immediately crumpled. "Jericho, whatever it is you're planning... it will only distract Sophia. She's sick and she needs some space at the moment," Bea admitted boldly.

Jericho, though very much frustrated, agreed to what Bea said. "In that case, I have to go now. Thanks, anyway," he said in a low tone.

Bea's guilt instantly consumed her. She was the one who witnessed the two since childhood, and it felt more agonizing to let *it* all just slip away. "Okay! I'll give you her address." She stopped Jericho from leaving. "But promise me that you will be careful when you talk to her, okay?" she grinned, and asked him for a pen and a piece of paper.

Jericho's face impulsively brightened up and he quickly hugged Bea. "Thank you," he almost cried. Then, he hurried to his car to get what she asked of him.

Right after, without any delay, Jericho left in high spirits and set for Orlando.

* * *

IN ORLANDO CITY, at the Vabueretti residence, Philippe and Elizabeth were already back at home together with Alex. The couple had been at the precinct to settle their son's release.

Alex dashed straight to his room, ignoring the people around. He simply had no face to show to anyone.

"Mom, is he gonna be okay?" Nadine asked her parents as she reached them, at the doorway.

"Yes, dear. Your brother will be fine." Elizabeth managed to speak, her eyes puffed-up and her nose totally clogged. Then, she opened her drooping arms to cuddle Nadine. She needed to be strong.

"Mom, where is Sophia?" Philippe asked Grandma Lucy when she reached them at the living room.

"She's in her room. By the way, dinner is ready." Discomfort resonated through Grandma Lucy's voice as she looked at her son and daughter-in-law.

"Sweetie, call your sister and we will have our dinner," Elizabeth ordered Nadine, distracting Philippe's small talk with his mom.

"No, sweetie. Just stay here. I'll go and talk to your sister." Philippe hampered Nadine's forward motion to the stairs.

"All right, Dad," Nadine concurred and hurried to jump into her mother's shoulders again.

On the second floor, Philippe was surprised by Sophia's sudden exit from her room. He could perceive those swollen eyes, as Sophia began to walk down. "Dinner's ready," he offered.

Sophia, pretending she was all right, hesitated, but the concerned tone of her father was too much to resist. She agreed, unspeaking, as she walked down the stairs with her father.

Five cuisines were served before them as they gathered around the table. The feeling of awkwardness crept through Sophia as she settled her back against her chair. They were about to eat when Nadine prompted them all to pray, first.

Amazed, Grandma Lucy asked Nadine to lead the prayer.

When Nadine had said the last words of the prayer, Alex, all of a sudden, came into sight. With all sincerity, he begged for their forgiveness.

"I'm sorry I caused you some trouble," he said, with his eyeballs rolled down.

As every eye on the table watched him, Alex further explained his misbehavior. "I'm sorry. I just can't help but... blame myself for everything that's happened." His voice sounded even more mortified and remorseful.

Not a second passed by that his parents hadn't comforted him. They convinced him, hard, that none of it was his fault.

"Yes, Alex. Please, do not blame yourself," Grandma Lucy reinforced, just now.

But for Sophia, she appeared static, in deep thoughts, after everything she heard from them.

Relieved by everyone's positive response, Alex sat on his chair and leaned back agreeably.

The dinner progressed and in the middle of it, Sophia asked them if she could go out the next day. "I want to visit Giovanni's grave," she expressed, with her long and thick eyelashes slanted down.

"Sure, honey. We will accompany you tomorrow." Elizabeth put on a smile.

Then, Sophia bowed her head down as if seeking for more clarity. Not consuming half of the steamed salmon fish on her plate, she excused herself and went back upstairs.

Alex followed her.

"I'll come with you tomorrow if you don't mind," he offered, hoping to have a fine conversation with his sister, but his gaze failed to meet Sophia's.

Sophia nodded with a grateful smile. "Yes, you may come."

"All right, then!" Alex's face brightened. And he went back to the dining area to finish his meal.

"When will this end?" Nadine flung some sentiments. "Everyone's so dramatic for such a long time now," she expressed, almost into tears.

"Honey, please be patient. Please, try to understand our family's situation, okay?" Elizabeth begged. She understood Nadine very well, but it was too much to ask her, for her young mind to understand. And so, Elizabeth attempted to cheer up Nadine by palming her daughter's cute, ponytailed hair, asking what she wanted to do later, to make her feel cherished, too.

Nadine's eyes revealed more tears. "It's just that... we used to be so happy and now—" Nadine faltered.

On the spur of the moment, with great effort, everybody on the table put all their attention to Nadine and yearned to soothe her muddled young mind.

Chapter 17

The Visit

NOTHING served to comfort Sophia as they made their way to the cemetery. Her hands were shaking, her thoughts were somewhere else, as she sat silently beside Alex at the back seat, while their parents were in front of the car. Nobody dared to make a noise, and there was the sudden need for Nadine's talkativeness. But Nadine was at home, left to accompany Grandma Lucy, while they were away.

It was past nine in the morning when they reached the cemetery, and they were surprised to see a car parked near Giovanni's grave.

Giovanni's ex-girlfriend, Loren, was also there to visit, but when she saw the family coming, she dashed to leave. Her then-unsuitability for Giovanni had been more obvious when she saw the gorgeous Sophia gliding out of the car.

Loren and Giovanni were star-crossed lovers until Sophia walked into St. Thomas Academy, with an aura that she had yet to explore the world. Loren knew that she and Sophia were exact polar opposites. She knew she could never live up to Sophia's beauty and kindness. Not even close. So, she just let Giovanni fall into Sophia's allure. But unfortunately for Loren, Alex saw her and chased her. And this, Loren hated.

"Loren, hey!" Alex yelled, while pursuing her. "I haven't seen you at school for months. Where have you been?"

Loren turned, with no intention of answering his query, but Alex lingered, waiting.

"We're here to visit Giovanni's grave," Alex talked again, with conspicuous grief in his eyes.

"Yes, I see," Loren finally spoke, letting her breath out with rustling impatience.

"I wonder if you want to join us," Alex dared.

"I have to go, Alex." Loren swiftly ended their small talk, and left without looking back.

From afar, Sophia saw her, as if she was absconding from anything dangerous. She wished she'd remembered Loren so she could be more confident to say *hi*, but nothing, so far, really served as a hint. (Sophia never intended to take Giovanni away from Loren. In fact, she never knew about the two of them, never knew if there were other girls in Giovanni's past. All she had in mind before was... she loved Jericho so much that she needed to forget him. And that was the time that Giovanni popped in, at Alex's recommendations, too.)

Sophia approached her brother and asked who the girl was.

"She's Loren, our band's former lead singer. She's here to visit Giovanni's grave," Alex said in detail, with no intention of spilling out that she was actually Giovanni's ex-girlfriend. He knew that Sophia was not yet ready to know more of Giovanni or his past.

Still wondering why Loren left in a cold-blooded way, Sophia watched Loren's back until the latter finally left, with her car.

Alex sat down beside Giovanni's grave, and began reminiscing, in agonizing silence. The more the memories rushed in, the more they seemed to kill him. He tried so hard to ignore the pain, but his conscience demanded to be felt. He was worn into shreds, forcing to gather himself back again, and carry on. Then he looked up at the cloudless blue sky and blinked back those unwanted tears.

Sophia, holding a bouquet of flowers, joined her brother. Slowly, she knelt down, placed the bouquet beside Giovanni's engraved name, and turned even more quiet.

Philippe and Elizabeth remained standing, watching how Sophia traced Giovanni's name on the asphalt tablet. It reminded them so much of Giovanni, of how he had always been polite everytime he would ask Sophia out. He'd always been thoughtful, and always had something to offer on the table everytime he would join the family for a meal.

The Vabuerettis spent one more hour at the cemetery, accompanied with prayers and small laughs, as they recollected more of Giovanni's blissful memoirs with them.

Sophia stayed silent, listening to every word her family was sharing.

"I think we should go now," Philippe suggested suddenly.

Elizabeth looked at her daughter, discerning she was ready to leave, but she could feel the hushed agony in Sophia.

"Sophia." Elizabeth put her hand on her daughter's shoulder, sending Sophia the comfort she needed.

Sophia, after the long wait, stood up as she repeated to herself, Giovanni's name. She wanted to stay longer, but the pain would only lose, if she left, while it was still early.

They were about to leave when a black Audi arrived.

Alex recognized it. "Gio's family is also here to visit," he mumbled, gazing at the slow-moving car.

The Habendards saw them too and went to them immediately. They were all wearing black.

"Mr. and Mrs. Vabueretti, hi!" Giovanni's father greeted them cordially.

"Oh, hello there!" the Vabueretti couple greeted back. "We're here to visit Giovanni's grave."

"I see," Giovanni's father reacted in delight, looking at Sophia with a splodge of pity.

"We're glad you're here!" Giovanni's mother supplemented, also taking a peek at Sophia, who now appeared iced-up, in awkward timidity.

For a while, Alex and Sophia stood with them, wordless as they listened to their parents' conversation with the Habendards. Then, a cute little girl emerged from the car, captivating Sophia's attention. She was Anna, Giovanni's younger sister.

Watching her, Sophia did not need to ask if she was Giovanni's younger sister. Her face already spoke for it.

Anna looked at her too, and passed the same message of grief through her beatific eyes.

Sophia remained staring at her, craving to talk to her, but Giovanni's mom approached Sophia, and blocked her curious look at Anna.

Sophia stiffened as Mrs. Habendard offered her a warm embrace. For a moment or two, they carved up the same longing for Giovanni.

"I pray for your memory to come back," Mrs. Habendard whispered in her ears, as her clasp tightened.

Standing still, Sophia was not able to return a response. Mrs. Habendard's cuddle was intense enough so that it seemed to paralyze every muscle of her mouth.

Coming to Sophia's rescue, Elizabeth thanked Mrs. Habendard and repeated that they were glad to see them again.

"Yes, we share the same thing." Mrs. Habendard finally released Sophia and stepped back to continue her talk with the Vabueretti couple.

"We should be leaving now," Philippe incorporated carefully, noticing the sky turning hotter. "And we're very glad to see you." Now, Philippe handled all the talking, as Sophia and Alex started getting inside the car.

As their car moved, Sophia glanced back at the Habendards, and once more, offered her silent goodbye to Giovanni.

It was lunch time when Philippe saw a Southeast-Asian-looking restaurant. "Hungry?" he asked.

"Yes. Please pull over," Elizabeth responded.

Then, they got inside the diner, noticing its ethnic designs and strange music.

It was all unusual. The people were eating with their bare hands and no one seemed to feel uncomfortable.

"It's the way they eat here. They don't use any utensils," Alex told Sophia under his voice. "It's the attraction of the restaurant, as well as the indigenous kind of music."

Sophia continued, observing. She was distracted when a Filipino waitress recognized her.

"Oh, Ma'am Sophie! You're here! It's been months since you last visited our restaurant." The waitress spoke in a perfect English accent as she led them to a special table.

To her utter surprise, Sophia lost her words.

The waitress' face increasingly crumpled. Typically, Sophia would smile at her. But this time, she seemed different.

"She doesn't remember you. She lost her memory in a car accident," Elizabeth spoke for her daughter, and sat down on a varnished wooden chair.

The waitress, shocked, couldn't make a move. It was ages before she recovered. "I see, ma'am. May I take your order, then?" she finally said.

Sophia looked at her in the eyes and asked, "What did I use to order here?"

"Oh, you and Sir Giovanni always ordered "adobo" and rice, topped with chopped leaves of pandan," the waitress gleefully detailed, unaware of Giovanni's passing away.

Philippe, Elizabeth, and Alex passed a message through their eyes, and quickly turned close-mouthed.

Sophia came to a thorny hush. Knowing that she used to go there with Giovanni, she had enough of emotional torture.

More and more confused, the waitress asked them again about their order.

"Okay, give us then that "adobo" and rice," Philippe demanded without more ado, in hopes of cutting the creeping awkwardness.

"And your drinks, sir?" the waitress, again, inquired.

Sophia noticed the coconut shells displayed at the restaurant reception area and gawked at them steadily.

The waitress shadowed Sophia's distant look at them and asked if they wanted coconut water.

"Yes, coconut water for the four of us!" Philippe, again, rushed to answer.

The waitress finally left them, but a designed wall seized Sophia's awareness. The wall was a message board for the restaurant's avid costumers. There were displayed photos and love notes, mostly by teenagers of the wealthy kind.

With its magnetic pull on Sophia, Sophia approached it and saw a photo of her and Giovanni. Beside it was Giovanni's love note during their first week together. It said,

I suppose I am the happiest guy already.
The girl beside me on the photo is my girlfriend,
my beautiful, endearing girlfriend. I feel so ~~lucky~~
blessed that she chose me over the other guys out
there, chasing her like she's on extinction.

This feeling I can't explain. Perhaps this is what

people call ecstasy. She smiles as I write this.
It's her lips that I thirst to kiss. She has these eyes
that weaken me. It bothers me that guys stare at her
tonight and if she's a candle, she could have melted
already. But it makes me proud that she's all mine.
I love her and I always will.

Sophia's chest grew heavier, realizing how this Giovanni loved her so much. At once, she stopped herself from getting more emotional and wished for a tower of strength, just a snatch away, to prevent her legs from collapsing.

Elizabeth followed her daughter and saw the photo.

"The food's ready." Carefully, she stopped Sophia's track of thoughts about Giovanni.

Sophia slowly glared at the floor, and turned to face her mother, wordless.

Tangled up with the oodles of emotions surrounding them, Elizabeth held her daughter's hand and led her back to the table. "Let's eat now."

"Um, this is good!" Alex expressed while eating. "The taste is weird but it's really good," he kept on, with his mouth chock-full.

"Yes, I have to agree," Philippe coincided, savoring every bite of "adobo."

Chewing, with no energy, Sophia noticed someone from the reception area. He was watching her from time to time, making her lose interest in her eating.

"Sophia, what is wrong?" Elizabeth asked and followed her daughter's distracted eyes.

Curious, Alex did the same and saw Enzo, one of Sophia's keen suitors before, who was also the son of the restaurant's owner.

"Oh, Enzo!" he screeched in discomfort.

"You know him?" Sophia's forehead wrinkled.

"A little, sis. I wonder if he's working here."

"What do you know about him?"

"That he's a jerk!" Alex gnashed his teeth, his angry eyes entirely targeting Enzo.

"You think I knew him?" Sophia stiffened, and examined Enzo sneakily.

Within their parents' presence, Alex chose not to provide her any answer. He was simply careful not to let slip any mischief he did before, involving Enzo.

"What is it, Alex?" Elizabeth butted in.

Philippe did the same, his face displaying inklings of Alex's naughtiness.

Alex sighed, deciding in his mind. But in the long run, he finally spilled all the beans.

"Sophia, that guy..." he spoke initially, discerning his father's irritated impression. "Um, he used to stalk you before," he finally admitted, already prepared for their parents' shock.

"What?" Philippe turned shaken.

"And because of that… Giovanni and I used to punch him in the face." Now, Alex conceitedly announced it.

"What?" Philippe and Elizabeth reacted simultaneously, their eyes continuously dilating.

"How come we never knew this, before?" Elizabeth freaked out modestly.

"Well..." Alex self-righteously shrugged his shoulders.

"Come on, honey! Let's eat fast so we could go. I'm glad I'm getting to know more of your brother's bad behavior," Elizabeth told Sophia, with a penetrating glance at Alex.

Sophia nodded, pondering everything she heard from them.

At the Vabueretti residence, Jericho was stealthily observing outside the house. He was in his car, away from the gate, waiting for Sophia to come out, but for hours, he did not see any of her silhouette.

Still patiently waiting, Jericho finally saw a car coming and thought that it might already be the Vabuerettis. He hid himself in the car and carefully looked out from its window.

Their gate was opened by Grandma Lucy.

The moment Jericho saw her, his nervous system immediately plunged down. Determined enough, he endured it all, so as to study the place again.

At last, Sophia appeared in his sense of sight, as she gracefully glided out of the car.

Euphoric, he smiled and then left.

Chapter 18

The Artist in Her

THERE were still a few weeks before summer ended.

One late morning, since Zarah was still on vacation in Europe with her parents, Elizabeth decided to convince Sophia to attend an art class. She wanted to wash her daughter's sadness away by reviving her passion, which was to sketch. She knew that it was the Tenth of May, the day of her daughter's painting competition at the National Art Institute, but she chose to zip her mouth about it, considering Sophia's amnesia.

"You love to sketch, honey! Every summer, you attend Ms. Bun's art class." Elizabeth talked to Sophia as she joined her on the dining table.

Landing a steaming cup of rosemary tea on the table, Sophia bent her head down and dampened her lower lip. She was not sure about how she was going to respond to her mother's offer.

"You have lots of sketch pads, hon." Elizabeth leaned forward and volunteered to squeeze a slice of lemon on her daughter's cup. "You're an exceptional artist," she added, pinning on a wide smile.

Sophia contemplated her mother's offer again. With a profound look at her hands, she wondered if they could still sketch, exactly like they used to. Though she hadn't seen, yet, a sample of her own work ever since the accident, she heard that they were great.

Elizabeth's eyes lingered and were drawn to Sophia, and she thought of something that could, somehow, let some light into her daughter's blank mind.

"Wait here and I'll get your sketch pads for you to see," Elizabeth set forth, giving Sophia a pat on the back.

"Yes, Mom. I'll wait here…" Sophia nodded and granted her mother a plain smile.

Elizabeth went upstairs and looked for them.

Rounding at her daughter's bed, she knew that she just put them somewhere in Sophia's bedroom. She kept searching and at last, she found one beneath Sophia's study desk piled along with art magazines and school books. It was Sophia's latest sketch pad. She went back, downstairs, and handed it to Sophia.

"I don't remember where I put the others but this is what I found," explained Elizabeth, as she approached her daughter from behind, and volunteered to open it for her.

As the pages were turned one by one, Sophia was amazed by her own artwork. "Did I sketch all of these?" she asked, lifting her chin, looking at her mom through the corners of her eyes.

"Yes, honey." Elizabeth's voice sounded proud.

Page after page, the sketch of what she saw at the lake house that night seized Sophia's eyes. The gigantic pair of white wings was, in particular, outstandingly sketched!

"It's beautiful, Sophia! What made you sketch that?" Elizabeth applauded her.

Out of the blue, Sophia remembered what she read from her diary a few days ago. It was described the way it was sketched.

"Your imagination is brilliant, honey! What made you draw such a pair of huge wings, surrounded by a flock of smaller birds?" Elizabeth, still at Sophia's back, ensued. "Um... let me interpret that." She brought out a challenge to herself and placed her right index finger over her lower lip, thinking hard.

"Mom, when will we visit Forest Green again?" Sophia, all of a sudden, changed the course of their conversation.

"Forest Green? We just went there about four months ago."

Gradually, Sophia nodded and confessed, "I feel like I need to go back there."

"And what would you do there?" Elizabeth's surprise persisted, as she punctured her eyes into Sophia's sketch, mulling over it, as if it reminded her of something.

"I don't know, Mom. It's just that... a part of me is telling me to get back there."

"Oh, by the way, how did you know of Forest Green?" Elizabeth quickly asked, surprised about how Sophia learned of Forest Green, despite her amnesia.

"Um, through my diaries, Mom…"

Knowing that Sophia grew up there and hopefully, some things would miraculously flash back into her memory, Elizabeth was fairly persuaded.

But Grandma Lucy spied their conversation.

Sensing Elizabeth's plan to visit Forest Green, Grandma Lucy demanded for a private talk with her daughter-in-law.

Elizabeth agreed and temporarily left Sophia.

They headed to Philippe's office room, the one that was adjacent to the living room.

While closing the door, Grandma Lucy made sure they did not appear suspicious to Sophia.

"I think it's time for you to know about Jericho." Grandma Lucy began to reveal some secrets, her eyes concentrated on the rays of the sun passing between the small spaces of the curtains.

"I heard of that name when we were in Forest Green. What about that guy, Mom?" Elizabeth asked as she stood, five feet away from Grandma Lucy.

Looking down, Grandma Lucy took a hard time to select her words. In an upset intonation, she spoke again. "Jericho is the son of an insane woman in Forest Green. They are poor… and pathetic! I don't want that kind of guy for my granddaughter!"

Rendered speechless, Elizabeth felt like she was thrown from East to West and vice versa.

"Mom, you mean to say... my daughter had a relationship with that guy?" Elizabeth survived to ask in pins and needles. "But she'd just turned thirteen when we took her!"

"That was what I was asking myself, before. She was too young, Elizabeth!" The frown in Grandma Lucy's face deepened.

"Mom, maybe he's just a friend. Maybe you're overreacting!" Elizabeth attempted to stretch it out.

"You think I was stupid enough to see what he was doing to her?"

"What, Mom?"

Instantly, Grandma Lucy fell mute. Letting her breath come out slowly, she folded her arms on her chest and carried on. "I was awake that night when I heard someone climb Sophia's room. Her door was open when..." Grandma Lucy's voice suddenly trembled.

On the edge, Elizabeth stepped closer towards her and waited for her mother-in-law to finish her sentence.

Grandma Lucy found courage to speak again. "Her door was open when..."

"When?"

"Her door was open when I saw him kissing Sophia!"

Elizabeth, at once, weakened. "Oh, dear God...."

"She was twelve so I decided to call you right away... to take her away." The moment she said it, Grandma Lucy faced Elizabeth, looking deadly.

Elizabeth felt rooted to where she was standing, and allowed herself be stabbed by every knife coming from Grandma Lucy's eyes and words. She was speechless, shaking, disbelieving every word she heard from her mother-in-law.

"I'm her grandma and I want the best for her! You think it was fine with me to see my young and innocent granddaughter being kissed by a tramp?" Grandma Lucy stressed and paced towards the windows to avoid Elizabeth's shocked and perplexed eyes.

With those sharp words, Elizabeth could almost collapse and sink to the floor. She wished for a pole of strength, just a grab away, for her knees were about to betray her.

"If I did not call you that day, to take her... her life would have been so different, Elizabeth!" Grandma Lucy advanced. "That is the reason why, as much as possible, I don't want her back in Forest Green. It will only bring everything back!"

About to explode, Elizabeth remained silent. Soon, she survived enough to say something, "What if it's over now...?"

Grandma Lucy brusquely laughed and faced Elizabeth once more. "When you visited Forest Green four months ago, they saw each other." Grandma Lucy lifted her lips sideways with swaying of head. "Oh, Eliz, trust me. I've been told. And I'm very sure the lust is still there. She's just like Francheska." All of a sudden, Grandma Lucy realized, too late, that it was a slip of the tongue.

"Mom, please! Don't dredge up the family history!" Elizabeth pleaded. "Please, don't involve my sister, Fracheska, here!"

Grandma Lucy's eyebrows raised. "All right! But from whom would Sophia inherit such—"

"Mom! Please!" Elizabeth pleaded harder, cutting Grandma Lucy's sentence before she could unearth the unwanted family secrets, of Sophia's true identity.

Grandma Lucy appeared disillusioned. "Remember, I lost my son, Benjamin, because of Francheska! And I don't know if he is still alive or—" Grandma Lucy cried, all of a sudden.

Silence conquered Elizabeth. She could not bear the rushing torrent of the past. The times when Francheska threatened to abort Sophia. The times when her parents, Randy and Emily, were filing a case against Benjamin, Philippe's younger brother, for sexually assaulting Francheska. And Elizabeth didn't know if her sister was alive afterwards (because she ran away after giving birth). *I also lost a sister because of your son,* Elizabeth wanted to scream at Grandma Lucy.

"My son was innocent, Eliz… Yes, they were both teenagers. We all know they were soft on the head... But everyone at the party told me that Francheska was taking too many drinks, the night you and Philippe got wed in Forest Green. Yes, Benjamin had a crush on Francheska, but I know my son! I know my son, Eliz! He might not have remembered everything because he was extremely drunk and had popped some drugs… but I know, he couldn't do such a thing. Francheska's claim, that she was raped in the woods, near our lake house, lacked evidence, Elizabeth. It lacked evidence! And now, I don't know where my dear Benjamin is…"

There was another moment of painful silence!

"There's not a day that passes by, that I do not think of my son, Elizabeth…" Grandma Lucy struggled to wipe her tears. "I always do…" She broke into another sob.

Still, silence served as Elizabeth's recourse. There were no words to mollify or lessen the situation she and Grandma Lucy were in.

"I'm going back to Forest Green tonight!" Grandma Lucy wiped another stream of tears. "Sophia's getting better and I think she doesn't need me anymore!" she proceeded cold-bloodedly, and was about to leave the room.

Elizabeth stopped her. "Your granddaughter still needs you, Mom. We need you! Please… give our family another chance," she said, attempting to meet Grandma Lucy's eyes.

"I have to get back there, Eliz!" Grandma Lucy insisted, and left Elizabeth, in a rush.

Sophia heard some echoes of shouts, ringing, from her father's office, and she decided to go there. Witnessing how Grandma Lucy recklessly exited the room, she knew they had a fight. Then, she made haste, to check on her mom.

Witnessing those tearful eyes of her mother, Sophia ran to console her.

"Mom, are you all right?"

Not a single word came out from Elizabeth's trembling mouth as she rested on Philippe's chair.

"Mom?" Sophia repeated. "What's wrong?"

Elizabeth blinked back her tears and pretended she was fine, looking at her daughter with a mixture of love and regret.

Sophia's innocent face slowly frowned as her hands rested on her mother's arm. "Mom, is there something that I can do?" Watching her mom, watching the heavy rainfall from her mother's eyes, it felt like the downward pull of her chest was much stronger than gravity.

Elizabeth's bare hands sponged her tears down but a dew magnified her daughter's face. "I'm fine, honey! I'm fine! Have you already decided to attend Ms. Bun's art class?"

The pallid smile of Elizabeth poked Sophia. Agreeing was one way to drift her mom's sadness away, she thought, and so she acted with full-blown interest.

"Yes, Mom. I'm actually excited to attend it."

"I'm glad you finally decided. I'll call Ms. Bun, then," Elizabeth concluded, her face finally revealing signs of relief.

Chapter 19

Remember Me

THE first light of the succeeding day came. The floor was cold when Sophia evacuated her bed and prepared for her art class. She was too nervous so that she did not even know which way to start.

Downstairs, while preparing for breakfast, Elizabeth decided to check on her daughter.

"Mom, what are you doing here?" Sophia, from the shower room, asked, with rosy cheeks, when she saw her mom placing clothes on her bed. She was quite uncomfortable to be seen with just a towel wrapped around her body.

"Sophia, honey, here are your blouse and skirt. Avoid wearing skinny jeans or anything revealing. You know, Ms. Bun is very conservative."

With her mouth hung wide open, Sophia murmured, nodding, waiting for her mom to get out so she could finally doll up.

"Mom, are you not gonna leave? I have to... dress up." Sophia reminded her mom, when Elizabeth lingered.

"Oh, I'm sorry. Actually, I'm about to leave now." Elizabeth laughed briefly, when suddenly, she saw a small tattoo at her daughter's upper right shoulder, at the back. It froze Elizabeth.

"Is that a tattoo you have there at your back?" Elizabeth approached her uneasily.

"What? I don't know, Mom!" Sophia hurried to check it, in front of the mirror. She was too impatient to see it and didn't notice her mom's rising anger.

Elizabeth drew closer to her and examined her tattoo, as if she was digging for gold. "Sophia, what were you doing with your body?" Elizabeth began scolding and saw the word *forever* in her tattoo. "Since when did you have this?"

"Mom, I don't know! I have amnesia, remember?" The color drained from Sophia's face as her mom looked at her more closely, her mom's expression a blend of puzzlement and concern.

"Your tattoo is inappropriate for you. Get dressed now, and I'll drive you to your art class." Then, Elizabeth went back downstairs, disappointed.

Sophia exerted a lot of effort to look at her tattoo again, self-questioning how she had it, until it finally frustrated her. And so, she began dressing up, and also went downstairs.

The steering wheel appeared more fragile than glass when Elizabeth drove Sophia's red mini-Cooper. It was not used for months now, and Elizabeth decided to use it in the hope of bringing back Sophia's old memories.

Sophia looked vacantly through the windshield. She was thinking of what could happen later, of how to introduce herself in front of the class, and the like, but one thing that bothered her the most was… if she could still sketch or paint.

"If you need something, don't forget to call me or your dad." Elizabeth attempted to distract her.

Sophia managed a nod.

Now, they were almost approaching Emerald Building.

"Are you sure you're not hungry?" Elizabeth stirred Sophia again, after Sophia admitted she couldn't eat earlier. "We're thirty minutes early. We could still grab some pancakes and bacon…"

"Don't worry, Mom. I'll grab my meal later." Sophia gave her mom a smile, then planted a kiss on Elizabeth's flawless cheeks.

It was an absolute bombshell to Elizabeth and it made her freeze up, disbelieving the latter act from her daughter. She was never kissed by Sophia, before. Before the amnesia, Elizabeth amended silently.

"Sophia…" Elizabeth grabbed Sophia's hand, the moment she recovered from her surprise.

"Yes, Mom?"

"Take care of yourself, okay? And be careful of strangers!" Elizabeth was exceptionally serious in saying it.

Dumbstruck, Sophia widened her smile. "Yes, Mom. I will."

And then, Elizabeth provided her a quick once-over as soon as Sophia stepped out of the car.

Sophia arrived in class and saw ten of her classmates. Glancing, she saw five vacant chairs at the back—three at the second-to-the-last row and two at the last one. She went straight to the nearest one but Ms. Bun saw her and welcomed her. She turned red-faced when all of her classmates began to scrutinize her. But she handled the situation fairly enough, and hurried to sit down again.

She was taking down notes about the introduction to the program when a tall guy suddenly entered the room.

"Oh! I suppose you are Mr. Leivinhyde!" Ms. Bun spoke in obvious pleasure, and began to introduce him to the class.

The tall guy took his shades off and beamed. He thanked Ms. Bun for her warm welcome and looked for an available seat.

"Wow! He's really hot!" one of the females whispered, in admiration.

Still writing and absolutely clueless about the new guy's presence, Sophia overheard, then out of curiosity, she finally set her eyes on him. One way or another, she was suddenly mesmerized.

The tall guy was looking at her, too, keenly, and a partial smile was bestowed upon her. Unexpectedly, he sat down beside her.

"Hi! I'm Jericho," he spoke with confidence.

Sophia flushed and wondered if he was the Jericho she knew in her diary. In a flash, she excused herself and ran to the lady's room.

Terribly bothered, she appeared before the mirror, while she washed her face again and again, trying to stop the shaking of her hands. She paused for a moment and pressed her fingertips to her eyes as if the pressure would stop her tension. Then, she took a deep breath and wiped her face with tissue paper.

When she was somewhat eased, she went out and was startled to see Jericho, waiting outside the lady's room, as if she was his target.

She stopped, motionless, her heart beating fast and loud.

Jericho, as he stood against the wall facing the door, noticed her fast and shallow breathing.

"Are you scared of me?" he asked with a dagger look.

"I... I'm not feeling well," Sophia reacted, stumbling.

"Really? I'm a doctor. I suppose you need me."

Upon hearing it, Sophia felt like she waned.

Jericho looked sharper and more tempting. He was trying to figure out if she knew something about him.

Sophia attempted to escape from him but Jericho suddenly grasped her right hand and led her straight to the lady's room, and swiftly locked the door knob. Then, he began to interrogate her.

"Let go of me!" Sophia protested aggressively.

Jericho carefully pushed her against the wall and examined her from head to toe. "Do you not remember me, Sophia?"

With her eyes avoiding his piercing look, Sophia grew scared. "I don't know you! Please, get off me!"

"Even if you scream right now, no one will hear you, Sophia." Jericho clutched her even tighter. "Now, if you'll allow me... I just want to explain some few things."

Sophia ceaselessly pleaded for him to let her go, but Jericho was unwilling.

"Please, don't hurt me!" Sophia begged severely, as tears started to fall from her terrified eyes.

"I would never hurt you, Sophia," Jericho assured.

"What do you want from me?" Sophia turned even more frightened as she incessantly endeavored to flee his overpowering skintight grip.

"I just want you to trust me and listen to what I'll say. I promise that I won't hurt you, Sophia," Jericho mellowed, and voluntarily wiped her tears with his caring hands.

Sophia paused, shaking. She looked at him again and begged him to let go of her. This time, her face manifested courage.

"Sophia, I missed you so much." Jericho bared his emotions uninvited, as he laid his head on her chest. "Why do these things have to happen to us?" He poured out even more words!

Silence took over the place for a while and then, Jericho spoke again, his voice echoing more heartache. "You don't know how long I've waited just to have you this close again... and now that you're here with me, I would never let anything hinder our way again. Never again, Sophia."

Sophia grew paralyzed. His begging voice instantly blocked every impulse in her brain, and she found it hard to process his words. But they sounded genuine, loving, and kind.

"I lost you once, Sophia. And I don't know if I can go through it again. You don't know how shattered I was when you left, and until now." Then, he grabbed her soft hand and placed it in his chest, allowing Sophia to feel the pounding of his heart.

Sophia did not know what to feel at that very moment. All she knew was the warmth of his approaching embrace and the tender touch of his hands. There was no mistake that he was slowly drowning her in the depths of his love, and soon, her ocean-blue eyes merged into his sea-green ones.

Their eyes met, unblinking!

Sophia's vanishing strength worsened when Jericho began tracing the shape of her lips, sending powerful messages to every part of her being. He appeared very alluring, and he was undeniably irresistible. Then, his bloodshot lips moved forward to cover hers.

Frozen, Sophia closed her eyes as Jericho's mouth journeyed over hers. And she felt like she travelled, too, to a place unknown, as she felt the extreme thirst in his passionate kisses.

Intense as his kisses and grip were, Sophia was pushed more and more against the wall—with Jericho not allowing their lips to slide away from each other.

Buried under, Sophia's mind battled. She distanced herself, then, and rushed to leave him.

Dismayed yet determined enough, Jericho chased her.

"What do you want from me?" Sophia repeated as she glided away from him. "Please, leave me alone now!"

Unwavering, Jericho pursued her and stopped her from walking too fast.

"Please, stop chasing me. I'm not even sure of who you are!"

"It's me, Jericho, the one who has always loved you since then. We grew up in Forest Green together…"

Now, Sophia was put to a sudden halt. She bent her head down and pacified herself.

"Please, do not forget that this never happened," Jericho implored. "I love you, Sophia. Please, give me the chance to get you back."

Seeing the man appearing like a boy, Sophia's emotions went off, like a thunderstorm, and it felt like breathing, for her, was impossible.

They were suddenly disturbed, as Sophia's cell phone rang.

Startled, Sophia quickly answered it and was blown away by her mother's earsplitting voice.

"Honey, I decided to go back and visit you in your art class but Ms. Bun told me that you went out and never came back! Where are you? I am here at Emerald Building! Come back here and I'll wait for you in the lobby!" Elizabeth's tone ricocheted rage and disappointment.

Upon hearing it, Sophia slowly met Jericho's worried eyes.

His eyes seemed to beg for more moments with her. Jericho understood it but he couldn't stand to let her go without reassuring her of his serious intentions.

"Sophia, please, wait a second!" Jericho risked grabbing her hands. Then, he brought out something from his pocket. "Please, take my cell phone and hotel address."

Hotel address? Sophia pondered over, her fright turning for the worse.

Jericho felt it was stupid of himself to offer his hotel address outright, and he wished he hadn't shown it. But out of his eagerness and excessive hope to get her back, he still put it forward, wishing for a positive response from her.

Uncertain, Sophia let her gaze go over the expensive mobile phone and elegant small piece of paper.

"I'll be calling you through this phone. Promise me, don't let anyone know about us, not even your family. I'll explain everything when I call you," Jericho instructed as he handed them to her, by force.

Sophia dropped her head, still, unwilling to accept them, and remembered what her mom told her: to stay away from strangers. Her guilty conscience instantly enclosed her and crushed her.

"Please, take them," Jericho begged, harder.

Hard-pressed, Sophia finally received them, and went to her already-incensed mom.

Sophia was already far away but Jericho didn't stop watching her every step, craving for a possible chance to have her again. Out of habit, he went back to the kiss they shared years ago, and a while ago, and he plunged himself into these. Then, he remembered the sweet, fragile magic of their childhood, especially the times they sneaked into the lake house. Too much water had surged under the bridge, then. She was alluring, young, and innocent. She was all his and

he was all hers. Heavens, he was craving for more cloud nine, and if only he could travel back to those days of their young love, he would, without any uncertainty.

Feeling over the moon, Jericho caught himself smiling, and began his unhurried footsteps, to follow her again.

Chapter 20

Your Song, Our Song

"WHERE have you been?" Elizabeth's voice seemed to reach the heavens, the moment she saw her daughter approaching.

Sophia, blank and quiet, was not able to respond to her mother right away. Her mind was somewhere else, and she could not stop thinking of him.

"Sophia, are you listening to me?" Elizabeth kept on, her blood's boiling point elevating. "What's happening to you? Are you sick or something?"

Sophia's thoughts of Jericho were disturbed fully and finally, when her mother's voice became angrier and louder. Then, she looked up, at her mom, still zilch of words, and floating.

"Tell me if you're not interested anymore in this art class, and I'll tell Ms. Bun!" Elizabeth stressed. Her disappointment was extending all over the place.

Scared stiff, Sophia immediately showed her interest and explained that something distracted her. It was followed by consecutive apologies, but in two minds, (for she debated with herself if she had to reveal her encounter with Jericho to her mom, or not).

Elizabeth narrowed her eyes, feeling persuaded, to some extent, and in due course, forgave her daughter. "All right. Let's go home now. I'll call Ms. Bun later."

Sophia managed a nod and walked with her mom, until they approached the parking lot. As the car moved, Jericho appeared through the all-glass windows of the building, with a steady and passionate stare at her side of the car.

Sophia looked at him, too, and felt so out-of-herself until they arrived home, before lunch.

A symphony of catering sounds came from the kitchen, and they found Philippe cooking.

"Honey, what's the occasion?" Elizabeth eyed Philippe interestingly, sensing the smell of pasta, cooking.

"Oh, I think we should celebrate Nadine's newly-found talent." Philippe displayed boundless excitement. "I'm cooking pasta by the way, and later, I'll mix it with arugula pesto and grilled chicken." Then, he made a move to kiss Elizabeth and saw Sophia's silent presence, from behind.

"You're home, so early?" he asked Sophia.

Sophia stayed shut, showing no intentions of responding.

"Nadine's quite easy to teach piano today," Alex, who was hidden when he bent down to get cherry tomatoes from the fridge, meddled.

"Nadine just learned to play the piano. Only the basics, but not that bad," Philippe supplemented.

"Oh, that's impressive! Where's that little pumpkin, by the way?" Elizabeth glanced around.

"She's upstairs, having a nap. She must be exhausted after long hours of straight practice," Philippe answered, with small laughs.

"And she's kind of difficult to teach and really complains a lot," Alex incorporated, snickering.

While listening to them, Sophia noticed something vibrating inside her bag. She excused herself and discovered that it was Jericho's cell phone. He was calling.

Reluctant, Sophia cancelled his call.

To her surprise, it vibrated again.

Afraid that she might get caught, Sophia went directly to her room and decided to answer it there.

Accepting the call without leaking out any word, Sophia's lips trembled. She did not know where it would lead her, but Jericho's wary and hopeful voice made her go on, with the call.

"Hey!" Jericho repeated for the third time.

At a standstill, Sophia still couldn't recover from her lock-jaw.

"I called to check if you're already home. How are you there? Are you alone?"

Silence continued to be Sophia's response. She was still hesitant, not sure if she wanted to go on with what they had already started.

"Sophia…"

"No, I'm not alone. I'm with... my family." Finally, Sophia said something.

"Oh, that's good." Jericho made sure he sounded easygoing.

"Why are you still doing this?" Sophia suddenly dared to ask him.

"Doing what?"

"This thing that you're doing. I don't remember anything about you and—"

"And what, Sophia?" Jericho was very fast in stopping her from talking too much, fighting for his chances with her.

"I'm not sure of who you really are, to me…" Sophia murmured, and it just sent Jericho to the grave.

A moment of stinging silence passed.

Then, a very heavy sigh was heard by her. She could feel his heavy-laden breathing, through the phone.

"Sophia…?"

"Yes…?"

"Can we meet? Today, if possible? I just want to clarify some things."

"I'm afraid I can't. My family… is celebrating my sister's new… achievement."

"Ah, Nadine!"

"You know my sister?" Sophia's tone, at last, became enlivened, manifesting signs of interest that ignited Jericho further.

"Sophia, I know everything about you and… I've known you all my life."

Upon hearing it, right away, it submerged Sophia into a puddle of questions. *He knows everything about me? And he's known me all his life? How? Why?*

Noticing that he was slowly pulling Sophia into his magnet of hopes, Jericho took control of their conversation, immediately. "I also know you have a brother. His name is Alex."

Astounded all the more, Sophia now began to accept his claims as true.

"You want me to tell you more about you, Sophia?" Jericho progressed, not circumventing, so as to grab all his chances: to make her believe in him, to compel her, to get her back into his life.

Sophia turned quiet. Not a word was spoken by her, for a full minute.

But Jericho sensed it as that kind of silence, everytime she was confused or troubled.

"Tell me when I can call you again," Jericho asked, after a while.

"I don't think that's a good—"

"I'll call you around nine tonight!" Jericho quickly said, not allowing Sophia to refuse. He needed to avoid words, that were too impossible to bear. "I hope you answer my calls. I love you. Bye now," he suddenly concluded.

Sophia leaned against the wall and slid her back, downwards. She found it hard, really hard to identify those things jumbling in her thoughts. She felt worn out into shreds, until something kicked her in the head to read her diaries: to know more of the past, and to see if Jericho was really what he said he was, in her life.

Going through her diaries, she noticed this one that seemed older than the others, yet it appeared very special and intriguing. She opened it and by chance, she read the parts in which she wrote many things about her life in Forest Green.

Dear Diary,

I was bullied in school today. I was hurt by Beatrice and her friends but Jericho came and warned them. He is in high school but he's always there, waiting for me outside our school building. He asked me if he could walk me home and I agreed. He had his guitar with him.

Along the way, he started to make me merry with his romantic songs. His voice was very pleasing. I was touched when he started singing the song he wrote. He told me that it was for me.

I heard the lyrics and they were very ~~striking~~ endearing. For the very first time, I felt like someone cared for me.

We stopped by the mango tree and he told me of his jokes. They were really funny! He made me laugh, Diary. We were laughing, singing, and dancing. He was like my compass everytime I found myself lost, because of the cruelty of the world around me.

He's so sweet, diary. He's so sweet. But grandma, she never likes him. She always reminds me to avoid him. If only she knows how I feel so protected and so valued, everytime I am with him.

Love,

Sophia

Sophia could hardly stop her eyes from brimming with tears. She didn't know that she was actually unhappy during those days. But she saw a folded piece of white paper attached at the back of the page. She opened it and saw a hand-written song, with guitar chords. It was untitled.

```
        G9                  C9
I.      When I look at your sad face
        G9              C9
        I just wish I can help you through
        G9          C9
        From your doubts and fears
        G9           C9
        I'm gonna face them with you
        D9   C9     D9    C9
        Ooohhhh , yeahhhh

        G9   C9
Chorus: I'm here, baby
        G9       C9        G9
        Turn to me and I'll let you see
        D9          C9
        The love in me for you
II.     When your world's full of thorns
        And everyone won't listen
        I'll be there to ease the pain (Repeat Chorus)

        Am-Bm (2x)
Bridge:     I'll be with you
        'Cause you're just
        the one who  turns my world, who turns my world
```

Sophia could not help but truly get emotional. She turned the white paper over, and saw another handwriting. It seemed like it was a poem.

Your eyes, blue as the wide ocean;

This suffering deep down my soul fades away;

Your presence calms the wild waves of my seashore;

Fulfil me with your tender love, I pray;

Those words coming from those tiny lips;

Flourishing elegantly as purple tulips.

Take my hand tonight, my darling;

Forbid it not for I'll be sighing;

Let me fly you to the moon;

Dance and sing so soon;

Darling, your yes that I ardently desire;

Grant me tonight and I am in seventh heaven.

Sophia was put to a stop when she heard a knock on her door. It was her father.

"Honey, the food's ready! Please, go downstairs now," Philippe called out, and quickly went back downstairs.

Sophia quickly closed her diary and pressed her eyes shut, for a moment. She took her time hiding the diary under her pillow, and headed for downstairs.

Seeing her family settled into their respective seats, Sophia hurried to join them, as the welcoming bearing of her father speeded her.

"Hey, Soph! I just learned to play the piano. I wanna be the female version of Beethoven," Nadine shared with glee.

Sophia brushed away her sadness and turned all of her attention to her sister. "I'm happy for you, Nad! I hope someday you'll teach me." She made sure the bliss glanced off, when she said these words, and sat opposite to Nadine.

Nadine shrugged her shoulders with swarming confidence. "Sure, sis," she guaranteed and forked the pasta, long enough, and that left some pesto pasted around her mouth.

"Right! And next time, avoid too much complaining, okay?" Alex intervened, and stretched Nadine's cheeks, out of his combined fondness and thrill for her. Finally, a family member would be joining his gang of musicians. He wished Sophia would join it, too, but he knew it was far from happening. Sophia was more into painting, something that he and Nadine were absolutely worthless at.

"Ouch! Okay, fine! You don't have to stretch my cheeks, though." Nadine struggled to peel his brother's hands off her flushing cheeks. It was as if they were super glued, and they were difficult to remove. "Please, stop now. I mean it. It really hurts," Nadine pleaded more.

Alex just chuckled.

Philippe and Elizabeth were overjoyed to see their family complete and happy again. Their eyes drilled into each other, and full of relief.

When they were done eating, Sophia helped her mom clean the table while her father and siblings hopped into the living room to watch their favorite game show.

"Honey, next time you feel distracted... call me or your dad, okay?" Elizabeth smoothly talked to her. "And what distracted you, anyway?"

Sophia fell still for a moment, and thought of things to say.

"Sophia…" Elizabeth rang a bell in her. "Are you having flashbacks?" Now, Elizabeth faced her, looking more serious.

Sophia bowed her down but her mom leaned her face forward, to examine her eyes.

"Tell me what distracted you," she repeated.

Hesitant, Sophia chose not to tip out any detail.

"Sophia, honey, you have amnesia and you must understand that I am trying to help you."

"I know, Mom, but…"

"But what?" Now, Elizabeth's voice raised a bit.

On the verge, Sophia wanted to escape the situation. She knew she wasn't geared up for what could happen, for how her mom would react once she let the cat out of the bag, that someone from the past was coming on the way.

Irritated with speculations flashing in her eyes, Elizabeth spoke again. But this time, with a moderate voice. "Have you met a stranger today?"

Sophia's steady look at the floor continued. It seemed like she was slapped straight onto a sea cliff and rolled back into the sea, and then was slapped again. Seeking for courage, she opened her mouth but nothing emerged.

The frown in Elizabeth's face deepened. "Sophia, I asked if a stranger approached you! What's happening to you? Goodness!"

Sophia stayed wordless, shaking her head, brooding over the thought: what if her mother had any idea about her encounter with Jericho? Meeting her mother's eyes, there were assumptions. *What did I just get myself into? Oh, God…* Sophia thought as her lips began to tremble.

Elizabeth got her jaw up, her eyes still punctured into her daughter. "I understand you don't want to disclose anything to me. I'll do the dishes. Get upstairs now and take some rest." Elizabeth was frustrated beyond doubts, that her queries were left unanswered.

Sophia followed her mom and went upstairs. To temporarily remain silent about Jericho was a smarter choice, she thought, but a guilty feeling left her hanging on a ragged rope.

That night, while observing herself in the mirror, Sophia's mushrooming track of thoughts about Jericho was distracted by a call. She thought it was him but it was the other cell phone that was ringing. She galloped for it and saw Zarah calling.

"Hi, Sophie! How are you?" Zarah's greeting was deafening, with a pleasing feature. "There's a party at Monique's! It's her birthday! She just called me and asked if we could go."

Taking in her lively way, Sophia livened up her tone, too. "Really? But... she never told us ahead of time. And how's Europe, by the way? You returned early."

"Oh, Europe's fine. Dad suffered from an extreme form of food allergy in Copenhagen so we came back home too early."

"I see…"

"Anyway, Monique told me that it's actually sudden! You think Alex could go?"

"Um, I'm not sure! I'll go and ask him."

"All right! Call me later, then," Zarah concluded, like greased lightning.

Sighing, Sophia went to her brother in the living room.

"Cool! I'm going." Alex was relieved that something was about to break his boredom. "How about you? Are you going, too?"

"I don't know."

"Hey! You're going, okay?" Alex did a lot of gestures just to convince her. "You need to get out of the house, sometimes."

They endured exchanging words when Elizabeth saw them. It seemed to her that they were planning something, something close to trouble. As a result, she sprinted, to ask them.

"We got invited to a friend's birthday party," Alex hoped but the objection was readily relayed to them through their mother's shaking head.

It was further confirmed when their father said no and told them, instead, to stay home for the night.

"But Dad?" appealed Alex.

"No, son. Don't push me on this." Philippe's mood turned quickly into a stone. "You just had your accident and I don't want it to happen again," he stressed, in tons. His eyes were clearly flickering red warning lights.

Elizabeth supported her husband and begged the two to be cooperative. "Please, give us time and space to recover from everything that happened." Elizabeth pleaded, her voice echoing with heaps of unsettled problems, as she massaged her forehead again and again.

Sophia felt stricken. But for Alex, attempts to escape suddenly bordered on his mind.

"Just join Nadine tonight! I'll let you watch the TV until dawn but you have to promise me that you'll never escape tonight, understand?" Philippe warned solidly, his gawk concentrated entirely on Alex as if he had already detected his schemes.

Alex, though very much disappointed, agreed to his father. He grabbed the TV remote control and switched the game show to ESPN.

Nadine promptly complained and made a move to get it back, and Sophia was there to reinforce her gutsy act.

"I'm the eldest and you must obey me!" Alex bragged.

"You're so unfair, Alex!" Nadine countered. "You're the eldest and you must know how to give way to your younger sisters!" Nadine pointed out further, on her way to snatching the remote control again.

Alex was even more watchful so he was able to distance it a meter away, and it now enraged Nadine to the max.

To calm her sister down, Sophia offered to help her go to bed early.

Like a kitten scraping her claws before a dog, Nadine gave Alex a pointed look and obeyed her sister. And then, they turned their backs on each other, in bitter blood.

Sophia accompanied Nadine to her room and helped her prepare for bed. Soon, she realized that it was almost nine. Jericho was probably calling now. Though there was an impulse of eagerness that travelled through her every nerve, she was too quick to block it. *Stop it! Remember, you're still uncertain of him.*

"Sophie," Nadine, all of a sudden, talked.

"Yes, Nad?"

"Are you going to sleep now?"

Nadine's cute voice made Sophia pause from covering her with a blanket. "Not yet," she muttered, getting the fact that she might be asking for some favor: reading her some fairytales, perhaps.

"I miss you. I miss you tickling me because of my nasty jokes about you." Her digging up of memories was not expected by Sophia.

Lifting her head up, Sophia joined her on the bed and palmed her sister's aroma-scented hair. "I wish I remember them, Nad. I'm sure they're really funny." She inserted a small laugh, in the hope of turning her sister's grimace into a smirk.

It was quite effective. Nadine not just smirked. She actually had a louder laugh and she even shared how Sophia got annoyed by them.

"Really? You drove me mad by your mean jokes?" Sophia asked in disbelief, on the move to grab Nadine's chin and shake it from side to side.

"Yeah! Trust me, Sophie, you're easy to piss off!"

"That I don't believe." Sophia shook her head kiddingly and kissed Nadine on the cheeks. "Goodnight now, Nad," she whispered smiling.

"Why too soon?" Nadine shrugged her shoulders in protest.

"Um, it's just that… you need to sleep now so you'll grow up very fast and exceed my height," Sophia expounded, and she knew she couldn't admit that someone was actually calling her by now.

Exhaling a tank of dissatisfaction, Nadine nodded and whispered back her *goodnight*.

Sophia forced a smile and provided her sister with an ephemeral look. She turned off the lights and left by the time Nadine finally closed her eyes.

Sophia already missed a thousand of calls, all of them from Jericho. The second the cell phone vibrated again, Sophia was on-the-lookout to answer it, without any delay.

"Hi!" Jericho greeted.

"Hello…"

"Guess what?"

"What?"

"I'm outside your house. Will you look out the window, please, so I can see you?" Jericho implored, yet somehow managed to sound very demanding.

Although terribly tense, Sophia managed to look out the window and saw a strange car parked a few meters away from their gate.

"Why are you here?" she asked, jumpy.

"I just wanna see you tonight."

"You're not supposed to be here," Sophia countered, when Alex suddenly opened her door.

"Who are you talking to?" Curiosity crawled under Alex's skin, noticing how his sister stood by the window as if someone was outside their house. "Is there someone outside?" he asked, elongating his neck to look through the windows.

"Oh, Alex!" Sophia was startled and unintentionally stopped Jericho's call. "It's just that..." she tried to explain, accompanied with a slight shaking of hands. "Um...." Obviously, she was stumbling.

"Is there someone outside?"

"Uh..."

Alex, by now, was near the windows, but Sophia suddenly stopped him and attempted to change the subject matter by stressing that he didn't knock.

"There's a door for you to knock, Alex! Why not knock?" she laid emphasis on, stiffening her back, so as not to appear nervy.

Outside, Jericho wondered why the call ended, all of a sudden. He pressed *call* again, but a man's shadow surfaced through the windows. It made him assume that it was Alex's. The moment he was a bit certain, he started his car and left, discontented.

"I want to go to the party," Alex admitted to Sophia.

"Alex, dad and mom will get mad..." Sophia groaned, drooping her shoulders, in anxiety.

"I need you to cover for me."

"What? No!"

"Just do it!"

Still, Sophia seemed unmoving.

"Please, Alex... I don't want mom and dad to worry about you again. Remember, you've been arrested!"

"Okay, I get it! Thanks for your help, anyway!"

Seeing how Alex sighed, in his failed mission, Sophia immediately apologized. "I hope you understand."

"But you know what? You're right! Why not stay home tonight?" Alex turned things around, scratching his head. "By the way, how's your art class?"

"It's... fine."

"I see." He lifted an eyebrow, a perfect arch, and let a rush of air come out from his mouth. "You sound sad. Are you sure it was fine?"

"Um, I guess so."

"Put a smile on, sis! It's turning you ugly! You're even uglier than Ugly Betty now!" Alex played some fun and left her, laughing.

Sophia sat on her bed and wondered if Jericho had plans to call her again. A second went by and the cell phone went vibrating again. Answering it, she rushed to the bathroom so no one could hear her.

"Was it Alex who entered your room?" Jericho confirmed.

"Yes, it was Alex."

"What did he tell you?"

"A friend of ours is having a birthday party tonight, and mom and dad don't want us to go. But Alex… he wants to escape."

"I see. How about you? Do you want to escape, too?"

"What? No! I knew you would call me and I...." Sophia was saying when she realized she sounded cheap. She wished she could take those words back right away, feeling she would die of shame, but it was actually a feeling of relief, for Jericho.

"And what, Sophia?" he asked, revealing excessive delight.

"Nothing!" Sophia was fast in denying. Afterwards, an awkward silence controlled their talk, leaving only the hammering sounds of their hearts, that reached up to their ears.

"Sophia…?"

"Jericho…?" Finally, Sophia spoke again.

"Yes, Sophia?"

"You know I have amnesia, right?" Unsure, Sophia got up the courage to ask him.

"Yes, Sophia. I promise I will do my best to help you." The way he delivered it, sort of rushed in, flooded through the four chambers of her heart, and extended beyond her spine.

Sophia managed to be grateful.

"Anything for you, Sophia." Jericho made sure safe haven manifested in his voice. "I guess I have to say *good night* now!"

"Why?" Sophia asked, but she flushed the instant she realized she had made it obvious she wanted to prolong their conversation.

"I suppose you need to get some rest now," Jericho carried on.

"No, I'm not that… tired."

"Are you sure?"

Goodness, I can't believe I just said that! A very cheap response! Oh, God! Sophia squeezed her eyes shut, in shame, and immediately changed her mind. "You know what? You're right! I should be resting now!"

Jericho smiled on his end of the line, feeling over the moon at Sophia's obvious desire to talk to him, some more. At last, thank Heaven, he was slowly dragging, her back to him, and he couldn't believe it was all happening now. His long wait was almost, finally over!

"So, is it *good night* now?" Jericho wanted to conclude before distractions and other things could stumble upon them.

"Um, yeah…" Sophia bit down on her lower lip, battling the discomfort of her stupid feedbacks.

But Jericho strove to tell her one important thing. "I love you…" he murmured in a soft, moving voice.

It was something that neutralized the acidity of her embarrassment. Those three words from him instantly went down into the core of her soul, and it took her about half a minute to make progress. By the time she realized she needed to give him a response, she whispered back her *good night*, and ended his call, smiling.

Chapter 21

Through It All

ELIZABETH was brisk while she was preparing to do the laundry, the next morning. After cooking for breakfast, she went upstairs to get all of her children's clothes.

A knock sounded at the Sophia's door.

"Come in, Mom."

"Hey."

"Good morning, Mom!" In a flattering V-neck floral-print dress, Sophia presented her mother with a cheery face, as she reached for the door.

Elizabeth, returning the same facial expression, examined her. "You look great with that dress I bought you! I'm glad you're finally wearing it!"

Sophia's preliminary response was to smile and thank her mom, but she caught something in the last sentence, that made her wonder. "Haven't I worn it before?" she asked, showing a map of tiny lines across her forehead.

Elizabeth was put to a sudden pause. They shouldn't dwell on the issue of her finally wearing the dress, but she couldn't help but recall the day when she gave it to Sophia. It was one of the thousand clothes she'd bought for her sixteenth birthday, to buy some *daughter*ly love and acceptance. But there was too much trouble during those days. Sophia was at the peak of her rebelliousness, against her. Heavens, she was quite unruly. There were no days that she would not come home free of mess. She was drawn to alcohol, and Elizabeth couldn't resist putting the blame on Daniella—an overly-rebellious girl who dragged Sophia into a mob of foster-teenagers! But Sophia was different from them; she was definitely not a foster child. Elizabeth knew that and emphasized the point, hard, on Sophia but her daughter was, one way or another, disbelieving. (If only Elizabeth could tell her more.)

Pressing her eyes, Elizabeth was back to reality now. She went near Sophia and brightened up the atmosphere by changing the flow of their talk. "You're early, by the way. You must be really excited for your class," she said, after looking at Sophia's alarm clock that had been clicking close to six thirty. The art class would usually start at eight and the building was just a twenty-minute drive away, but Sophia was clearly in an on-the-go mode.

Sophia tossed a chirp, "Yeah." She nodded and began a move to put all her painting materials inside her bag. "By the way, Mom..."

"Yes?"

"I'm going to take a cab. Please, don't bother driving for me." Sophia dared to say, hoping to sway her mom.

"Why not?" Now, Elizabeth was the one showing puzzled lines across her face.

"Um, it would just exhaust you. Besides, I want to know more of the roads, on my own." Sophia made sure her tone was infused with a confident quality.

"All right."

"And Mom..." Sophia wanted to say more.

"Yes?"

"I have to go now. I promise, I won't forget to grab a bite of sandwich later," Sophia assured, while wearing her flat beige sandals, matching the imprinted flowers of her short dress.

In wonder, Elizabeth lingered, while observing her daughter. Something was odd. Yesterday, art class was dull for Sophia, but now, a sudden enthusiasm showed, and it just puzzled Elizabeth.

"Mom?"

Now, Elizabeth shook her head in hesitation. "All right. Be safe, then." With a strained smile, she brought up her hands to touch Sophia's shoulders, while trying to decode any mystery in her eyes.

Sophia suddenly blinked in haste but she had it all controlled, immediately, being able to shoot a look straight into her mother's inquiring eyes. "I will, Mom. Bye now," she mumbled, planted a kiss on her mother's cheeks, then she left the house in one fell-swoop.

Arriving in class, Sophia was surprised by Jericho's earlier appearance. And he was alone, so it placed Sophia into a sort-of-trap.

Jericho, displaying a euphoric impression, immediately stood up to meet her, and brought out the bouquet of red roses that he was hiding. Surely, the tips of his lips could almost touch his ears as he came forward and smiled. It was followed by a long and heartfelt kiss on her cheek.

Tomato-red, Sophia suddenly could not say a word. The heaven-scent of him just lavished her with amazement. And as his careful hands gently glided over her arm, they rashly sent electrical signals that ran through every part of her body.

She was rooted to the spot. Evidently, a graduated scale of tension was elevating, between them.

Jericho's eyes lingered as he looked at her, trying to figure out any message in her eyes. There was something new in her. A better glow. And there was no denying that she was falling into his charm. Again.

An hour seemed to go by. Finally, Sophia managed a not-too-obvious, delighted smile. "Thanks for the flowers. They're lovely."

"You're welcome. Please, take a seat," Jericho answered, in high spirit, spellbound, as he brought himself closer to her. It was still early morning but her face was already showing him what could possibly be the… fireworks of the coming night.

The moment he got his self-control back, Jericho sat down beside her. "You look really pretty," he praised, as his smile continued to widen.

It made Sophia flush more and more. "Thanks." She exerted a lot of effort not to look too excited.

Yet again, Jericho was lost in thought. He just sat there, facing her as if he was swimming in her aquatic eyes.

But such gape of him passed more tension on Sophia. She attempted to shift her look on the other side, but she knew he was still looking at her. She could tell it through the corners of her eyes.

Their taciturn situation was too much to handle, as they waited for each other to go on with their dialogue. A long wait ensued!

When they finally pulled through, Sophia asked why their classmates were not yet around.

It was a hard punch in the stomach for Jericho. He appeared to think hard, so that now, Sophia had to hypothesize about his gestures. He cleared his throat and began explaining that he did something.

"What did you do?" Sophia queried.

Detecting the concentrated curiosity in her stare, Jericho moistened his lips and began spilling the beans. "Yesterday, I..." Jericho's tongue was sliding back. It seemed like sighing was the best opening for his vindication.

But Sophia seriously waited.

Then finally, Jericho found the words to say. "Yesterday, I decided to sponsor an art exhibit at the National Museum, and I asked Ms. Bun if she could host it..."

"Then?"

"She said yes and… I volunteered to tell our classmates about it." Jericho slowed down, noticing the gradual pulling of her face. "That means... they will not be here today," he tried to tell more.

"You told them without telling me?" Sophia's face became completely screwed up. Surely, an ache was felt by her but Jericho was reasonably equipped to clarify more of his side.

"Please don't get me wrong, Sophia. I did it to be alone here with you, with no one else around."

Now, Sophia avoided his gaze.

Struggling to give more details, Jericho witnessed the pits of her frown. "I just want the two of us here. Besides, Ms. Bun would notice. She's a good friend of your mom, remember?" His voice resonated with more worry, as he looked like he would be joining the world's toughest tournament.

Nonetheless, it sounded pretty convincing to Sophia, so that straightaway, her scowl was changed into a plodding grin. She tried to bestow him an approving nod and remained silent again, contemplating the things that he just said.

Afterwards, Jericho had the guts to ask her for more favors. "Can we go somewhere else?"

Sophia's first impulse was to say no, but Jericho's tone and begging face motivated her to agree.

Ecstatic with something more than the effect of methamphetamine, Jericho leaned closer to her. "Thank you," he spoke softly, as his lips were out an inch away from hers, now.

The same pleasure was felt by her, and so, they left the building together.

"Where are you taking me?" Sophia asked, as they walked towards Jericho's glacier-white Toyota Prius, across the street.

"You'll see. Trust me on this, Sophia," Jericho winked and opened his car for her. "You'll love it."

"Thank you," Sophia flashed a shy grin.

"My pleasure!"

Then, Jericho jumped to the driver's seat, to join her.

Along the way, Sophia appeared blank, as if a thousand things raced in her mind, while Jericho quietly observed her. She wondered if it was right for her to agree to his offer, as she summoned up all her mother's reminders. She continued weighing things as they passed by the busy boulevards and avenues of the city.

Clinging to the shreds of his wishes, Jericho attempted to break the awkward silence that was sickening him. He straightened his backbone and risked crawling his fingers, to reach Sophia's edgy hands.

Sophia plainly felt it, the passing of unspoken comfort as he tightened his grip on her hand. Then, she swung her gaze towards him, capturing the grandeur of his stylized sideburns and blond highlights, that complimented his thick tousled hair.

And while he was melting from her stare, Jericho looked at her, too, with excruciating fondness. It was so intimate that Sophia immediately hurled her gaze, back to the other side.

Jericho broadened his grin and kept driving until they finally arrived at their destination. It was a romantic garden —a perfect place for a dating couple.

When the shadows of beautiful flowering trees fell over her face, Sophia rolled the window down to feel the cool breeze. Gentle was the wind that bestowed her with a dreamland scent, something that was so refreshing and relaxing.

Jericho settled his eyes on her again even as he struggled to focus on his driving. He pictured the same anticipation he had with her, many years ago, back at the lake house where they were always secretly playing.

Once he parked the car, he pleaded with her to stay put, for he would like to open the door for her.

Sophia felt how Jericho treated her like a princess, and it was very agonizing already. But by some means, she was heartily moved by it.

It always mattered to Jericho to provide her with all his love and tenderness.

A table for two was there, waiting to be occupied by them.

Gallantly, Jericho took hold of Sophia's hands, looked straight at her, and said, "I can no longer wait for tonight, to ask you for a date."

Sophia stood stock-still, beneath the undisguised love in his eyes. It felt like all her blood piled up on her cheeks, and she barely knew what to say, any longer, to compensate for his affection. A sincere smile was all that she could provide, in return.

At that exact moment, everything that Jericho did for her could be summed up as chivalrous ways.

They continued their walk to the table, their fingers slowly creeping into each other's, as their heartbeats drummed in their ears.

Since the garden was near an ocean cliff, the magnificent deep waters beneath the bright blue sky was well-appreciated by Sophia. For a while, she submerged herself into all of it.

And Jericho joined her, in her nature-tour.

"It's beautiful!" Sophia spoke, in an increasingly astonished voice.

"As beautiful as you, Sophia..."

Touched to the bones, Sophia let a shaft of light flash from her face and eyed Jericho. Looking at him, looking at those glittering sea-green eyes, Sophia was drowning more and more, and knew that Jericho did not need to say *I love you* anymore.

Before long, Jericho realized he needed to offer her a seat, and so, he rushed to pull a chair for her. By the time Sophia got seated, Jericho started to bring out a piece of paper. It was perfectly rolled and appeared like it was well-taken care of. Jericho rolled it over, and handed it to her.

"This is yours," he spoke.

Sophia gracefully took it and saw a sketch, almost the same as those she had skimmed, from the artworks her mother said, belonged to her hand.

"You drew that when we were at the lake house in Forest Green. It was a peaceful sunny morning when you decided to paint the view but... pencil was all I had in my backpack. I had no painting materials for you to use, as paint," Jericho detailed, accompanying it with a modest laugh. "You said pencil was all right and then, you started sketching. You were so exceptional, Sophia."

Sophia looked at the sketch once again—now trying, at her utmost, to abstain from getting too emotional.

Though she remembered nothing of him, his voice kept echoing what was from their past.

"The moment you finished it, you gave it to me. You don't know how happy I was, Sophia. I took good care of it. It was the only thing that relieved me since you... left." Jericho exposed his emotions further. "And please, turn the paper around. You wrote something on it."

Sophia obeyed him and read,

Deep down the sea of my sorrow,

you revived me with your love.

The pouring out of tears was intolerable. At his glance, Sophia fell in his arms.

Jericho, too, could not resist it all. They hugged each other, like they were never going to let go of each other. Later, he planted a kiss on her nose.

At home, Elizabeth was already done with the mountainous laundry, and noticed the quietness of the house, without the kids. Since Alex and Nadine went to the mall and Philippe went to work at the hospital, it was a chance for her to clean up their rooms.

She finished cleaning Alex's room, then Nadine's, and now it was time for Sophia's. Removing Sophia's bed sheet, unintentionally, Sophia's diary fell from her bed—and a piece of paper came out from it. She picked it up and read a hotel address. Elizabeth pondered heavily. *Whose hotel address is this?* she asked herself, perturbed. *Why does my daughter have this?*

Without any delay, Elizabeth opened Sophia's diary. It happened that she went to the last entry and unintentionally read,

Dear Diary,

I saw him today and I could not find the words to describe my first encounter with him, after the accident. I may have amnesia but I feel like I have always felt the same thing for him ever since we were young. His passionate look, his tempting eyes, and his tender lips that I could not resist. His touch so gentle... that triggered me... and his kiss, so magnificent, that wooed me.

Oh, Diary, I think I am truly falling in love!

Love,

Sophia

With the date so fresh, fear and worry howled through Elizabeth's heart. If only she could fly straight away to her daughter's art class and confront her about it, she would, without hesitation. She decided to visit the hotel. But calling Ms. Bun hit her head first.

Unexpectedly, she was informed that there were no classes and that Sophia was not with them at the museum, for the art exhibit.

It sounded like a thunder crush in Elizabeth's ears. Very soon, negative things began to border on her mind. On the double, she dressed up and prepared herself. Calling her daughter, struck her head, but she deliberated, first. She wanted to surprise Sophia, and catch her in the act, to know if her daughter might be truly hiding… Something!

Jericho and Sophia were still at the garden, savoring each other's company, just after they amorously fed each other during that early lunch.

"I love you, Sophia… and I'll never get tired of telling you this," Jericho showed copious genuineness, as he laid his thumb over her lips, and glided it over to the side.

She risked a smile but all of a sudden, a heavy feeling cropped up in her chest. It was as if it was going to crack her into pieces. Was it a premonition of something?

It was a deepening moment for Jericho, but it just kept on torturing Sophia. Sophia blinked really hard, trying to understand the clashes of her thoughts... when Giovanni's face, all of a sudden, flashed, like a dim mental picture. A feeling of extreme guilt wrapped her up right away. She tried to beat it off but it was failing her. She knew how Giovanni loved her, from reading her own diary.

Sophia struggled to brush it all away. Then gazing at Jericho's eyes, she wished for peace of mind, and so she spoke up. "Jericho, there's something I want you to know." Her tone quivered, with a wave of mixed emotions.

"What is it, Sophia?"

Slowly, Sophia distanced herself from him and thought of words to use, to help her explain herself, but Jericho crept nearer.

Under those optimistic eyes, Sophia spoke again, "I loved a guy, Jericho. After you. His name was Giovanni. I—I couldn't remember, except for my diary."

"Sophia, I don't care about your past. What I do care about right now is... your present and future, with me."

For a split second, she was wordless. "It's just that... it's been just few months ago since he passed away and I... I feel like I'm cheating on him, now that I'm with you. Like... it's too soon for me."

Jericho looked up, trying to grasp for some air. He couldn't bear the squeezing of his heart, and it felt more unbearable than the sunrays penetrating his eyes. At length, he endeavored to walk closer her, while still trying to breathe.

"Sophia, what will I ever do? What do you want me to do, so you can love me completely? Even before, when we were young, I always felt like someone owns the half of your heart! When will that time come, that day that... the

whole of it will be mine?" Please, tell me! When?" Jericho was now down on his knees, clutching her waist with his shuddering hands. "I don't wanna lose you again, Sophia!"

It was tormenting her.

"Jericho, please, stand up," she asked, with her voice on edge. "Please, Jericho... please."

He did not want to. He merely laid his head over her tummy, like a little child, and clutched her hands tightly.

His stinging tears soaked her clothes, and Sophia struggled to carry on, but she turned weaker and weaker.

Shattered! They both turned shattered!

A moment went by. Still, they were at the height of their own wishes to end their mutual agony, and to put everything back into place.

"Sophia, you've killed me once! Do it one more time, and I'll really die, forever!" Jericho cried out, holding her hands tighter, as if he never meant to release her.

Hearing those words, Sophia could almost collapse.

Moving seemed impossible, but he strained to clutch her closer and closer.

Sophia pleaded with him to let go of her, when Jericho suddenly stood up, and kissed her, not allowing her to make any further move. He kissed her... over and over.

Now, the clouds revealed the sun, which heated up the place where they were standing.

Elizabeth was on her way to the hotel, and was filled with thoughts of unpleasant things, about her daughter. When she got there, she temporarily stayed at the lobby, to calm herself, and to prepare herself for any kind of explosion.

She was sitting beside a man in an elegant suit, then she dialled Alex's number, and asked if he noticed something strange in Sophia. Alex couldn't recall anything, but then he shared that he caught his sister gazing through the windows last night, as if she had seen someone outside.

Elizabeth's suspicions worsened. She was still sitting there when Mr. Wakins, the owner of the hotel, saw her. He used to be her client.

Mr. Wakins approached Elizabeth and talked to her in obvious glee. "Attorney... you're here at my hotel!"

Elizabeth was surprised to see him but she managed to stand up, and then shook Mr. Wakins' hand.

"Mr. Wakins…" Elizabeth greeted back.

"Are you solving a case here, attorney?"

"Something like that," Elizabeth put on a smile, appearing unperturbed.

"Okay, whatever that is, attorney, you are free to roam around my hotel," Mr. Wakins offered with laughs. "After all, you helped me win my case."

Elizabeth smiled once again, and appeared grateful.

"Attorney, I have to go now, and, thank you again!" In a hurry, Mr. Wakins ended their small talk, with a friendly grin.

Watching Mr. Wakins exit the building, Elizabeth, at long last, approached the receptionist. She asked who had checked in at Room 808.

The receptionist declined to reveal it, at first, but since she saw the boss talking animatedly to her, she finally mentioned the name Jericho Leivinhyde.

Upon hearing it, Elizabeth instantly felt like blowing up, in shock, but she was able to ask when he had checked in.

"A week ago, ma'am."

Right away, Elizabeth thanked the receptionist and walked away. Immediately, she called up Grandma Lucy.

"Mom, what is the surname of Jericho? The one from Forest Green?" Elizabeth breathlessly talked to Grandma Lucy on the phone.

"Leivinhyde. Why, Elizabeth?"

Elizabeth, with waning strength, accidentally dropped her cell phone and broke it. Though it was hard for her to do so, she managed to ponder if Sophia was seeing this Jericho. Finally, she hastened to the elevator, to clear up her suspicions.

Elizabeth was struggling with herself, and trying to stay relaxed. She knew she must not judge her daughter right away. But, it was this Jericho who truly bothered her of. She went to the elevator and surreptitiously tried to get to the eight floor.

Standing before the door of Room 808, now Elizabeth started knocking but no one was responding. She wanted to call her daughter, but she realized, her own cell phone was already shattered to pieces. In tears, she finally went home, disbelieving all of Sophia's actions. *How could Sophia do this? How could she?!*

Sunset came at last.

"I'll drive you home," Jericho told Sophia, as they began to leave the place.

"You can't drive me home. They will see you," Sophia reminded him.

"I'll drive you near your gate then." Jericho managed a smile, and caught a strand of her hair that was flown away by the cold wind. Then, he tucked it behind her ear.

Sophia initiated a step, but she could not stop thinking of the kiss they shared, a while ago. Tracing her own lips, she seemed on the brink of discovering, something, until they reached his car.

Arriving near Sophia's gate, Jericho's face instantly saddened. He was silently begging for more time with her.

"I have to go now," Sophia spoke in a low tone, and opened his car door.

"Sophia, please, wait." Jericho moved fast to grab her hands. "I love you, okay?" he reassured, very seriously.

Sophia prioritized her own worry—that they might be caught together—rather than respond to his reassurance. "I think I better go. Mom is probably looking for me now." Then, she got out of his car immediately.

Unsatisfied, Jericho let her go, and restarted the engine with a heavy heart.

Sophia entered her home, but her mother was already fuming... as if a wildfire was scattered through her every nerve. She was waiting for Sophia at the living room, her eyes alight with fury.

"Where have you been?" At least, Elizabeth managed to ask, first, as she tried to calm herself, when she stood up from the couch.

Wordlessly, Sophia was rooted to where she was standing. The fire in her mother's eyes sent her some silent warnings.

"Why can't you answer me?"

Still, Sophia couldn't say any word. It appeared like her mother knew something. Or everything.

Now, Elizabeth approached her, passing a stare, as if she could hurt her at any moment. "I saw this piece of paper in your room." She began confronting.

Sophia saw it and could almost die. She didn't know what to say. But she knew a bomb was about to explode now.

"Have you been lying to me, Sophia?" Elizabeth completely hooked her eyes on her. "I called Ms. Bun and she told me that you don't have a class today, and you were not in the art exhibit either, so where have you been?"

Shaking prominently, Sophia remained mute.

"What are you hiding from us, huh?" Now Elizabeth stepped closer to her.

Still, Sophia couldn't say anything. She felt more guilty than a suspect in a trial court.

"Are you seeing someone? Why the hotel address?"

Like a rock being pushed to the edge of a cliff, Sophia wished to escape, but her mom grabbed her, like there was no way out, for her.

"Tell me about this guy, Jericho!" Elizabeth demanded, her hand still encircling Sophia's wrist.

Now, a heavy rainfall collapsed from Sophia's eyes as she started to cry, and endeavored to face her mother, with vanishing strength.

But Elizabeth was determined enough to interrogate her.

It seemed that Elizabeth's shout was heard by everyone at the house, all at once, and they now ran towards the source of commotion.

"Mom..."

"What, Sophia? Tell me! Have you been sleeping with him?"

Sophia struggled to look at the floor, to avoid her mother's deadly stare. She didn't have the nerve to show her face.

"I'm asking you! Did you sleep with him? A hotel address, huh?"

Sophia was about to clear herself, when her mother suddenly slapped her in the face.

Approaching, Philippe saw how Elizabeth hurt Sophia. For the first time... physically.

Sophia, ashamed of herself, attempted to run straight to her room, but her mother grasped her hand again.

"How could you do this to us? I may not be the one who raised you but I knew I taught you well! I never thought that you could do this to us!" Elizabeth delivered it all, with such gale-force, shaking Sophia's shoulders, as if she was excavating Sophia for her very core. "Don't you ever come back here if you find yourself pregnant, Sophia!" Elizabeth's watery eyes persisted.

"Mom, it's not like that. It's not what you think!" Sophia would have gone through fires and oceans to explain, and willingly received her mother's consecutive blows.

Alex and Nadine also rushed to the scene. They were very much surprised at what they were seeing.

Now, Philippe dashed to stop Elizabeth from slapping Sophia even more.

"Elizabeth? What's going on? You're hurting her!" Philippe grabbed Sophia away from Elizabeth.

"Your daughter!" Elizabeth cried, not finishing her sentence.

"What?!" Philippe yelled back, in response.

When Elizabeth finally breathed in enough air, she began howling. "Sophia, you're grounded! Your art class is over! No more cell phones! No more tablets! No more laptops!"

Fleeing from her father's grasp, Sophia ran upstairs.

Sob after sob, Sophia locked herself in her room. She wanted to convince herself to remain loyal, for Jericho.

A few hours after pouring out all her emotions, she rummaged through all her diaries. By coincidence, she saw some photos of Giovanni inserted in between the pages. She was so torn apart! Struggling with confusion and mixed emotions, she decided to read all her diaries, hoping to clear her heart out. Once and for all.

Page by page, no word slipped past her eyes. Diary after diary, it was all clear to her now. It was Jericho whom her heart was always longing for. Not Giovanni.

Bawling and bawling, Sophia couldn't believe how she betrayed the deceased Giovanni, when the Jericho of her childhood was all she ever desired to be with.

"I'm so sorry," she wept incessantly, over Giovanni's old photos.

Chapter 22

The One Step Behind Your Silhouette

IT had been days since Sophia was grounded and Jericho could not contact her anymore. She imprisoned herself in her room, sulking, and Philippe was already worried for her.

"Eliz, I'm her father. I have the right to know everything." Philippe's tone was more than tinged with fear as he pleaded with his wife, at the front porch, that sundown. "At least you can explain to me about this Jericho."

When Elizabeth opened her mouth, nothing came out at first, but she instantly recovered and started to spill out some details. "He's from Forest Green. Mom told me that he's poor and the son of an insane woman, there. Mom doesn't like him and warned me about him."

"Eliz, so what if his mother is insane! You can't just judge a person, through that!"

"I think you should ask your mom about him, Phil." Elizabeth unintentionally raised her voice. "She just can't be so utterly wrong."

"I'm very worried for Sophia, Eliz. I think... I think you should talk to her," Philippe answered back, trying to calm himself down.

Wishing to end all the dramatic episodes in the house, Elizabeth listened to her husband, and agreed to what he asked of her.

"You're right! I missed Sophia already." Elizabeth let loose the knot that was squeezing her heart. Agreeing to Philippe was probably the best solution for now.

"I'll walk you to her room," Philippe gladly offered.

"All right."

"When you were arguing with Sophia, I heard the word pregnant. What do you mean?" Philippe dared to ask while they were heading to Sophia's room, but he was thrown away like wild waves breaking on the shore. The word *pregnant* just gave him goose bumps.

Elizabeth did not answer him right away. She arranged, first, the better kind of words, in her mind, mulling over how she would tell him.

But Philippe was already becoming uneasy, with her facial reaction.

"Hon, it's just my suspicion and I... hope it is wrong," Elizabeth admitted, with regret.

Philippe pulsated, but he remained brave for the situation. Picturing his daughter in the morning sickness mode was already starting to cause him chills.

Sophia was on her bed, now, drained because of hunger and thirst. Her parents knocked on the door, but she was determined to ignore them.

Her father knocked over and over, and requested her to open it.

Bothered by the unending knocks, Sophia finally got up and opened it against her will, her eyes bloody and puffy, and her hair looking like it had gone through a hurricane.

When her parents saw her, they were badly distressed. They took a step closer, but Sophia spun away from them.

"Honey, I'm so sorry!" Elizabeth, without ado, apologized, and trailed after her. Then, a tight hug ensued.

Sophia did not hug her mother back. Her mind was floating.

"Sophia, honey, let's go downstairs. I cooked a lot of seafood." At any rate, Philippe spoke, and managed to be cheerful.

Gazing at her daughter, Elizabeth tried to fix Sophia's hair and to wipe away her tears. Then, she held her hand carefully and led her to the dining room, with Philippe on the side.

Alex and Nadine were already at the dining table. When they saw Sophia, Nadine suddenly jumped from her seat to clasp her.

"Oh, I miss my sister!" Nadine expressed, squeezing Sophia like it was the last time.

Like a slice at the heart, Sophia endeavored to fight the inexplicable emotions she felt, at that very moment. It seemed like everyone was concerned enough, and yet she remained silently stubborn. She couldn't forget Jericho.

Alex pulled out Sophia's seat. "Take a seat, sis… and welcome back," he winked, smiling.

They began eating, and they all ogled Sophia. They could feel her extreme hunger.

"Alex, I've never seen Sophie eat that much before! It's kind of weird!" whispered Nadine to Alex.

"Me too, Nad. She must be really hungry," Alex whispered back, while stealing a look at Sophia.

Sensing that every eye was fixed upon her, Sophia dropped down her spoon and fork over her almost-empty plate, and continued chewing. "Please stop watching! I did not eat for almost two days," she pressed, while her eyes were entirely focused on the remnants of her grilled halibut with peach and pepper salsa.

"Yeah! Dad, did you cook all these? They are really delicious but I prefer this shrimp taco salad, and these seared scallops, and these clawed lobsters, and these weird-looking mussels, too!" Nadine ventured to divert the topic, as she pointed each dish, one by one.

"Yes, Dad. They are really good!" Alex appended as he put more seafood on his plate, as if he could munch them too, all at once.

Philippe and Elizabeth passed a forced grin at each other.

When Sophia was done, she excused herself and hurriedly went back, upstairs, without any word.

Her parents watched her go upstairs, determined to remain strong, because of all their family's dilemma. They tried to convince themselves that it was nothing, and they were trying to make up for all the years they neglected her, in Forest Green.

"Sophie is still beautiful, even in her gloomy days." Nadine was animated again, recharging their talk.

"As beautiful as you, honey!" Elizabeth returned, from her cavernous inner thoughts, and quickly presented Nadine with an adoring smile, to make her feel valued, too.

"Of course!" Philippe synchronized, feeling he needed to resurrect the mood, too.

They were done with eating, when they heard the doorbell.

Philippe volunteered to open it and rose from his seat. Opening the door, he was surprised to see a strange guy dressed in his finest. It was Jericho. He missed Sophia so much that he finally had the nerve to go and introduce himself to her parents, to her family.

"Good evening, Dr. Vabueretti!" Jericho appeared timid yet strong-minded.

"Yes?" Philippe eyed him, from head to toe.

"I'm Dr. Jericho Leivinhyde and I'm here for... Sophia." Jericho straightened up and offered his trembling hand, for a hand shake.

Philippe was taken aback at why a doctor wanted to see his daughter, especially at that hour. He accepted Jericho's hand shake, and noticed a bouquet of red roses behind his back. Consequently, he welcomed him inside the house.

Elizabeth, curious about the strange male voice, followed, and saw Jericho.

"Honey, this is Dr. Jericho Leivinhyde and he wished to see our daughter Sophia."

Hearing his name, Elizabeth instantly pulled back, but Jericho greeted her in the most polite manner. Still shocked, Elizabeth decided to act hospitable and clueless. But she was surprised to learn that Jericho was actually a doctor. All she knew, from her mother-in-law, was that he was underprivileged.

Accordingly, Philippe offered Jericho a seat.

Jericho Leivinhyde, Elizabeth pondered over his name as she watched Jericho take a seat. Then, she faced him again.

"So, Dr. Leivinhyde…" Philippe initially spoke and gawked at him, wondering, again, why a doctor wanted to see his daughter.

Elizabeth's next impulse was to try to offer Jericho something to drink, but she was so disturbed, that she confronted him right away.

"So, Jericho, what do you want from my daughter?" Elizabeth's eyes examined him penetratingly, and it just melted Jericho down, like a dying candle.

Jericho? Philippe heavily wondered, and finally registered, in his mind, that he was the Jericho who Elizabeth was pertaining to. But… how could he be… for he was much older than Sophia? And so, Philippe scrutinized Jericho piercingly, and with this face that turned cold.

For a full minute, there was an uncomfortable silence.

Before long, Jericho cleared his throat to break the quietness that was causing him too much burden.

"I'm hoping to see Sophia. I couldn't contact her for days, now, and I'm already worried for her," he explained, with a massive fear in his heart. "I also came here, hoping to explain some things to you," he continued, still ill-at-ease.

"How old are you, Dr. Leivinhyde?" Philippe interrogated. His face turned even colder.

Jericho swiftly thought of how he was going to answer, them, as he decided to go for honesty. "I'm... twenty-one, Dr. Vabueretti," he said, with his head bowed down.

To their utmost shock, Philippe's and Elizabeth's mouths absolutely hung wide open.

"Twenty one?" they asked themselves, unbelieving.

Jericho faced them again, and even managed a trembling smile that almost split his face from ear to ear. Then, he repeated, "Yes, sir. I'm twenty-one."

"Before I go to Sophia, I want to know about you, Dr. Leivinhyde." Elizabeth swallowed her wish to remain distant.

"What do you want to know, Atty. Vabueretti?" Jericho respectfully asked, his face halfway between pleasure and tension.

Elizabeth was, again, surprised. *How come he knew my profession?* "Everything about you," Elizabeth carried on, pretending she knew nothing about him.

Jericho looked down again and camouflaged his nervousness by trying to pull out a lively grin. Then, he began telling them that he was from Forest Green and that he used to go to the same school with Sophia.

"Oh, really?" Philippe was exceptionally intrigued.

"Well, uh…" Jericho slowed down to choose the best words to say, his body language already speaking louder than what he was about to tell. "She was in grade school and—"

"You were in high school," Elizabeth interfered, not allowing Jericho to finish talking. Her disapproval at their untimely, childish *dalliance* suddenly registered in her eyes. And Jericho sensed it.

"Yes, ma'am."

"I hope you don't mind, Dr. Leivinhyde, but I think Sophia is already sleeping." Elizabeth lifted an eyebrow, at him.

Jericho's face displayed sudden disappointment, but he survived, to act as if it was fine with him. He came to realize that Elizabeth simply did not like him for her daughter.

"May I ask you, then, to give this to Sophia?" Jericho struggled with himself, as he left the bouquet of flowers on the glass table, before them.

"Yes, we will." Elizabeth bestowed him a fake smile, and Jericho just felt it.

Jericho stood up and thanked them again.

Accompanying him to the door, Philippe flung a grin. "You're welcome."

Jericho battled against his dismay. *They don't like you*. His negative thoughts conquered him as he initiated a step back into his car. *But I want to see her. I miss her so much, yet I couldn't see her*. Still, he was resolute, thinking of endless ways to see Sophia. Again.

"I can't believe he's a doctor," Elizabeth told Philippe as she made her way to throw the bouquet of flowers into the trash can.

"So, is it him? The one you were suspecting?"

"Yes, Phil. And I don't like him. His family background is no-good."

Chapter 23

Hold On

SOPHIA dove into the kitchen and saw her dad relaxing, with a steaming cup of coffee latte.

"Good morning, sunshine! How's your sleep?" Philippe took a partial sip of it and watched his daughter open the fridge.

"Dad…?"

"Hmm…" Philippe murmured while resting the cup on the kitchen table. Afterwards, he looked at her again, discerning an admission of guilt in his daughter's voice. His eyes appeared poignant, as he waited for Sophia to go on with her sentence.

"I am really sorry," Sophia stated with bowed head.

"About what, honey?" Philippe intended to act dumb.

"About everything, Dad. I know I caused you some trouble."

Philippe endured watching her make an apology. He could almost hear the howling in his daughter's voice.

"Dad, I—" Sophia's voice unexpectedly faltered.

"Come here." Now, Philippe opened his arms to receive her into his shoulders. "Let's just get your memory back, okay?" he incorporated with a hoarse voice.

Coincidentally, Elizabeth saw them and intruded. She just came from the grocery store, with Alex and Nadine.

"Honey, I need to talk to you." Elizabeth held up Sophia, and plunked the grocery bags down, on the table.

Sophia agreed by nodding, unable to look at her mom straight.

"Jericho came here last night," Elizabeth said.

"Why didn't you tell me, Mom?" Sophia's eyes immediately dilated.

"I didn't know he's a doctor." Elizabeth avoided Sophia's thwarted stare and allowed her breath in a hiss. "Sophia, honey, you're sixteen. At least for him, he already has a profession but you... you need to finish your schooling first. Besides, you're still in high school." Elizabeth now began to reprimand.

Sophia was brought to a standstill, looking straight at the floor. She did not want to argue anymore, with her mom.

But Elizabeth continued.

"Sophia, you are too young for this. You don't know what love is. Please, don't be carried away. You're just a teenager!" Elizabeth stressed. "As your mother… yes, I understand your teenage affection. I've been your age once, but Sophia, I'm telling you... one day, you'll wake up and realize... that everything you felt was all a huge mistake," Elizabeth said it straight. "Believe me, whatever it is that you're feeling for him, is nothing but hormones!"

Sophia looked at her mom as if she wanted to answer her back, but then she chose to remain silent.

"I want you to stay away from him, Sophia!" Elizabeth's tone turned even more serious.

Hearing these words, Sophia shifted her eyes even more, downwards, wrestling with the dragons in her mind.

Then, there was a flash of stillness. They both realized… Philippe had observed them.

About a minute after, a word finally came out of Sophia. "Mom…?"

"Yes?"

"You know that this is not my first time to be in a relationship."

"Yes, I am fully aware of that. But please, not with him."

"Why are you so harsh when it comes to him? I thought grandma is the only one who doesn't like him!" Now Sophia distanced herself from her mother.

"Because he is not right for you! As simple as that!"

"What do you know about what is right, Mom? I may have amnesia but I know I love him." Sophia was unbending. "I went over my diaries and I read everything about him, and about my life in Forest Green." Sophia squeezed her eyes shut. "Mom, I was unhappy when I was in Forest Green! But Jericho… he was the only one I had, back there, who cared for me."

"What are you saying, Sophia? So, you mean to say that your grandma never cared for you? Not even Bea?" Elizabeth shouted, her eyes fully wide opened and voice continually rising. "I can't believe he has already poisoned your innocent young mind!"

"Mom, I read everything and my life was miserable there! I was desperate! You can never imagine how desperate I was, how devastated my pathetic little life was because you were not there... but Jericho... he was always there for me..." Sophia fought back the tears that started to blind her eyes.

Philippe and Elizabeth fell quiet. They were roughly distressed with the words they heard from their daughter, particularly regarding her desolation during her stay in Forest Green. Elizabeth, in fact, felt so low, now, when she realized she had probably made a mistake in leaving Sophia, to grow up, at Forest Green, away from her. Oh, Heavens! If only she could turn back time! But then... she was back, again, to her problem with Jericho!

"No, Sophia! No! Stop it! I'm your mother and you must obey me!" Elizabeth tried to assert herself, for the last time.

"Mother? Obey you? For what I know, a mother does not abandon her child. Not even temporarily. You'll never understand!" Sophia countered, and left them crossly.

Philippe's first impulse was to chase after her and stop her, but he thought Sophia might need some space, at the moment.

"Let her go!" Elizabeth declared. "I can't believe she just spoke to me that way, and in front of you!"

With mixed emotions, Sophia hurried outside the front porch, and then her emotions got the better of her. Struggling to hold back her unwanted tears, she left the house and headed... nowhere.

It happened that Jericho was observing, a few meters away from their house, when he suddenly saw Sophia leaving, in a bad mood. He let Sophia saunter away, until she was far enough. Then, he followed her, guardedly.

Sophia was walking blankly when she noticed a sluggish car behind her. She turned around and discovered that it was Jericho's.

Jericho, at once, got out of his car and ran towards her. He became disheartened the moment he saw those tears streaming down her face. Unwavering, however, he dashed to comfort her.

"Hey… what happened?"

Sophia sent a message of I'm-not-okay through her reddened eyes.

A step closer, Jericho volunteered to wipe her tears.

"What happened?" he repeated, his nerves exposed.

"Jericho…" finally, Sophia spoke, but it was very low and heart-wrenching.

"Sophia…?"

"Jericho, please take me away from here," Sophia begged, her tone shredding him into pieces.

"Where do you want to go?"

Sobbing, she reached out for his arms and put her face on his muscular shoulder.

Jericho openly welcomed her in his arms, and hoped she would find them warm enough to surround her with all the comfort she needed.

"Anywhere, Jericho. Please, just take me away from here," Sophia begged, still under his zealous embrace.

Absorbing the depth of her cries, Jericho was persuaded.

"Okay," he spoke low, too, and slowly released her, still volunteering to wipe away her tears that continued to fall past her trembling lips.

Immediately, Jericho opened his car and assisted her. Not prolonging the agony of her situation, he made haste to bring the engine back to life. He didn't know where to take her, but he just drove on and on, feeling desperate himself. He could not think of a place where she could be soothed.

Sophia's quietness bothered Jericho, but he was battling with himself regarding where to take her, and how to bring her anguish to an end.

After half an hour of silently driving, Jericho was thrown into bewilderment, when Sophia said she wanted to go to Forest Green to clear everything— and to be with him.

Jericho, shocked and instantly worn out, disagreed, saying that her family would only look for her. Plus, her Grandma Lucy was in Forest Green.

Sophia insisted through and through, until Jericho could no longer afford to say no.

"Please, Jericho... I want to know everything back there." Sophia's plea sounded like the wild waves tossing him back to the seashore.

Drawing for more breaths, Jericho declined, "Sophia, we will go back there, but not now. And your parents would be looking for you." He had gone through the most tormenting place, when he faced her parents, once, and he wanted to tell her that, about last night.

"Please, Jericho. I beg of you. Take me there. We grew up there, together, and... we had each other there. Why can't you understand that?"

With these words, Jericho was put to a sudden halt, and he looked at her steadily. Like a falling drop of water, he fell into those compelling ocean-blue eyes of hers.

Speared and controlled by her gaze, Jericho took a U-turn, and suddenly drove for Forest Green.

Philippe was trying not to turn into a blazing fire, with his worry for Sophia. "Eliz, I don't think I should overreact this way, but I'm really worried for our daughter," Philippe confessed to Elizabeth, right after the minor argument.

"Okay, I'll look for her." Elizabeth initiated a walk, and went to the front yard to look for her daughter. To her disappointment, there was no Sophia there. She went over to their covered car park, but Sophia was also not there.

"I don't see her at all." Elizabeth walked over to Philippe, as she went back inside the house.

"I'll call Zarah's parents. Perhaps, she's there." Philippe tried to relieve his growing tension, before grasping the telephone.

"Alex, have you seen Sophia?" Elizabeth yelled, for her son to hear, from his room upstairs.

"No, Mom but... I'll check her room," Alex yelled back. He went out of his room and headed for Sophia's.

"Where are you, Sophia?" Elizabeth asked silently, bothered by the immense doubts suddenly looming in her head.

"Mom, she's not in her room," Alex shouted again, now in a hurry to join his parents and search.

"They're not answering their phone," Philippe told Elizabeth.

"Maybe, Zarah and her parents are still in Europe," Elizabeth said.

"No, Mom. Zarah and her parents are already back here, "Alex meddled.

"Then, where is she?" Philippe was now openly worrying.

"Maybe, she just went somewhere, where she could free her mind." Alex attempted to be optimistic.

"I don't know, but I'm worried already," Elizabeth poured out, massaging her chest, that felt truly weighty.

"I think I should go to the security guards to check on the CCTVs," Philippe said quickly. He suddenly looked so tired.

"That's a good idea, Dad!" Alex approved.

"Honey, I'll come with you!" Elizabeth looked hassled, too.

"Okay! And Alex, look after Nadine!" Philippe ordered.

"Yes, Dad!"

Philippe and Elizabeth arrived at the security headquarter, and requested the guards to look over the video footages.

They were accommodated immediately.

Soon, one of security guards who was familiar with Sophia, recalled that in a video of two hours ago, he saw her walking around the park.

Quickly, Philippe and Elizabeth gawked at the video and confirmed that it was their daughter. They continued watching it until it showed a car in slow motion, which approached Sophia. They were thrown into a pit when Jericho came into sight.

"What!" Elizabeth, in a blast, reacted in fury. Her hatred of him worsened exponentially. "That guy again!"

"Where do you think he took her?" Philippe moderately asked her, so as not to create a scene.

"I don't know but I have this dreadful feeling." Elizabeth struggled to allay herself from another bout of worrying.

"Excuse me, Atty. Vabueretti. If you don't mind... we can trace the car," Mr. Hilling, the head of security, said. At least, something could be done to lessen Elizabeth's heavy load.

"Yes, Mr. Hilling. Will you?"

"Right away, attorney!" Mr. Hilling called his contacts, the city security officers, and asked them to trace a Prius car with a plate number of EMC 513.

Straight away, they were informed that the car left the city about an hour ago, heading to Orstia, the province where Forest Green is located.

Elizabeth was greatly terrified.

Did they elope? she cried silently, and Philippe tried to prevent her from collapsing.

Elizabeth, though seemingly turning blank and weakened, managed to whisper something to her husband. "Let's stop them. Please."

On the double, Philippe thanked the security guards and dragged Elizabeth back to the car. He contacted Grandma Lucy, so she could keep an eye peeled, for Sophia, in Forest Green.

"No, Philippe! We will go to Forest Green ourselves!" Elizabeth was strong-willed enough, in saying it, as they made their way back to their house. "I'm afraid that something might happen to her!"

"Okay, honey, but... let's go home first, okay? Alex and Nadine are waiting for us," Philippe sighed. "I'm gonna call the cops, too."

Elizabeth, with her worry spilling over, was not able to give Philippe a response, anymore.

Philippe understood her silence, and concentrated his eyes on the road.

Just as they arrived home, Elizabeth rushed inside and asked Alex and Nadine to pack at least two pairs of garments.

"You're going to sleep at Julia's house," she told them. "It's temporary. I'll call Grandpa Randy and Grandma Emily to come and look after you, okay?" Elizabeth reassured the two.

Alex and Nadine were confused by the fast turn of events and persistently questioned why they would sleep over, at their mother's best friend. And, they were asking for Sophia.

Philippe and Elizabeth implored that the two would sleep over at Julia's, while they would be looking for Sophia.

Full of queries, the two had no choice but to follow their parents. Mystified, they prepared their things.

The couple had dropped Alex and Nadine at Julia's, and then headed, right away, for Forest Green.

"Phil, please drive as fast as you can."

"I'm on it, hon. By the way, mom's really worried."

Elizabeth moaned heavily.

"She has already assigned her workers there to look out for Sophia," Philippe continued, then turned all his attention to the road.

"That's good, honey," Elizabeth managed to say something. She gazed out of the car window, questioning herself… Why did Sophia do such a thing to them? Then, her mind flew back to the past, and remembered how the teenager Francheska did the same act of running away, when she was on the brink of her dreams, but was pregnant with the unwanted Sophia. Yet Elizabeth achingly hoped for the better: that this time they would find Sophia, get her back to Orlando, and fix her life so she could be a normal teenage girl… Unlike what happened to Francheska.

Oh, that poor, Francheska! Where could she have disappeared to, all this time?

By sunset, Jericho and Sophia were almost at Forest Green, when they suddenly noticed a car that blocked the way. It belonged to Grandma Lucy. Her workers, including Bea, were there.

Extremely surprised, Sophia slid out of the car and asked Bea why they were there.

"Sophia, your grandma has been searching the town and I'm afraid the cops will arrest Jericho," Bea answered, with a shuddering voice.

"Why would they do that?" Sophia's face immediately displayed disquiet.

"Your dad called your grandma and told her that you're with Jericho. Now, your grandma is accusing Jericho of kidnapping you. He could be arrested because you're a minor."

"What?" Sophia's knees trembled. "N—no, that is not true! I went, willingly, he did not kidnap me!" Sophia asserted, even though she almost lost her nerve.

"Sophia, I think you can just stay here with us now and tell Jericho to surrender, when the sheriffs get here." Bea was straight in saying it.

"No, Auntie Bea!" Sophia stiffened. Promptly, she spun, at fast motion, to hug Jericho, who had just stepped out of his car.

Jericho instantly tried to calm her. He had heard everything, and was trying to be strong.

"Jericho, what are we going to do?" Sophia leaned her shivering head on his shoulder. "I'm scared, Jericho. I'm scared."

Bea walked closer, towards them, and told Jericho to surrender when the cops get there, but Sophia tried to be assertive.

"No, Auntie Bea! That won't happen to Jericho!"

"But why, Sophia?"

Sophia's eyes conveyed a doleful plea to Bea. "Because my family hates him! Oh, Auntie Bea, please, tell us where to go! They must not see us here! Please!"

Bea was speechless, for a moment.

Sophia's face grew beseeching. "Please, Auntie Bea, please!" Now, her teardrops began to fall, like rain.

Bea looked at them emotionally. She was, somehow, touched by their wretched appearance. "Go to the lake house for a while," she instructed, shaking. "I'll tell them we never saw you!"

"Thank you, Auntie Bea." Sophia, on the spot, embraced her.

"But how about them?" Jericho pertained to Bea's companions.

"I will take care of it," Bea reassured. "Just go! Quickly!"

Jericho started the car again and drove straight to the lake house.

When they arrived there, the place appeared dusky and silent. Lending Sophia a hand while sitting down on the front porch, Jericho consoled her. Sophia was looking disconsolate.

"Jericho, why do we have to go through all these?" Sophia, all of a sudden, asked, crying even more.

Jericho drew in a lungful of air and heaved a quick sigh. He could feel her panicking again, and probably missing her family. She was having second thoughts. Then, Jericho held her even tighter. "I'll take care of you, Sophia. We're going to survive this," he bolstered her and devotedly palmed her tense hands, to stop them from shaking. "I think it's too late to pretend that you didn't leave them..."

"I don't have any regrets being with you here, though," Sophia whispered, feeling the warmth of his tender caress and very potent reassurance. "It's just that, I—I feel for my parents, now..."

"I know! I don't regret being with you, too," Jericho whispered back and further wrapped his hands around her. "And right now, it feels so good... just you and me, here, alone together... like we used to do..."

Chapter 24

Come What May

THE night deepened and yet the two still soothed each other, at the lake house's front porch.

With his car's head lights alight, to brighten up the place, Jericho strove to have some cell phone signal. He had to call his cousin, Reuben, for the things they needed, for the night.

The moment he finally spotted a signal, Jericho called Reuben and begged him to be vigilant in leaving the town proper.

When Reuben got there swiftly, he gave Jericho the things he asked him, even the spare key of the lake house that Grandma Lucy entrusted to him.

Sophia went to Reuben and thanked him but Reuben was suddenly awestruck... quickly fascinated by her. He didn't know the little Sophia he remembered had turned into a very fine lady, with a very astounding face.

No wonder my cousin would kill himself for her, Reuben thought. *She's… a goddess!*

Jericho plainly saw how Reuben looked at Sophia, in a passionate way, as if Reuben could liquefy her. Troubled by it, he instantly asked Reuben to leave, but Reuben offered to guard them for the night.

"Jericho, it's too dangerous for just the two of you here," Reuben insisted, but Jericho already doubted him. He was still bothered by how Reuben looked at Sophia.

"Jericho, I think you should agree," Sophia begged him.

Eventually, Jericho agreed, but it was against his will. Something in him seemed to warm him.

Then, all of them went inside.

Philippe and Elizabeth had just arrived at Grandma Lucy's. Faster than anything, they looked for Sophia.

"The cops are still searching for her," said Grandma Lucy, as she received them, at the front yard.

"Where else would they go?" Elizabeth said, troubled once more, and silence served as the answer.

At the lake house, Jericho was pacing here and there, uncomfortable at Reuben's presence.

Exhausted, Sophia excused herself and went upstairs, but Reuben dirty-eyed her long legs, even though they were covered by her faultlessly-fitted blue jeans. Reuben's look at Sophia's figure pushed Jericho to the limit.

"Reuben, look! She's my girlfriend!" Jericho rose from his seat, and boldly faced him.

"Dude, what are you talking about?" Reuben said, defensively.

"What am I talking about? You think I did not see the way you looked at her?" Then Jericho pushed him.

Reuben reacted forcefully too, and aimed to throw some punches.

From upstairs, Sophia heard the sounds of arguing, and dashed back to check on them. Seeing the two pushing each other, she darted between them, to stop them.

"Please, stop!" she yelped, with terrified eyes.

The two were suddenly put to a stop.

"Sophia? I—" Jericho ached to explain himself but his mouth was absolutely frozen. He could not find the words to, somehow, clarify his misconduct.

Reuben immediately removed Jericho's grip on his black leather jacket and left, his anger blazing.

Watching Reuben bang the door heavily, Sophia faced Jericho and asked for some explanations.

"What has just happened?"

"Please, don't get me wrong, Sophia." Jericho could see how Sophia scowled. In the face of it, he moved fast to explain his misbehavior.

Sophia listened to him.

Finally reaching the town proper, Reuben, by chance, was seen by Grandma Lucy, when he passed by.

"Reuben!" Grandma Lucy shouted to him.

Reuben heard it and pulled over.

"Do you have any idea about my granddaughter's whereabouts?"

To get the score even, Reuben revealed that the two were actually at the lake house.

Grandma Lucy felt cold, with disbelief, but she survived the shock, and straightway, informed Philippe and Elizabeth, including the three cops who were interviewing them.

Bea tensed the very second she heard it all.

Without beating around the bush, all of them started their engines and went to the lake house, in a flash.

"Jericho…?" Sophia nudged Jericho, while she was trying to dry her hair.

"Um?"

"How did you…?"

"What?" Jericho earnestly beamed at her, as he sat beside her on a bench, made up of woven rattan. They both just had a shower, separately, of course.

Sophia smiled back.

"What?" Jericho repeated.

The scent of his fresh bath crept into Sophia's senses, as she managed to look at him.

"What do you want to know, Sophia?" Jericho asked again, entertaining himself with the sight of her, drying her hair.

"How did you become a doctor, that fast?"

Jericho now paused, swallowed a large lump in his throat, and thought of words to say.

"After you left Forest Green…" Jericho took his eyes away from Sophia, and exhaled deeply. "After you left, I attended a lot of advance classes. I wanted to fit into your world so fast, so that I… I bled myself, almost to death, just to finish med school."

Sophia bowed her head in guilt and shame. She knew Jericho was very smart, but to learn that she was actually the reason behind his struggles… a piping hot blade sliced her heart apart. *I'm sorry*, was all she was able to say.

"I'm fine now," Jericho spoke again. "I've got you now… and I could not ask for more."

Cloud nine, indeed! Sophia could feel what Jericho was feeling! They were both swarming with the same emotions! And that statement she heard, just now, was a sign that she was finally forgiven. And as she processed Jericho's last sentence in her mind, teardrops promptly overflowed. Her eyes were somewhat apologetic and grateful at the same time.

"Oh, Sophia!" Jericho rushed to catch her lips, tasting the saline in her tears. He didn't care. All he ever longed for was a slice of heaven.

The harsh sounds of vehicles distracted them.

Jericho hurried away, to look through the windows, and saw vehicle lights heading towards the lake house. Hastily, he asked Sophia to prepare, for they would now hide in the forest.

Sophia was alarmed but she was not reluctant to leave. She and Jericho speedily went into the forest. Unknowingly, in her haste, Sophia left her silver bracelet on the lounge table.

The cops moved in, and began inspecting the lake house.

Philippe and Elizabeth went after them with the hope of seeing Sophia.

"The shower room's wet but no one is upstairs," one of the cops informed Grandma Lucy.

By chance, Elizabeth saw her daughter's bracelet on the table. "They've been here!" She announced, and clutched the bracelet.

Philippe's chest crumpled. Looking at the bracelet, he remembered that he gave it to Sophia. He strode on, in search for her, his worry deepening.

With Grandma Lucy's emotions in a state of tumult, she beseeched them to search the forest.

Jericho and Sophia were running fast, and heading for the dim forest, now.

Sophia got tired and begged Jericho to rest for a while.

Jericho let her, but the sound of voices shouting ruptured his heart, to die. Swiftly, he begged Sophia to continue running.

They kept running and running until they were approaching a high cliff. They did not anticipate it, in the darkness of the night. The two went on running until Jericho accidentally stepped on a rock, fell to the ground, and lost consciousness.

Sophia, five steps ahead of him, saw what happened to him. On impulse, she stopped, too, but her last step did not land on the soil.

She had fallen, too late, from the high cliff!

Sophia screamed her heart out—an intense heart-stopping moment!

Sophia felt the wind upon her and knew she was falling fast. She grew weak. She looked up at the dark sky filled with tiny and sparkling stars but then—out of the blue—she felt that something had caught her. Her vision was fading in the growing darkness, when a blurred face came into sight, and she also heard the beating of... wings.

It was Abanir. He heard her screaming during his wandering, and he immediately came to her rescue.

The cops and Philippe endured searching the wild forest while Grandma Lucy and Elizabeth stayed at the lake house.

"Mom," Elizabeth immensely cried to her mother-in-law.

Heartfelt, Grandma Lucy hushed her.

"I'm sorry that this is happening."

"It's not your fault, Eliz."

"I can't believe Sophia would do such thing."

"Don't blame Sophia, Eliz. Blame Jericho." Grandma Lucy persevered to face Elizabeth. "Jericho's the one who keeps on chasing her. If only he did not enter her life again, Sophia could have been just fine."

"Oh, that Jericho!"

"Yes, Eliz. That boy keeps on ruining my granddaughter's life!"

"What should we do now?" Elizabeth stifled another sob.

"I have a plan. You'll see."

Overwhelmed by the presence of the unconscious Sophia in his arms, Abanir decided to temporarily land her at the forest. At first, he did not know what to do but he was distracted to see her right foot bleeding. He carefully laid her under the acacia tree and shadowed his eyes upon her. Then, he left, for the meantime, to pick some guava leaves nearby; the kind of leaves that Vangkekans ordinarily used for wounds to prevent infection.

About ten minutes passed, he went back to her, milled the leaves, and placed them over her wounds, accompanying it with a gentle palming. Then, he drew closer to examine her face—peaceful and magnificent.

He lingered observing her but it was cut when Rabel suddenly landed and went directly to him.

It was such a bolt from the blue for Rabel to see a human with his raha. He staggered, unknowing how to react next.

"Raha, what have you done?" Rabel asked when he finally recovered from his shock.

"Rabel, this is the strange creature that I was telling you about!"

"How? How did you…?" Rabel faltered.

"She was falling from a high cliff when I came to her rescue."

Rabel further pulsated. His conscience was killing him, deciding if he had to reveal anything he knew about the humans.

"My Raha…" Rabel spoke more when something in him pulled him back to continue his sentence. He remembered Datu Ilak's order: that his raha must not know anything about the humans. But soon, he finally admitted, "Raha, that strange creature is a human."

"Human?" Abanir wondered. "What is a human?"

"My Raha, humans are..." Rabel stiffened to finish his revelation.

"What, Rabel? Tell me!" Abanir's eyes dilated.

"My Raha, they are like us but they are one of our enemies." Rabel, in a weak-willed voice, avoided Abanir's eager eyes.

"Enemies?" Abanir pondered heavily.

"Yes, my Raha. They are enemies," Rabel repeated, bowing down his head to the limit.

"But why?"

"Humans once tried to invade us." Now, Rabel procured a long gape at Sophia, and examined her carefully.

Abanir also landed her a stare, a blend of fondness and curiosity.

Innocent face! Dead to the world as her wounds persisted to outflow more blood.

"Rabel, this human needs me," Abanir carried on, narrowing his eyes to study her wounds further.

"But Raha, the tribe will be in trouble if you take her to the palasyon," Rabel opposed greatly.

"But her wounds are bleeding heavily and she needs further treatment," Abanir asserted. "I'll take her to Shamante." At speed, Abanir carried her.

"But Raha, you're making a big mistake!" Rabel contradicted again but Abanir finally flew her in the air.

Datu Ilak and Reyna Kaya were in shock to see Abanir carrying, in his hands, a human.

Rabel hid at Abanir's back, afraid of Datu Ilak's reaction. Hiding was the better choice, he thought, for he was not able to warn his sepe to put some distance, from the human.

"My son, why are you with...?" Datu Ilak asked, his eyes dilating, and his body suddenly shaking, badly.

"Ilo, I saw her falling from a high cliff and I…" Abanir was temporarily put to a halt by his parents' deepening, intense look. "She needs our help. She is wounded."

Datu Ilak and Reyna Kaya were still surprised by their son's actions but they decided to help the human. But, they warned Abanir and Rabel that it should be a serious secret.

Datu Ilak ordered Rabel to call for Shamante, the tribe's healer. Rabel obeyed him and flew off quickly.

While they were waiting, Datu Ilak asked his son to return the human, very early, the next morning, for her prolonged disappearance from her kin would surely cause a menace to their tribe.

Abanir was silent and hesitant. He felt torn into two.

In a short while, Rabel and Shamante arrived.

Datu Ilak suddenly asked Shamante to keep what he was about to see, a top-secret.

Shamante concurred then he was startled to see a strange creature, in strange clothes, lying down on the bamboo bed.

A human, he presumed, for she had no pair of wings. He reacted with uncertainty, but Abanir begged him, again and again.

In due course, Shamante was convinced to help.

Chapter 25

The Miracle Plants

SHAMANTE cleaned up Sophia's wounds with the extracts of guava leaves, which were believed by their tribe, to possess antiseptic properties, and dried them with the tiny leaves of ogbo tree, presumed to relieve the pain. Next, he pulverized the magical ula-ula and hala-hala shrubs (found exclusively in Kravena), using clay mortar and pestle, and applied them directly on Sophia's wounds. Then, he used the hard and wide stalks of the two magical shrubs to hold up the poultice. Right after that, Shamante asked Rabel to ignite a candlestick made of hayan (a mixture of different aromatic herbs), which could send a comforting effect to Sophia's nostrils.

Everyone watched and waited for the results.

Now done and feeling confident, Shamante stood up and approached Datu Ilak, but he was quickly reminded by the datu not to reveal anything to anyone, otherwise, grave punishment would be bestowed upon him. Shamante heartedly agreed, and left.

Before long, Sophia gained consciousness. Bit by bit, she opened her weary eyes. Then, she was enormously shocked to see how different her new world had become.

Such strange environment! Bamboo walls designed with woven coconut leaves!

She looked up and saw a roof made up of huge dried leaves that she was unfamiliar with! Furthermore, she was dazed to find herself lying on a bed that looked like nests. She tried to look around once more, and was repeatedly shocked at everything. It was all so... so alien!

Now, a pair of huge, white wings appeared before her eyes!

Terrified, she screamed, but Abanir, in a flash, covered her mouth to stop her. Her eyes grew wider and wider—from second to second—as he tried to hush her.

A masculine man with a pair of gigantic white wings at his back! Sophia was about to collapse. But for a heart-stopping moment, there was this eye-to-eye that they shared—ocean-blue eyes and sky-blue eyes—both dilated, unblinking.

With bedazzled eyes, now Abanir gently put his hand away from her mouth. He looked down and noticed that her hands were shivering. He tried to speak, but Sophia could not understand him.

Abanir realized that she could not understand him and so, he started communicating, using signs.

Sophia looked at him, for the moment.

Moment by moment, he tried to read her mind.

Sophia returned his look; her face displayed boundless fright. She was still traumatized by his very different appearance. Suddenly it hit her. Her sketch! The memory of her sketch reminded her of those gargantuan pair of wings! It was exactly the same!

At some point, she risked touching those beautiful white feathers. Then, she suddenly felt the pain on her foot. She looked down and was surprised to see some odd leaves wrapped around her foot. (She didn't know they were—leaves.)

Abanir explained by using signs, but Sophia found it really hard to understand him.

Abruptly, they were distracted when Datu Ilak, Reyna Kaya, and Rabel opened the door.

Sophia's heart pounded faster and louder. Her massive shock intensified, but Abanir was attentive enough to try to pacify her.

Like a bolt out of the blue, Sophia's world was thrown upside-down.

"Human, do not be afraid!" Datu Ilak said, but his tone put Sophia into further panic, because she could not understand his words.

Reyna Kaya witnessed her boundless fright, and attempted to ease her, by patting her hair.

Sophia trembled to the extreme, but eventually, she realized that she wasn't going to be harmed, after all.

They all ended up ogling Sophia who, then, did not know what to do next.

Chapter 26

Struck With His Eyes

IT was, by now, early dawn.

Still, Philippe and the cops could not find any traces of human beings in the forest. In need of reinforcement, they temporarily stopped, knowing that Grandma Lucy and Elizabeth might have a dispute.

Submerged into feelings of frustration and sorrow, Grandma Lucy and Elizabeth, encouraged themselves not to lose hope, upon hearing the preliminary news from the cops.

"Don't worry, I'll call for more back-up," Sheriff Murry said, making sure that the family would not feel so neglected.

Philippe thanked everyone and continued planning for the next search. For this, he called some of his friends, back in high school, and pleaded for their help.

"We will find her, Eliz." Grandma Lucy allowed Elizabeth to sink into her arms. "We will find her," she repeated, sniveling.

In Kravena, Abanir noticed how Sophia pressed her stomach, in hunger. So at once, he went to offer her water and sinapoy.

Sophia looked at the strange food. She was reluctant to eat it but she was extremely hungry, so she forced herself to chomp it all down.

Abanir enjoyed watching her but Sophia didn't mind him. To fill her empty stomach was all that mattered to her, at that time.

A minute passed and then Sophia unintentionally looked at him; she was astonished to see his blue eyes turn green.

"Your eyes!" she voiced out, awestruck, but Abanir could not understand her.

Sophia incessantly stared at his eyes, silently asking herself why he had the capability to do such a thing.

Is my sense of sight deceiving me now? she asked herself. *I'm probably hallucinating now….*

Feeling bashful, Abanir ended up blinking.

Sophia stopped eating sinapoy, and instead, looked for some water to wash her hands with.

Abanir determined her needs and carefully led her outside the palasyon, where water was abundant.

Tilting her head to follow the light, Sophia was amazed to see the Kravena houses. They were all made up of bamboos, and large, dried grasses served as rooftops.

What an extraordinary world!

In a flash, the wind blew mightily, sending some coldness down her spine.

Abanir easily noticed her chill, and straight away flew to his dulsabang for the fabric he got from the lake house. He did not know that it actually belonged to the human he was with. Then, he returned to Sophia, in a tick.

Sophia looked startled, upon seeing the familiar shawl, and wondered why it looked so different from the clothes Abanir was wearing.

At once, Abanir wrapped it around her shoulders, a gesture so intimate, that it caused Sophia a flare of uncertain bewilderment. In spite of it, she coped. Breathing in, she realized that the scent coming from the textile was quite familiar. It was hers!

The moment he was done covering her shoulders, Abanir stepped back and waited for her next move.

She, too, waited for his succeeding moves, but then other things began to jumble her thoughts. Looking up to clutch for more air, in hopes of mollifying her muddled thoughts, the brightening sky caught Sophia's unsteady eyes. It was heavenly, filled with beautiful flocks of small birds that never lost their assemble. In time, she could see those green grasses and blooming flowers all around. The scent coming from them was exceptional. She looked farther on and saw the wide field of sinapoy, its grasses dancing along with the early zephyr.

Paradise! It was all paradise!

Captivated by the view, she wished it was tattooed into her eyes and would never, ever fade.

Under her beauty's spell, Abanir himself, lingered also, to gawk at her, and oh, how he wished to ascend with her, up in the air, to help her glimpse the larger view of dreamland. The entire land.

Sophia closed her eyes and then soothed herself, with a long and deep sigh.

Watching her, and watching her face in pleasure was, by far, the best form of entertainment Abanir ever had. She appeared to be encircled with an all-pervading splendor; such beauty was beyond description!

Sophia was a magnet to him, draining all of his energy, as they both shared a riveting look at each other, now.

Turning weak, Abanir fought for self-possession.

After that, he led her back to the palasyon, before anyone in the tribe could see her, something that should never, ever happen!

She was walking with him now, when, suddenly, Sophia remembered Jericho. She felt the sudden impulse to run away, to run far, far away, to find Jericho, but she couldn't. Her painful wounds were hampering her.

"What am I doing here? Where is Jericho?" she wailed, to the utmost.

Abanir did not know what to do next. Seeing her in turmoil plunged him straight into despondency, then to uncertainty and panic.

Sophia, desperate to see Jericho, boldly faced Abanir.

"I have to leave!" she explained, in the supreme hope of being understood. "Please, I need to go!" she repeated, more loudly.

"Raha, what does she want?" Rabel ran to Abanir. He was nerve-wracked to think that she might be overheard by everyone in the tribe.

Sesa Sanaya was disturbed by the chaotic sounds and wondered where they were coming from. She arose from the bed and followed the noise.

Rabel heard Sesa Sanaya's footsteps and informed Abanir right away.

"Rabel, watch her and I will sidetrack Sanaya," Abanir promptly ordered Rabel.

Rabel followed him and approached Sophia. Unfortunately for him, Sophia finally saw an escaping hole and fled fast, without thoughts of causing a further panic.

Rabel, afraid to create further noise, was not able to stop her. He thought that if he chased her, Sophia's scream would completely disturb the entire tribe.

But Sophia's panic grew worse.

Jericho needs me! She said to herself, and she ran on and on until she felt she was far enough from the hinterland of Kravena.

Successful in sidetracking Sesa Sanaya, Abanir went back to Rabel. To his tremendous shock, the human was no longer there!

"Rabel!" he shouted.

"Raha, I'm afraid she had escaped!" Rabel trembled, while explaining.

"What? How?"

Rabel tried to speak further. "Raha, I think we can still track her. She headed for the falls."

Upon hearing it, Abanir hastily flew, and Rabel followed him.

Sophia kept on running, ignoring the pain of her wounds. All she had in mind was to see Jericho again. Catching her breath, she slowed down for a while.

Without her knowing it, a strange, medium-sized black animal, resembling a wild pig, was roaming around. When she finally sensed it, her chest heaved, with a sudden alarm. She turned and ran off, but the animal already saw her.

She was about to be attacked, but out of the blue, Abanir came and carried her off, away from danger.

Her vision waned, as Abanir carried her up, in his arms.

They landed near Harem Falls.

Abanir laid Sophia on the ground, beneath the blackberry tree, and checked on her wounds. Then, Rabel volunteered to make a plain kubot, to shelter them.

The sun elevated and the rays were already hurting Jericho's eyes. He immediately stood up and discovered that Sophia was not with him, anymore. He panicked and summoned her name, ceaselessly, until he realized that there were no traces of Sophia's whereabouts. Discovering a high cliff ahead of him, he almost died, frantic with worry.

"Sophia!" He cried out, over and over. One more emotional blow, and he felt that his sanity was about to fall into pieces. He panicked as he vacillated between belief and disbelief… regarding Sophia's possible fall into the cliff. A flashback of last night reminded him that she was a few steps ahead of him. "No!" he cried out harder. "No! Oh God, no!"

The daylight lingered. Philippe and his company were now heading to the forest, in search of Sophia. Now, more cops were with them, including K-9s. They divided themselves into three and thoroughly searched the forest.

Nightfall was already approaching. Sophia was still unconscious but Abanir never got tired of looking after her. And he never got tired of staring at her.

As for Rabel, he was almost done making a kubot. Exhausted, he went to his raha.

"She looks quiet, for now," Rabel spoke in an undertone, as he and Abanir stood before her.

Nodding, Abanir knelt down and leaned closer to her. Gingerly, he touched her upper back, wondering how it felt like, to have no pair of wings.

Rabel watched him.

Not long after, Sophia's consciousness returned.

"Ouch," she groaned as she began to move.

"No, please, your foot!" Abanir said, shouting.

Sophia halted. She looked around and noticed the deepening darkness, along with the sounds of the night... crickets, frogs, and other animals that dominated the place.

Struggling to stand up straight, Sophia's worry came back.

"Raha, she's already hungry and thirsty," Rabel assumed.

Abanir agreed, giving his utmost efforts to help her up.

"Raha, you think humans eat fish?"

"I don't know. Maybe." Abanir faced Rabel nearer. "I'll catch a fish and you can start creating a fire. It's getting dark now," he ordered, and led Sophia to the plain kubot.

Drained and still terrified, Sophia prayed. She yearned to escape but she couldn't. And the surrounding was now almost devoid of sunlight. Staying was, by far, the best choice she had.

Entering the plain kubot, Abanir bade her to sit down and wait.

Though she could only guess, Sophia thought that maybe, he wanted her to sit down. With a heavy heart, she tried to sit down, and gingerly observed the wood she just sat on. It was made up of a fallen tree trunk.

Abanir left her and went to catch some fish.

Rabel, on the other hand, collected pieces of wood and started rubbing two stones together, to ignite a fire.

From the plain kubot, Sophia watched them in motion, pondering over their wings and peculiar garments. They appeared ethnic yet still very mannish.

A rush of wind plucked at Sophia's hair, carrying a strong scent of flowers. The sweetness was soothing—but beyond human description.

"Um, the smell of dama-dama is visiting us," Rabel told Sophia. "Dama-dama," he repeated.

"Dama-dama?" Sophia whispered unconsciously, and noticed Rabel's pleasure at sniffing the air all around him.

"Yes! Dama-dama!" Rabel agreed, still doing the same gesture, of inhaling.

Sophia put on a smile, and unintentionally locked eyes with Abanir. Watching him, watching those hard muscles as he stabbed fish after fish, Sophia was astounded that his heavenly wings spread out like perfect clouds on a clean day. In a breath-taking moment, she sensed she had fallen for his charm, like the falling waters of Harem Falls. Her musings stopped the moment Abanir came back to them. With him was a dozen catch... big fishes that hung on a bamboo stick, something that he had found, floating on the water.

Sophia immediately tried to clear her head. *What am I doing? Stop it!*

Abanir handed the fishes to Rabel and ordered him to quickly toast them.

Sophia froze, feeling confused from where she was sitting, but the aromatic smell from the smoke triggered her hunger pongs.

Before long, Rabel let out a noise. "Raha, three fishes are done! I think she should eat now!"

Abanir nodded and approached him.

Carefully, Rabel handed him a whole fish which was still pierced by a bamboo stick.

Abanir hurriedly went to offer it to Sophia.

Sophia was motionless, struggling to decide what to do next, as she saw Abanir coming towards her.

Abanir stared at her, drinking in her eyes that seemed blank yet suddenly, very magnetic. Then, he handed her the fish.

In time, she accepted it, then sat on the edge, for he tried to sit down next to her.

Abanir put on a smile, a narrow one (yet silently stretching wide from the inside, for he felt like truly smiling).

Sophia returned a shy smile. "Thank you."

And though they couldn't understand each other's words, their smiles lingered, stretching their lips, until Abanir's eyes began changing into different colors again, noticeable even in the absence of clear daylight.

Sophia's eyes widened, and her mouth hung open. *What is he?* she asked, silently, unbelieving.

Witnessing her amazement, Abanir cleared his throat to lessen his own tension.

"Ahem!" Rabel intentionally distracted them, noticing the sparks blazing between them. "Raha, are you not going to join her and eat?" Rabel shouted, like he was itching to tease them.

"Ah! Yes, Rabel. I think I… I mean, we should join her," Abanir yelled back.

"Good, Raha!" Rabel reacted more blissful and turned the fire bigger, to further brighten up the place.

Still awkward in her coyness, Sophia began eating.

"Raha, you don't know her name yet!" Rabel pitched a flaring jest as he neared them.

"Ah, yes…"

In her cluelessness at their dialect, Sophia just tried to listen in.

"If you won't ask her name, I will." Rabel set forth, joking his raha, and started making signs, so as to introduce themselves to Sophia.

Sophia got it. She knew the two were trying to introduce themselves to her. But at the back of her mind, she was amazed that creatures like them also had names.

"Me Rabel!" Rabel pointed to himself as he continuously mentioned his name to Sophia. "Rabel," he repeated.

"You are… Rabel?" Sophia guessed as she pointed her finger to him.

Rabel nodded, and they were astounded by her quick guess.

"Your turn," Rabel told Abanir, with a dare.

Abanir accepted the challenge and began introducing himself, too. Swallowing a lump in his throat, he faced Sophia with a determined gesture. After that, he pointed to himself and said, "I'm Abanir." He repeated, "Abanir."

Abanir? His name's Abanir?!

Abanir said his name again, with a shaft of light coming out of his face.

"You are… Abanir?" Sophia asked, interested.

"Yes, I'm Abanir!" Abanir's enormous chest, heaved, in glee.

Sophia realized she had learned their names! She felt awestruck!

To keep it rolling, Rabel pointed to Sophia. "Your name?"

Right away, Sophia guessed that he was asking for her name. "I'm Sophia." Sophia pointed to herself. "Sophia," she repeated.

"Oh, Sophia!" Simultaneously, Abanir and Rabel reacted, in amusement.

Sophia simpered, perhaps carried away by the two's humor, as they spoke her name again and again.

As the moon brightened the dark shadows, Sophia could feel the growing chill of the forest, while she was still seated beside Abanir, inside the plain kubot. The shawl that still hung around her shoulders was not enough to warm her. She clutched her hands together and then hugged herself, awkwardly, in an attempt to warm herself.

Abanir saw it, sensing her need of warmth. Straight away, he made signs, for Sophia to come close to the fire, but the suggestion wasn't helpful. Imagining her slowly freezing to death, he volunteered to wrap his body around her, close enough, and that caused her some goose bumps.

"Oh, God!" Sophia spoke to herself quietly, fighting the escalating tension.

Controlling himself, he tightened his clasp, and that made Sophia's cheek press hard against his lean and broad torso. Yet finally, he was giving her the heat she longed for.

While her thoughts were in chaos, Sophia felt him more, as his wings suddenly flapped, and she looked at them.

With profound tenseness, Abanir hid his wings, flapping it down to the limit. He suddenly felt shy.

Sophia closely scrutinized him, over and over, until Abanir was completely subdued.

To abscond from getting more pushed to the edge, Abanir concentrated his eyes on Rabel who was now resting at the tree branches, nearby.

As they stood together before the fire, they watched its flames grow bigger, but Rabel suddenly broke out in a song:

Well, there is this shy yet brave Kravena;

A Kravena who never learned to smile;

But the night grows and the

moon shines on her face;

And his gloomy face turns bright;

As the owls chant, so is his heart;

Oh, what does this human have

that sweetened his bitter heart?

Oh lalalala lalalala!

"Rabel!" Abanir shouted, embarrassed, with his eyes blazing like the fire. Still, his warm body remained wrapped around Sophia.

Sophia gave the two an earnest smile, getting the hint that they were making fun of each other.

Rabel laughed out loud, turning Abanir's infuriation into something much worse.

Sophia tilted her head up, staring at Abanir, eye-to-eye. Then, she gradually brought up her hands to touch his back, bit by bit, until they reached the core of his wings.

It gave Abanir an electrical current that triggered his wings to spread to their utmost, and so magnificent was the sight, that he appeared like a god of beauty, to Sophia.

So splendid!

Now, mutual adoration rushed in between them and bonded them together.

"You saved my life," softly, Sophia spoke.

Vaguely, Abanir listened to her, trying to understand each word that came out of her tiny, bloodshot lips.

"You saved me not just once but twice," she whispered again, and leisurely laid her head on his chest, once more. "Thank you."

Abanir carefully rested his chin on her head and compressed her further.

Along with the flickers of the fire, another strong scent of dama-dama howled through the night, sending more quickening impulses to Sophia.

"It's dama-dama," Abanir said, facing Sophia again, to tell her of the flowering shrub. "Dama-dama," he repeated.

"Dama-dama," Sophia agreed, beaming.

The night carried on, and drowsiness now invited Sophia.

Abanir carefully led her back to the kubot and offered his chest as her pillow, until they both finally closed their eyes.

Chapter 27

Confuse Me Not

THE first light of the day shone vibrantly, at the forest.

Sophia woke up and found her face still leaning against Abanir's chest, as they both laid down inside the plain kubot.

But he was now fully awake.

"Hi," she greeted him as she smoothly leaned backwards.

Slanting a fresh look, Abanir unwrapped her and let her move.

Subsequently, Sophia stood up, and detected the return of her strength. She looked at her wounds and they were already healed.

Abanir also stood up and followed her every move.

She eyed everything around her, and was extraordinarily amazed by the beauty of Harem Falls at day. It was a paradise! There were bees, birds, dragonflies, and butterflies freely flying, with hums pleasurable to the ears. A celestial symphony! And there were various flowers nurturing around, completing all the colors of the rainbow. Their daylight scent was divine. It was as if she was hurled straight to heaven in a full blast.

"Wow!" she expressed as she initiated a step outside the kubot and approached the falling water.

Abanir ceaselessly smirked as he trailed her footpath. Such an amused grin of him was witnessed by her, and it brought her to a pause. Then, she began to sink her unwounded foot into the fresh water and indulged herself with its refreshing coldness.

Rabel was also awakened and joined them as Sophia explored more of the Shangri-La right before her eyes.

Subsequently, Abanir signed to Sophia to hold on to him, for he would ascend with her into the air.

Sophia went along with him.

In a flare, Abanir flew her around the vicinity of Harem Falls.

It was an incomparable experience for Sophia to be flying under the wings of a strange creature. And as her skin was embracing the gentle wind, she looked down. The shimmering waters of falls and the enchanting green forest were nothing but bravura, something out of this world. Gazing at Abanir, her admiration elevated.

In return, Abanir flew higher and faster.

It made Sophia scream, making her close her eyes in fear and excitement.

Laughing in excessive enchantment, Abanir decided to slow down the moment he felt her clasp had tightened.

They finally landed on a huge stone close to the falling water. Looking at Sophia, a white beautiful flower from behind her enthralled Abanir's eyes. Quickly, he picked it up and handed it to her saying, "Dama-dama… just like you. Pure as white… and exquisite."

Taken aback, Sophia accepted it and noticed its heart-shaped leaves and four elongated petals. Then, she breathed in with its sweet fragrance, and offered him her most grateful smile.

Not long after, Abanir looked at her passionately and started to sing his heart out.

In the sky so vast,

a weary soul flew alone;

Famished and parched

for a new path;

A new path to the

calmness of the wind.

For very long, these weak wings

were once broken;

Then there came you

and these wings can soar again.

Sophia could not understand his words but they sounded amazing. His voice was angelic and she did not want him to stop.

Abanir moved closer to her, his eyes constantly changing colors for another time.

Time and again, she was stunned.

Sophia quickly dropped her gaze. She was scared, scared to fall into his spell. *This is not right!* She hindered herself.

For Abanir, he never skipped any second to gawk at her.

Witnessing the burgeoning admiration the two shared, Rabel left them and returned quickly like a lightning was about to strike.

"Raha, I saw the Sulabuns heading to Kravena." Rabel shivered while informing his raha. "And they, with them, are the Fegratus."

Shocked by what he just heard, Abanir hastened to look at Sophia one more time and told her that he needed to take her to the place where he first saw her—the lake house—where she could be safe there.

Sophia could not understand him.

Though desperate to let her understand, Abanir immediately carried her and flew her away from Harem Falls, making the flower of dama-dama fall from Sophia's hands. He ordered Rabel to inform their tribe about the joined attack and that he would take Sophia first to the lake house.

Far away, Abanir could see the Sulabuns and the Fegratus at the Samo River. Faster, he flew to the lake house.

When they were almost there, Abanir saw people moving in and out of the lake house and decided to leave Sophia nearby, so that no one would see him.

Sophia also saw them, and assumed that they were looking for her.

Abanir hastily landed, took a passionate look at Sophia, and on the spur of the moment, kissed her steadfastly. He looked at Sophia once more and then flew away, in a blast of tempest wind.

Sophia was left blankly staring after his white beautiful wings. She lingered, until he was already hidden by the tall trees.

Then, the stride of a person coming from behind distracted her. She turned around and saw Jericho approaching.

Instantly, Jericho wrapped her up with his arms.

"Thank God! You're safe, Sophia!" Jericho held her for as long as he could.

Sophia's mind turned vague. Her emotions were worn out, into shreds.

Jericho! Abanir! And... Giovanni!

Seeing people at the lake house, Jericho directed Sophia there.

When Grandma Lucy, Philippe, and Elizabeth finally saw them, they ran to Sophia at high-speed. They grabbed her tightly while the cops started to arrest Jericho.

Jericho openly surrendered himself, but Grandma Lucy rushed to slap him in the face.

Philippe sprinted, to stop his mom.

Jericho looked down, entirely ashamed of himself, but never missed a stealing glance at Sophia.

Sophia saw what her grandma did to him, so she ran to his aid. But alas, the cops were already pushing him into the police car.

Through the hazy car windows, for the last time, Jericho bequeathed Sophia with a look of longing, as the police car sped away from her.

Watching him go, tears completely blinded Sophia's eyes now.

Her parents crept closer to her and embraced her, very much relieved that Sophia was with them now, safe and sound. They led Sophia inside their car, and as they left, Sophia found herself holding the white piece of cloth around her shoulders, while staring at the wild Forest of Evergreen.

Epilogue

Leaving the Fate Behind

THE Vabuerettis finally arrived at the town proper.

Getting Sophia inside her room, Elizabeth dampened a towel and quickly wiped it on her daughter's arms, going through a lot of dense emotions as Sophia remained docile, sitting on her bed.

Through the half-closed door, Philippe and Grandma Lucy watched the mother-daughter scene. They wanted to know what happened to Sophia in the woods, more particularly when they saw the wound-mark at Sophia's right foot.

"Hey." Philippe's voice unfocused Elizabeth. "How is she?"

Elizabeth was not able to answer him right away, absolutely drained and feeling out-of-herself.

Feeling the need to leave the two, Philippe then offered something. "I'll go and make chicken soup." He tried to smile.

Still standing outside Sophia's room, Grandma Lucy decided to join Elizabeth. The second she got closer to eyeing Sophia, the more she tried not to reflect all the objectionable things about her granddaughter's misconduct.

"Mom..." Elizabeth wanted to say something to her mother-in-law. "Mind if you continue cleaning up Sophia? I'll just look for a dress she could wear," she said, and went to Sophia's closets.

"Sure."

Elizabeth went through Sophia's old clothes and noticed the red dress, appearing like it was never worn. She reached for it, and a small card fell off the floor. It said,

> My dearest Sophia, on your 13th birthday,
>
> remember to smile. Wear this dress, and I
>
> will be there, with the moon, watching you.
>
> **- B.V.**

Elizabeth was suddenly beside herself with worry. *BV?* She mulled it over and looked at Grandma Lucy, her look questioning, hoping that Grandma Lucy knew something about it. Elizabeth only knew one person who had initials of *BV*, and it was Benjamin Vabueretti, Philippe's long-time missing brother and the Most Wanted Criminal charged with rape. Her heart cracked into fragments, speechless at the thought that the person who molested her sister, long ago, was actually out there, hiding somewhere close.

Her pondering was cut short when Sophia unexpectedly stood up and went straight to the bathroom, then wept and wept, as if for the last time. Jericho was now in prison and Abanir—it was his unexpected kiss that enormously troubled her.

How it all ached! Her heart was aching, not knowing what to do!

Then, she realized she wanted to see Jericho. After all, she was the reason why he was arrested. But in her mind, how could she ever see him, when everyone here was guarding her? Then, she decided to seek her father's help, and he was at the kitchen, cooking.

Philippe's worry intensified. His daughter was asking for his car key, and he found it hard to refuse.

"There are just two places where she'll want to go, either to the lake house or to the precinct!" intruded Grandma Lucy.

"No, she won't go to the lake house, nor to the precinct!" Elizabeth put in.

Sophia became deadly quiet. She wanted to see Jericho, but it seemed like there was no chance now. *I am betrayed by everyone!* She sobbed to herself silently. She could not bear to leave Forest Green knowing Jericho would be in jail.

Now, Grandma Lucy spoke again, "You have two choices, Sophia. First, if you insist in being with him, Jericho will be behind bars forever…"

Sophia's eyes clouded further, while hearing these words from her grandmother.

"And second, you can leave today, but I guarantee you, Jericho will be released from jail. But you have to promise me... that you will never... ever come back to him... again!" Grandma Lucy's voice was now at its utmost pitch.

Sophia, now on her feet, felt near-collapse. It was as if a lot of knives had stabbed her already-bleeding heart. Her agony worsened but she realized she must not be selfish. She wanted Jericho to continue his life, and she had no choice but to let him go.

"Fine," she answered in a spineless, quaking voice. "I will... leave... but you have to truly promise me that you will free him." More tears filled Sophia's eyes.

Grandma Lucy and Elizabeth were very much relieved, as if flaming chains had just been removed from their necks. Finally, Sophia would no longer be connected to the guy that disgusted them all, the most.

"At this very moment, I can call the precinct and withdraw my allegation against him. He could be freed, any time. I guarantee that, Sophia," Grandma Lucy reassured her.

When Sophia heard it, she went straight to the car without looking at them, making a sign that she was now ready to leave Forest Green.

As a result, Philippe and Elizabeth hastened their goodbyes to Grandma Lucy.

Grandma Lucy felt extremely sad about the things that happened, but she convinced herself that she did the right thing for her granddaughter.

It was almost sundown when the family finally left Forest Green.

In Kravena, Abanir bestowed his utmost strength to battle the united forces of the Sulabuns and the Fegratus. He had unleashed every command to his fellow Kravenas and struggled vigorously to win the battle, for his tribe and for the human he yearned to be with—Sophia.

The battle persisted heavily. The forces of the Kravenas were dominating, in spite of their smaller number. They craved—for so long—for a victory that would give justice to their fellow ones who sacrificed their lives for them.

Abanir unleashed every deadly arrow he had at his back and stabbed his bolo through and through, at every single foe—in his mind, to grant revenge for Karan.

After the very long battle, some of the Sulabuns and Fegratus were now fleeing. They were now losing the fight.

Abanir looked around thoroughly, hoping to see, at least, the wings of Banaak. He was dismayed. Banaak did not join the battle, not even his son Kalib.

After the enemies completely escaped their territory, Abanir checked on his family. He was very thankful; they were there, alive and well at the palasyon. Abanir still roamed around, searching for Rabel. Out of nowhere, suddenly, Rabel's voice was heard—coming from the trees, yelling that he was all right.

Abanir was somehow relieved that his dear hakaro was alive. Still, he continued securing their territory, speculating that some enemies might still be around.

Right after that, the other Kravenas began cleaning the place and lamented, for a few of them did not survive the battle.

Abanir, with an intense pounding in his chest, felt the need to see Sophia. He asked Rabel to watch the tribe for him, and then rushed to the lake house.

Landing there, he noticed its quietness, and to his extreme disappointment, there was no presence of Sophia there. In spite of that, he persisted and waited for the human he longed for—hoping, at least for a moment, that he could see her silhouette.

Ardently, he waited. Yet at the crack of dawn, not a thing stirred his senses. The sadness in him ruptured his heart. Desolately, he went back to Kravena—still, with the aching hope of seeing Sophia. Again.

Appendix A

Definition of Terms

Bandoryon. It is a group of musicians in Kravena.

Bunjao. He is a well-trained warrior.

Dama-dama. It is a flowering shrub that has a strong scent especially at night.

Datu. He is a tribe's leader.

Dulsabang. It is a box where Kravenas could put their belongings. It is made up of woven rattan.

Hakara. She is a servant of the tribe's leader and his family.

Hakaro. He is a servant of the tribe's leader and his family.

Hala-hala. It is a magical shrub in Kravena used in treating wounds.

Hayan. It is a candlestick of different aromatic herbs believed to send a relaxing effect to the nostrils.

Ila. It is how Vangkekans call their mother.

Ilo. It is how Vangkekans call their father.

Kansilo. He is a wise Kravena responsible in guiding the datu's decisions.

Kubot. It is a dwelling of the Kravenas; made up of bamboo walls and large dried grasses as rooftop.

Kul-pas. It is the female Vangkekans' bark-fiber skirt.

Lapey. It is a Vangkekan liquor, prepared from coconut.

Mang-aani. He/she is a tribe peasant responsible for planting sinapoy, the Vangkekans' staple food.

Ogbo Tree. It is a tree in Kravena that is believed to have a pain-relieving property.

Palasyon. It is the dwelling of a datu and his family. It is much larger than any kubot and it is located at the center of the tribe.

Pasindol. It is the Kravena Tribe's annual contest to spot the most excellent in archery.

Pluta. It is a musical instrument that sounds and looks like a flute.

Pugad. It is a hiding place of the Kravenas. It is located underground, covered with wild grasses. It has a secret way leading to the Samo River.

Raha. He is a datu's first son and successor.

Reyna. She is a datu's wife.

Sagigilid. He is a brave and skilled Vangkekan assigned by the tribe's leader to head the forces.

Sayang. It pertains to a sister.

Sayong. It pertains to a brother.

Sepe. He is a datu's son.

Sesa. She is a datu's daughter.

Sinapoy. It is a form of grain that is considered the staple food of Vangkekans. It is boiled along with various aromatic leaves to enhance its flavor.

Sukdalang. It is the datu's basket-work hat placed on the back of the head.

Surato. He/she is a trained Vangkekan in writing or carving inscriptions.

Taga-siklaw. He is assigned to investigate the tribe's anomalies.

Taga-sumalas. It is a group of dancers performing for every Vangkekan festivity.

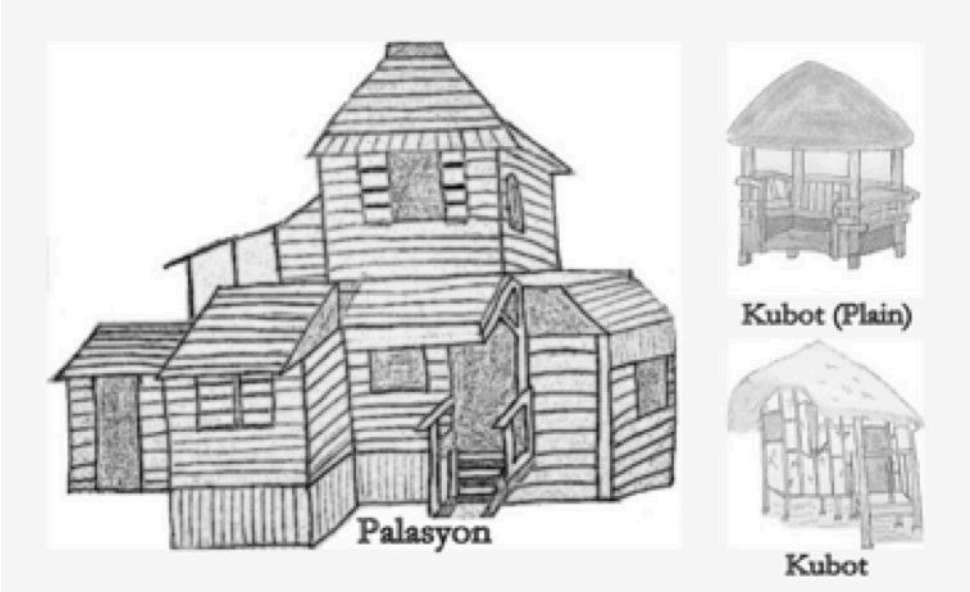
Tambuling. It is a musical instrument resembling a drum.

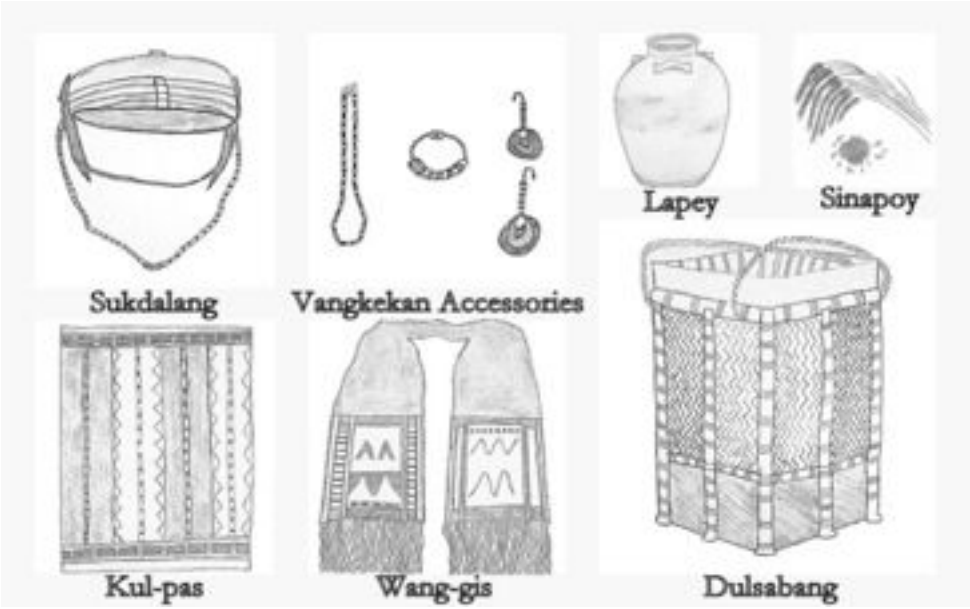
Ula-ula. It is a magical shrub (like hala-hala shrub) in Kravena, used for treating wounds.

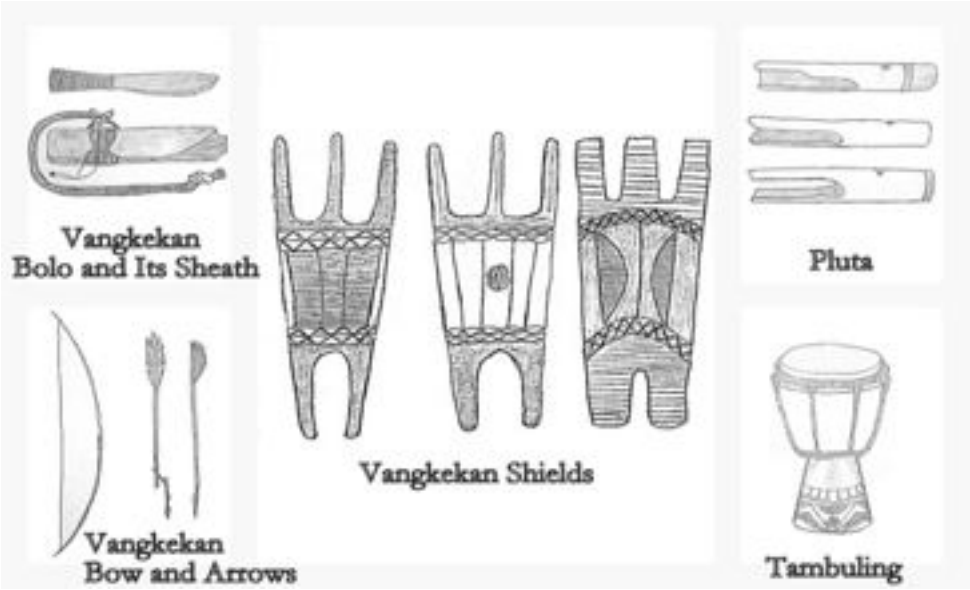
Wang-gis. It is the male Vangkekans' wide and thick breechcloth.

Appendix B

Illustrations






Vangkekan
Bolo and Its Sheath
Vangkekan Shields
Pluta
Vangkekan
Bow and Arrows
Tambuling

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Photo © Fritz and Maricor

Teresa May B. Bandiola is a licensed Filipino pharmacist. She is, presently, a lecturer at the College of Pharmacy of Our Lady of Fatima University in the Philippines. Concurrently, she is pursuing her master's degree at the Pontifical and Royal University of Santo Tomas.

The Forest of Evergreen: Lost in the Wilderness is her first book. Her idea of the story started when she was an eighteen-year-old sophomore in college, but she only began writing it four years later.

Today, she lives and writes in her beloved Philippines.

Stay in touch with the author via:

Facebook: **www.facebook.com/bandiolatere**

If you liked this book, please post a review at Amazon and Goodreads, and let your friends know about **The Forest of Evergreen** series.